THE THRESHOLD

Third Edition

GENERAL ENGLISH TEXT-CUM-WORKBOOK

Editors

JAGDIP SINGH • PRAVEEN KUMAR

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To our dear teachers who remain a continuous source of inspiration and strength

FOREWORD

The Threshold has been designed as a text-cum-workbook to enable the students to learn some grammar, partly based on the text, even as they read the prescribed poems, essays and short stories. After the first edition came out last year a need was felt to further improve the book by elaborating on a few things and by adding some more grammar exercises based on the text. Virtually every section of the book has been revised. The revision was undertaken by Mr. Balwant Kumar, Mr. Krishan Gopal, and Mr. Praveen Kumar who has also compiled the revised manuscript. Professor V.K. Khanna spared his valuable time to go through the entire manuscript, and offered crucial suggestions. I do hope the teachers and students find the revised edition more useful.

28 April 2003

PANKAJ K. SINGH
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Shimla

EDITORS' NOTE

The General English curriculum comprising communicative and functional English for students at the undergraduate level has been devised to help them attain a certain level of competence in listening, speaking, reading and writing English. The text-cum-workbook format that seeks to put together a selection of short stories, essays and poems with extensive exercises in grammar and comprehension is the first effort in this direction.

While preparing this book, every attempt has been made to achieve the desired objectives which include a shift of emphasis: (a) from cramming and mindless memorising to understanding and practical application of the language, and (b) from the study of literature to the use of language. The texts have been used as means of imparting language skills. Aspects of grammar have been presented in a simple manner with step by step exercises to strengthen students' functional knowledge of vocabulary, syntax and usage. To further reinforce the process whereby students learn the mechanism and intricacies of language effectively and naturally, we have also included in this course Raymond Murphy's *Intermediate English Grammar* which contains detailed additional exercises in grammar and comprehension. To improve speaking and listening skills, largely neglected so far, a modest attempt has been made to acquaint students with the sound system of the English language and word stress which are useful for achieving correct pronunciation and intelligibility in day-to-day conversation and communication. It is hoped that our efforts will find favour with both students and teachers.

Preparation of this book was assigned to both of us. Biographical details of the authors, critical comments on the texts and glossary have been contributed by Praveen Kumar and sections on grammar, vocabulary, usage, composition, etc., have been prepared by Jagdip Singh. We are grateful to Prof. V.K. Khanna, Department of English, Himachal Pradesh University Centre for Evening Studies, for his help, encouragement and guidance from time to time in the process of preparing this book. Principal Balwant Kumar (Retd.) deserves thanks for his insightful suggestions in preparing the points of grammar.

Prof. Pankaj K. Singh, Chairperson, Department of English, Himachal Pradesh University and Convener, Textbook Committee, merits all praise for her genuine interest in seeing the book finally through.

We would like to thank Prof. S.D. Sharma, Vice Chancellor, Himachal Pradesh University, and Prof. S.K. Gupta, former Vice Chancellor of

Himachal Pradesh University, for their guidance and help in the successful completion of this project. Thanks are also due to Dr O.P. Sharma, Director of Education, and Dr S.K. Dhawan, Joint Director of Education, Himachal Pradesh, Dr Yoginder Verma, Director, Academic Staff College, Himachal Pradesh University, and Prof. V.P. Sharma for providing valuable financial, administrative and academic support in holding the workshop in March 2001 to deliberate on and restructure syllabi for the teaching of English at the undergraduate level, and for their continuing assistance thereafter. And finally we would like to thank the experts and teachers of English from government and private colleges in Himachal Pradesh who deserve appreciation for their active participation in framing the present syllabi.

Suggestions for further improvement from the teachers and the students are always welcome.

Shimla

JAGDIP SINGH
PRAVEEN KUMAR

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Part I
SHORT STORIES

1

THE GIFT OF THE MAGI

O. Henry

William Sydney Porter (1862–1910), known in the literary world by the pseudonym O. Henry, was born in Greensboro, North Carolina. Having lost his mother while he was still in his early childhood, he was brought up by his grandmother and aunt. Later, he travelled to Texas to work on a sheep farm. His married life was troubled by the illness of his wife, with the early death of their first child adding to the woes of the couple. While working at the General Land Office, O. Henry used his spare time to draw caricatures of his colleagues and gained a reputation as a cartoonist. In 1894, he launched a weekly comic magazine, *The Rolling Stone*, which, however, collapsed within a year. A heart-broken O. Henry took up a job in a bank in Austin. But his bad luck continued to pursue him. As a result of some discrepancies in the financial accounts he maintained, he was tried for embezzlement. He fled the scene and went first to New Orleans and then to Mexico. He had to return to Texas in 1898, when he came to know about his wife's rapidly deteriorating health. He was caught, tried and imprisoned for three years in the Ohio Federal Penitentiary. His wife died soon afterwards.

In a show of exceptional fortitude, O. Henry made good use of his time in prison. His interaction with fellow inmates helped him gain insight into criminal minds. At the end of his prison term he moved to New York and reinvented himself as a serious writer. His release from jail also marked the beginning of a new identity for him in a rather literal sense. It was in an attempt to dissociate himself from his past that he took a pseudonym from one of the prison staff named, Orrin Henry and eventually came to be known in the world of letters as O. Henry.

O. Henry's stories are characterized by a keen eye for detail. If it was his habit of pacing the streets at night that constantly generated fresh ideas for story lines, it was his power of observation that brought his narratives alive. As he himself admits, 'I've got some of my best yarns from park benches, lamp posts and newspaper stands. . . . There are stories in everything.'

In recognition of his merits as a short story writer, an annual short story prize has been instituted in O. Henry's name in the USA.

Della and Jim, the relatively poor young couple in O. Henry's 'The Gift of the Magi' take enormous pride in their two separate possessions: Jim's gold watch and Della's long and beautiful hair. Both secretly wish to give each other presents that would enhance the magnificence of their prized

possessions. When Christmas, a traditional occasion for giving gifts arrives, both Della and Jim start to wonder as to what would be the most appropriate present to give to each other. Lacking enough money to buy a gift which is to her liking, Della decides to sell her dearly loved hair for twenty dollars. From the money that she gets, she purchases a platinum fob chain for Jim's gold watch. In a gesture that is equally moving and selfless, Jim sells his beloved gold watch in order to buy for Della a set of expensive combs which she has admired for a long time in a Broadway shop. As the plot unfolds, the couple realises that they have both lost the only two treasures which they possessed. But their initial sense of shock subsides as they gradually come to see that even though they are poorer in terms of material possessions that Christmas, they are the richer for the loss: their mutual sacrifice has served to confirm the strength of the love they have for each other. Jim and Della imbibe the true spirit of the Magi, the 'wise men' from whom the tradition of giving gifts at Christmas first began.

One dollar and eighty-seven cents. That was all. And sixty cents of it was in pennies. Pennies saved one and two at a time by bulldozing the grocer and the vegetable man and the butcher until one's cheeks burned with the silent imputation of parsimony that such close dealing implied. Three times Della counted it. One dollar and eighty-seven cents. And the next day would be Christmas.

There was clearly nothing left to do but flop down on the shabby little couch and howl. So Della did it. Which instigates the moral reflection that life is made up of sobs, sniffles, and smiles, with sniffles predominating.

While the mistress of the home is gradually subsiding from the first stage to the second, take a look at the home. A furnished flat at eight dollars per week. It did not exactly beggar description, but it certainly had that word on the lookout for the mendicancy squad.

In the vestibule below was a letter box into which no letter would go, and an electric button from which no mortal finger could coax a ring. Also appertaining thereunto was a card bearing the name 'Mr James Dillingham Young'

The 'Dillingham' had been flung to the breeze during a former period of prosperity when its possessor was being paid thirty dollars per week. Now, when the income was shrunk to twenty dollars, the letters of 'Dillingham' looked blurred, as though they were thinking seriously of contracting to a modest and unassuming D. But whenever Mr James Dillingham Young came home and reached his flat above he was called 'Jim' and greatly hugged by Mrs James Dillingham Young, already introduced to you as Della. Which is all very good.

Della finished her cry and attended to her cheeks with the powder rag. She stood by the window and looked out dully at a grey cat walking

a grey fence in a grey backyard. Tomorrow would be Christmas Day, and she had only one dollar and eighty-seven cents with which to buy Jim a present. She had been saving every penny she could for months, with this result. Twenty dollars a week doesn't go far. Expenses had been greater than she had calculated. They always are. Only one dollar and eighty-seven cents to buy a present for Jim. Her Jim. Many a happy hour she had spent planning for something nice for him. Something fine and rare and sterling—something just a little bit near to being worthy of the honour of being owned by Jim.

There was a pier glass between the windows of the room. Perhaps you have seen a pier glass in an eight-dollar flat. A very thin and very agile person may, by observing his reflection in a rapid sequence of longitudinal strips, obtain a fairly accurate conception of his looks. Della, being slender, had mastered the art.

Suddenly she whirled from the window and stood before the glass. Her eyes were shining brilliantly, but her face had lost its colour within twenty seconds. Rapidly she pulled down her hair and let it fall to its full length.

Now, there were two possessions of the James Dillingham Youngs in which they both took a mighty pride. One was Jim's gold watch that had been his father's and his grandfather's. The other was Della's hair. Had the Queen of Sheba lived in the flat across the air shaft, Della would have let her hair hang out of the window some day to dry just to depreciate Her Majesty's jewels and gifts. Had King Solomon been the janitor, with all his treasures piled up in the basement, Jim would have pulled out his watch every time he passed, just to see him pluck at his beard from envy.

So now Della's beautiful hair fell about her, rippling and shining like a cascade of brown waters. It reached below her knee and made itself almost a garment for her. And then she did it up again nervously and quickly. Once she faltered for a minute and stood still while a tear or two splashed on the worn red carpet.

On went her old brown jacket; on went her old brown hat. With a whirl of skirts and with the brilliant sparkle still in her eyes, she fluttered out of the door and down the stairs to the street.

Where she stopped the sign read: 'Mme. Sofronie, Hair Goods of All Kinds'. One flight up Della ran, and collected herself, panting. Madame, large, too white, chilly, hardly looked the 'Sofronie'.

'Will you buy my hair?' asked Della. 'I buy hair,' said Madame. 'Take yer hat off and let's have a sight at the looks of it.'

Down rippled the brown cascade.

'Twenty dollars,' said Madame, lifting the mass with a practiced hand.

'Give it to me quick,' said Della.

Oh, and the next two hours tripped by on rosy wings. Forget the hashed metaphor. She was ransacking the stores for Jim's present.

She found it at last. It surely had been made for Jim and no one else. There was no other like it in any of the stores, and she had turned all of them inside out. It was a platinum fob chain, simple and chaste in design, properly proclaiming its value by substance alone and not by meretricious ornamentation—as all good things should do. It was even worthy of The Watch. As soon as she saw it she knew that it must be Jim's. It was like him. Quietness and value—the description applied to both. Twenty-one dollars they took from her for it, and she hurried home with the eighty-seven cents. With that chain on his watch Jim might be properly anxious about the time in any company. Grand as the watch was, he sometimes looked at it on the sly on account of the old leather strap that he used in place of a chain.

When Della reached home her intoxication gave way a little to prudence and reason. She got out her curling irons and lighted the gas and went to work repairing the ravages made by generosity added to love. Which is always a tremendous task, dear friends—a mammoth task.

Within forty minutes her head was covered with tiny, close-lying curls that made her look wonderfully like a truant schoolboy. She looked at her reflection in the mirror long, carefully, and critically.

'If Jim doesn't kill me,' she said to herself, 'before he takes a second look at me, he'll say I look like a Coney Island chorus girl. But what could I do—oh! what could I do with a dollar and eighty-seven cents?'

At seven o'clock the coffee was made and the frying pan was on the back of the stove, hot and ready to cook the chops.

Jim was never late. Della doubled the fob chain in her hand and sat on the corner of the table near the door that he always entered. Then she heard his step on the stairway down on the first flight, and she turned white for just a moment. She had a habit of saying little silent prayers about the simplest everyday things, and now she whispered: 'Please, God, make him think I am still pretty.'

The door opened and Jim stepped in and closed it. He looked thin and very serious. Poor fellow, he was only twenty-two—and to be burdened with a family! He needed a new overcoat and he was without gloves.

Jim stopped inside the door, as immovable as a setter at the scent of quail. His eyes were fixed on Della, and there was an expression in them that she could not read, and it terrified her. It was not anger, nor surprise, nor disapproval, nor horror, not any of the sentiments that she had been prepared for. He simply stared at her fixedly with that peculiar expression on his face.

Della wriggled off the table and went for him.

'Jim, darling,' she cried, 'don't look at me that way. I had my hair cut off and sold it because I couldn't have lived through Christmas without giving you a present. It'll grow out again—you won't mind, will you? I just had to do it. My hair grows awfully fast. Merry Christmas, Jim, and let's be happy. You don't know what a nice—what a beautiful, nice gift I've got for you.'

'You've cut off your hair?' asked Jim, laboriously, as if he had not arrived at that patent fact yet even after the hardest mental labor.

'Cut it off and sold it,' said Della. 'Don't you like me just as well, anyhow? I'm me without my hair, ain't I?'

Jim looked about the room curiously.

'You say your hair is gone?' he said, with an air almost of idiocy.

'You needn't look for it,' said Della. 'It's sold. I tell you—sold and gone, too. It's Christmas Eve, boy. Be good to me, for it went for you. Maybe the hairs of my head were numbered,' she went on with a sudden serious sweetness, 'but nobody could ever count my love for you. Shall I put the chops on, Jim?'

Out of his trance Jim seemed quickly to wake. He enfolded his Della. For ten seconds let us regard with discreet scrutiny some inconsequential object in the other direction. Eight dollars a week or a million a year—what is the difference? A mathematician or a wit would give you the wrong answer. The Magi brought valuable gifts, but that was not among them. This dark assertion will be illuminated later on.

Jim drew a package from his overcoat pocket and threw it upon the table.

'Don't make any mistake, Dell,' he said, 'about me. I don't think there's anything in the way of a haircut or a shave or a shampoo that could make me like my girl any less. But if you'll unwrap that package you may see why you had me going awhile at first.'

White fingers and nimble tore at the string and paper. And then an ecstatic scream of joy; and then—alas!—a quick feminine charge to hysterical tears and wails, necessitating the immediate employment of all the comforting powers of the lord of the flat.

For there lay The Combs—the set of combs, side and back, that Della had worshipped for long in a Broadway window. Beautiful combs, pure tortoiseshell, with jeweled rims—just the shade to wear in the beautiful vanished hair. They were expensive combs, she knew, and her heart had simply craved and yearned over them without the least hope of possession. And now, they were hers, but the tresses that should have adorned the coveted adornments were gone.

But she hugged them to her bosom, and at length she was able to look up with dim eyes and a smile and say: 'My hair grows so fast, Jim!'

And then Della leaped up like a little singed cat and cried, 'Oh, oh!'

Jim had not yet seen his beautiful present. She held it out to him eagerly upon her open palm. The dull precious metal seemed to flash with a reflection of her bright and ardent spirit.

'Isn't it a dandy, Jim? I hunted all over town to find it. You'll have to look at the time a hundred times a day now. Give me your watch. I want to see how it looks on it.'

Instead of obeying, Jim tumbled down on the couch and put his hands under the back of his head and smiled.

'Dell,' said he, 'let's put our Christmas presents away and keep'em awhile. They're too nice to use just at present. I sold the watch to get the money to buy your combs. And now suppose you put the chops on.'

The Magi, as you know, were wise men—wonderfully wise men—who brought gifts to the Babe in the manger. They invented the art of giving Christmas presents. Being wise, their gifts were no doubt wise ones, possibly bearing the privilege of exchange in case of duplication. And here I have lamely related to you the uneventful chronicle of two foolish children in a flat who most unwisely sacrificed for each other the greatest treasures of their house. But in a last word to the wise of these days let it be said that of all who give gifts these two were the wisest. Of all who give and receive gifts, such as they are wisest. Everywhere they are wisest. They are the Magi.

NOTES

When we speak English not all syllables in a word are equally prominent; some syllables are 'louder' or 'more prominent'. These are said to be stressed. The main stress in a word is shown as a raised vertical bar (') before the syllable. (English speech sounds and word stress are discussed later in this book.)

the Magi	:	the three wise men from the East who brought gifts to the infant Christ
'bulldozing	:	bullying
ˌimpu'tation	:	accusation
'parsimony	:	excessive carefulness in spending money, miserliness
sniffle	:	act of breathing noisily, especially when one has a cold or one has been crying
beggar description	:	impossible to describe, be too extraordinary to describe adequately
vestibule	:	lobby or entrance hall
mendicancy squad	:	those who make their living by begging, e.g. *bhikshus*
coax a ring	:	make (the bell) ring by patient effort
ˌapper'taining	:	belonging, affixed
'pier glass	:	tall mirror
'agile	:	active
Queen of Sheba	:	famous queen who visited Solomon and gave him many expensive gifts

Solomon	:	King of Israel in the Old Testament regarded as the wisest of men. His court was noted for its riches.
'janitor	:	caretaker of a building
cas'cade	:	a small waterfall
Mme	:	abbreviation for Madame (French)
hash	:	cut up into small pieces, (fig.) to do something very badly, to make a mess of it
'metaphor	:	A figure of speech involving comparison in which one thing represents or symbolises another. The expression 'two hours tripped by on rosy wings' is described as a 'hashed metaphor' because it uses two very different images at once to describe the passage of time: walking ('tripped by') and flying ('on rosy wings') like a butterfly
'ransack	:	search a place thoroughly
fob chain	:	chain attached to a watch carried in a fob or small pocket in the waistband of trousers
ˌmere'tricious	:	superficially attractive
on the sly	:	secretly
the ravages	:	damage done by something
a mammoth task	:	a big task
Coney Island	:	amusement centre on Long Island in New York
setter	:	a dog trained to be motionless at the scent of a bird or an animal to be hunted
assertion	:	a strong statement or claim (The assertion is described as dark because its full implications are revealed a little later in the story).
going awhile	:	refers to Jim's reaction on seeing Della after her hair cut. He appears to have briefly lost his senses
ec'static	:	full of great joy
lord of the flat	:	refers to Jim
'Broadway	:	an important street in New York famous for its theatres
'tresses	:	long hair, especially of a woman
like a singed cat	:	like a burnt cat, i.e. suddenly
'dandy	:	(informal, especially US) excellent
Babe in the manger	:	The infant Christ, who was put in the manger soon after he was born in the stable of an inn at Bethlehem in Jerusalem. The gifts brought to him by the Magi were 'gold and frankincense and myrrh' (St Matthew) which could not have been of any immediate use to the newly-born infant but which showed the great love and regard of the Magi, who indeed were wise men because when they saw a new star moving in the sky they recognized it as an indication of the birth of a great soul. They were also able to infer that the direction of the star's movement indicated where the great soul was to be born. The Magi then followed the star to Bethlehem where it stopped.

COMPREHENSION

1. What were Jim and Della's most precious possessions?
2. 'Down rippled the brown cascade.' Which cascade is being referred to in this line?
3. For how much money did Della sell her hair?
4. What was the price of the platinum fob chain?
5. Earlier, Jim used to look at his gold watch on the sly. Why?
6. What prayer did Della utter when she heard Jim's footsteps on the stairway?
7. What was Jim's reaction on seeing Della after the haircut?
8. Why did Della start weeping after unwrapping the package brought by Jim?

COMPOSITION

1. Describe the scene in which Jim and Della show their gifts to each other.
2. 'Let's put our Christmas presents away and keep'em awhile. They're too nice to use just at present,' said Jim. Why?
3. Discuss the surprise ending of the story.
4. Discuss the significance of the title 'The Gift of the Magi'.
5. Narrate the story in your own words.

Exercise 1

Punctuate the following sentences (See detailed description of *punctuation* in Chapter 18):

1. and the next day would be christmas
2. only one dollar and eighty-seven cents to buy a present for jim
3. a very thin and very agile person may by observing his reflection in a rapid sequence of longitudinal strips obtain a fairly accurate conception of his looks
4. one was jims gold watch that had been his fathers and his grandfathers
5. will you buy my hair asked della
6. oh and the next two hours tripped by on rosy wings
7. quietness and value the description applied to both
8. she looked at her reflection in the mirror long carefully and critically
9. she whispered please god make him think I am still pretty
10. itll grow out again – you wont mind will you

USING YOUR DICTIONARY

A good dictionary is a very useful tool in the learning of any language and gives us not only the meanings of words but also their correct pronunciation, their grammatical category, the compounds that can be formed with the root word and a great deal of other information. Let us see how a dictionary functions.

The words in a dictionary are arranged alphabetically. Each entry gives, first, the correct pronunciation (including stress) in phonetic transcription, i.e. in symbols devised by the International Phonetic Association so that each sound in the language is represented by a different symbol. Usually, the phonetic symbols used in a dictionary and their pronunciation are given either at the beginning of the dictionary or at the bottom of each page in the main section so that one does not have to learn the symbols by heart to be able to use the dictionary correctly. If there is a difference in the British and American pronunciations of a word the dictionary will also indicate this, usually by mentioning *BrE/AmE* just before the phonetic transcription.

The grammatical category of the word is indicated by abbreviations like *n* (for noun), C (for countable noun), U (for uncountable noun), *adj* (for adjective) and *v.tr.* (for verb transitive). If the plural of the nouns listed in the dictionary are not formed in the usual manner, i.e. by adding an 's' or 'es' to the root word, this will also be indicated within brackets. For example, the entry for man will give (*pl* men/men/) immediately after the grammatical category. Similarly, irregular past tense and past participle forms of verbs are also given.

If a word has more than one meaning, each meaning will be numbered, with the commonest meaning being given first and the rarest being given last. (Meanings of common abbreviations are also provided.)

After this, phrasal verbs and idiomatic expressions which use the head word are listed together with their meanings.

This is followed by a listing of compound words and derivatives (made by adding suffixes). Good dictionaries also provide hints on correct usage and warn us against commonly made errors. They also indicate whether a word is formal, informal, colloquial, slang, offensive or taboo.

Some specialised dictionaries also provide synonyms (words similar in meaning), antonyms (words opposite in meaning), and the etymology or information on the origin of the word.

Exercise 1

(a) Find out the variant spellings (British/American) of the following words.

labour	programme	colour	travelled	organize
burnt	patronize	odour	localize	handkerchiefs

(b) How many meanings of the following words does your dictionary list?

trunk	approach	cross	form
lift	brief	sentence	principal

(c) How many new words can be made from the following by adding suffixes?

value	teach	meaning	norm
think	fix	profit	make
read	form	use	active

(d) Make compound words by adding other words to the following:

hand	house	book	order
market	grand	drive	hard
absent	self	left	alarm

(e) Make phrasal verbs from the following:

give let bring put cut look

(f) Expand the following abbreviations to their full forms:

MP	etc.	BBC	AD
USA	wpm	e.g.	a.m.
YMCA			

(g) Find out the word stress in the following words and mark the same at appropriate places (in ordinary spelling). [Read the section 'Word Stress' in this book before attempting this exercise.]

English	admit	refer	academic
British	become	pretend	biology
account	information	eighteen	recover

GRAMMAR

ACTIVE AND PASSIVE VOICE

1. Voice is that property of the verb which shows whether the grammatical subject of a sentence is doing an action or is being acted upon. Thus, a transitive verb has two voices – the Active Voice and the Passive Voice.

   A verb is said to be in the Active Voice when the person or thing denoted by the subject acts or is active.

   A verb is said to be in the Passive Voice when the person or thing denoted by the subject does not act, but is acted upon by something or someone.
2. Only those sentences in Active Voice can be changed into Passive Voice which have *transitive verbs*, because the object of Active sentence becomes the subject in Passive Voice. Since an intransitive verb has no object, an Active Voice sentence with an intransitive verb cannot be changed into Passive Voice. Look at the following sentences:
   (i) My father wrote a letter. (Here 'wrote' is a transitive verb because it has an object 'a letter'.)
   (ii) My horse ran fast. (Here 'ran' is an intransitive verb because it has no object.)
3. (i) When changing a sentence from Active Voice to Passive Voice, the object of Active Voice sentence becomes the subject of the sentence in Passive Voice. If the Active sentence has two objects, either of these can become the subject in Passive Voice; however, if one of them refers to a person and the other to a thing, then usually the object referring to a person (indirect object) is made the subject in Passive Voice.
   (ii) The helping verb 'be' is added in the same tense in which the main verb was used in the Active sentence; and with that is used the third form (past participle) of the main verb.
   (iii) Passive Voice usually omits the agent who performs the action indicated by the main verb. When the agent is mentioned in Passive, the preposition 'by' is generally used before the agent if the verb indicates activity.
   (iv) Sometimes, especially when the grammatical subject of the Active sentences is a lifeless thing, or when the main verb does not indicate any activity, prepositions other than 'by' are used in the Passive Voice, keeping in view the suitability, for example, *with*, *in*, *to*, etc.
   The following sentences illustrate this:
   The room was filled <u>with</u> smoke.
   Milk is contained <u>in</u> this pot.
   He is known <u>to</u> me.
4. Sometimes verbs have prepositions attached to them which must go along with the verbs in the Passive Voice, e.g.
   Active Voice: He objected to my proposal.
   Passive Voice: My proposal was objected <u>to</u> by him.
5. Sometimes, the change of voice is effected only through the change of voice in the infinitive (that is, infinitive 'be' plus third form of the Active Verb), e.g.
   Active Voice: It is time <u>to take</u> tea.
   Passive Voice: It is time for tea <u>to be taken</u>.
6. If in Passive Voice the agent (or doer of action) is implied and not expressed, the implied or likely agent is added as subject while changing the sentence into Active Voice.
   Passive Voice: The ship was wrecked.
   Active Voice: The tempest wrecked the ship.
   Passive Voice: It is said that . . . .
   Active Voice: They say that . . .
7. In imperative sentences, the word <u>let</u> is added in the Passive Voice followed by the infinitive 'be' and third form of the main verb, e.g.
   Active Voice: Open the door.
   Passive Voice: Let the door be opened.
   However, when the Active imperative sentence begins with 'please' or 'kindly', the Passive is commonly formed with 'You are requested to' followed by the infinitive of the main verb (the form of the main verb remaining unchanged in this particular case), e.g.
   Active Voice: Please <u>help</u> me.
   Passive Voice: You <u>are requested to help</u> me.

NARRATION
(Direct and Indirect Speech)

1. There are two different ways in which a speaker's words can be conveyed:
   (a) by repeating the actual words used by the speaker (Direct Speech)
   (b) by giving the same version of his speech without giving his exact words (Indirect Speech)
2. Direct Speech has two important parts: the *Reporting Verb* outside the inverted commas, and the *Reported Speech* within the inverted commas.
3. While changing the form of narration, the tense of the Reporting Verb is not changed.
4. The tense of the Reported Speech is not changed in the following cases:
   (i) When the Reporting Verb is in the present or future tense.
   (ii) When there is a universal truth, historical event or habitual fact in the Reported Speech.
5. When the Reporting Verb is in past tense, and there is no universal truth, historical event or habitual fact within the quotation marks, the tense of the Reported Speech is changed as under:
   (i) The present tense is changed to its corresponding past form.
   (ii) The simple past is changed to the past perfect.
   (iii) The past continuous is changed to the past perfect continuous.
   (iv) The past perfect and the past perfect continuous tenses remain unchanged.
6. The First Person pronouns in the Reported Speech change to the Person of the subject of the Reporting Verb (who spoke the words) and the Second Person pronouns change to the Person of the object to whom the words inside the inverted commas were spoken. The Third Person pronouns do not change at all.
7. In changing Direct Speech into Indirect Speech, words denoting nearness in time and place are generally changed into those indicating distance. For example, *here* is changed into *there*, *this* into *that*, *now* into *then*, *tomorrow* into the *next day*, *yesterday* into the *previous day*, etc.
8. In changing statements from Direct into Indirect Speech, the Reporting Verb *said* is often changed into *told*, *informed*, *answered*, *replied*, etc. (Note there will be an object after *told* and *informed*). The comma after the Reporting Verb, and the quotation marks are removed and the conjunction *that* is used to connect the Reported Speech with the Reporting Verb.
9. *Note:* In the Indirect Speech only the sentence structure of statements can be used, so questions, exclamations, orders, requests, etc., all have to be recast in the structure of statements.
10. In converting interrogative sentences,
    (i) The Reporting Verb is changed into *asked, enquired, demanded,* etc. (an object has to be there after *ask*).

    (ii) If the question begins with *what, why, when, where, who, whose, whom, how,* etc., no separate conjunction is required to introduce the Reported Speech.
    (iii) If the question begins with a verb, use *if* or *whether* as connecting word.
    (iv) The interrogative form is changed into that of a statement and the question mark is removed. While in a direct question the helping verb comes before the subject, in reporting a question in the form of a statement the verb is placed after the subject.
11. In converting imperative sentences,
    (i) The Reporting Verb is changed into *ordered, advised, requested, commanded, forbade,* etc. (followed by an object).
    (ii) The verb in the Reported Speech is changed into an infinitive.
    (iii) No conjunction is generally used to introduce the Reported Speech.
    (iv) In sentences beginning with *let*, the Reporting Verb is changed into *proposed* or *suggested* followed by *that* and *should*. If *let* denotes permission, it is changed into *might be allowed* or simply into the infinitive.
12. In converting the sentences expressing a wish, etc. (e.g. 'May you live long!' 'If only he were here today!') the Reporting Verb is changed into *wished, prayed,* etc. and *that* is used to introduce the Reported Speech whose structure is changed to that of a statement.
13. In converting exclamatory sentences,
    (i) The exclamatory form is changed into that of a statement.
    (ii) All interjections are removed and their sense is conveyed by changing the Reporting Verb into phrases like *exclaimed with joy/ sorrow, confessed with regret, applauded, remarked,* etc. (an object has to be there after *applaud*).
    (iii) The conjunction *that* is used to introduce the Reported Speech.
14. In changing the form of narration from Indirect to Direct Speech, there is a reversal of the process mentioned in these rules.

Exercise 1

Change the *voice*:
1. Three times Della counted it.
2. Perhaps you have seen a pier glass in an eight-dollar flat.
3. She found it at last.
4. This dark assertion will be illuminated later on.
5. Jim had not yet seen his beautiful present.

Exercise 2

Change the *narration*:
1. "Will you buy my hair?" asked Della.
2. "Give it to me quick," said Della.

3. "You've cut off your hair?" asked Jim.
4. "Cut it off and sold it," said Della.
5. "Don't make any mistake, Dell," he said, "about me."

2

A DUEL

Guy de Maupassant

Guy de Maupassant (1850–93) was born in Normandy, France. His parents separated when he was still young and Maupassant stayed on with his mother, who was a friend of the great French novelist, Gustave Flaubert. Young Maupassant did not show a particularly creative spark in his early life, but the rich, even if somewhat unusual, experiences of this period provided him with enough raw material upon which he could draw when his literary talents became manifest.

Maupassant was initially inclined towards poetry, but Flaubert persuaded him to try his hand at fiction. He spent several years coaching the younger author in the art of writing, and perhaps even more significantly, in the art of observation. In a statement that lays down the significance of employing fresh perspectives, Flaubert claims: 'There is a part of everything which is unexplored, because we are accustomed to using our eyes only in association with the memory of what people before us have thought of the thing we are looking at. Even the smallest thing has something in it which is unknown. We must find it.' Flaubert also encouraged Maupassant to search for exact words rather than approximations, and dissuaded him from taking 'recourse to verbal sleight-of-hand to avoid a difficulty'.

As a young man, Maupassant was lively and athletic, but in his late twenties he contracted an infectious disease that undermined not just his physical health but also his mental stability. By 1889 it was obvious to his friends that he was losing his mind. In 1891 Maupassant attempted suicide and was thereafter confined to an asylum in Paris, where he died two years later.

Three of Maupassant's novels—*A Woman's Life, Bel-Ami* and *Pierre and Jean*—have earned critical acclaim, but his genius lies in short story, a genre he took to great heights. From the beauties of the countryside to the cunning and greed of Norman peasantry, from the Franco-Prussian War to issues of adultery and prostitution, Maupassant's stories deal with many themes.

The story is set in France during the German occupation. German soldiers miss no opportunity of humiliating the French people. The story begins with a chance encounter between a Prussian officer and a pot-bellied Frenchman, Monsieur Dubuis. Acting on the assumption that no Frenchman would dare to defy his orders, howsoever humiliating, the officer orders the Frenchman to fetch him some tobacco. When his initial attempts to avoid the Prussian are unsuccessful, Monsieur Dubuis loses patience and punches him in the face

and the officer starts to bleed. Feeling humiliated at having been mauled by a Frenchman, the officer challenges him to a duel in which the odds seem to be heavily against Monsieur Dubuis, but as it turns out, it is the German who gets killed in the end.

The story clearly shows the plight of the people of a subjugated nation and the humiliations they have to suffer at the hands of the victors. Faced with a humiliating situation Monsieur Dubuis emerges as a symbol of patriotic fervour and self-respect. When provoked he shows restraint and avoids confrontation, but the outrageous conduct of the Prussian officer finally exhausts his patience. Unable to compromise his dignity any further, he throws all caution to winds and expresses his repressed anger in a violent manner, even if he stands exposed to possibilities of yet more demeaning atrocities. The story also shows the senselessness of the tradition of duelling as a means of settling a point of honour.

The war was over. The Germans had occupied France, and the country lay quivering like a defeated wrestler under his opponent's knee.

The first trains from the famished, suffering, despairing capital were making their way to the new frontiers, crawling across the countryside and through the villages. The first travellers were looking out of the windows at the ravaged plains and burnt-out hamlets. At the door of every house that was still standing, Prussian soldiers in black helmets with brass spikes were sitting astride chairs, smoking their pipes. Others were chatting or doing odd jobs as if they were members of a family. Whenever a train passed through a town the passengers could see whole regiments drilling in the main square, and in spite of the rumble of the wheels hoarse words of command could be heard now and then.

Monsieur Dubuis, who had served in the National Guard throughout the siege of Paris, was on his way to Switzerland to join his wife and daughter, whom he had prudently sent abroad before the invasion.

Neither hunger nor hardship had reduced his pot belly, the belly of a well-to-do, peace-loving tradesman. He had endured the terrible events of the past few months with sorrowful resignation and bitter comments on the inhumanity of man. Although he had done his duty on the ramparts and had mounted guard on many a cold night, it was only now, when the war was over and he was approaching the frontier, that he caught his first sight of some Prussians.

He stared with mingled fear and irritation at these armed and bearded foreigners who had made themselves at home on the soil of France, and he felt in his heart a sort of fever of helpless patriotism and at the same time that instinct of self-preservation, that newly acquired sense of prudence which has never left us since.

In the same compartment were two Englishmen who had come to France as sightseers, and who looked at everything with calm, inquisitive eyes. They were both very stout too, and chatted together in their own language, occasionally referring to their guidebook and reading out extracts aloud while trying to identify the places mentioned.

The train stopped at the station of a little town and suddenly a Prussian officer climbed the two steps into the carriage, with a great clanking of his sword. He was a tall man, dressed in a tight-fitting uniform, with a flaming red beard up to his eyes. His face was cut in half by a pair of long mustachios, paler in colour, which stuck out on either side.

The Englishmen promptly began examining him with smiles of gratified curiosity, while Monsieur Dubuis pretended to be reading a newspaper. He sat huddled in his corner, like a thief faced with a policeman.

The train moved off again. The Englishmen went on chatting and looking for the exact positions of different battles. All of a sudden, as one of them was pointing to a village on the horizon, the Prussian officer stretched out his long legs, leaned back in his seat, and said in very Teutonic French: 'I killed twelve Frenchmen in that village. I took over one hundred prisoners.'

The Englishmen's interest was immediately aroused, and they asked: 'Oh, really? What was the name of the village?'

'Pharsbourg,' replied the Prussian.

He went on: 'I took those French rogues by the ears.'

And he looked at Monsieur Dubuis, laughing proudly in his whiskers.

The train crawled on, passing through more and more occupied hamlets. German soldiers could be seen on the roads, on the outskirts of meadows, standing by gates or chatting outside cafes. They covered the earth like African locusts.

The officer stretched out his hand.

'If I had been in command, I would have taken Paris, burned everything, killed everybody. No more France!'

Out of politeness the Englishmen replied simply: 'Oh, really?'

He went on: 'In another twenty years the whole of Europe, every bit of it, will belong to us. Prussia is stronger than all the rest.'

The Englishmen, feeling a little uneasy, made no further reply. Their faces had become expressionless and looked like wax masks between their long sidewhiskers. Then the Prussian officer burst out laughing. Still lying back in his seat, he sneered at France, insulted the prostrate foe. He sneered at Austria, defeated a few years before. He sneered at the fierce but futile defence put up by the provinces, at the French

militia, at the ineffectual artillery. He declared that Bismarck was going to build a city of iron with the captured guns. And suddenly he pushed his boots up against the thigh of Monsieur Dubuis, who flushed to the roots of his hair and looked away.

The Englishmen seemed to have become oblivious to everything, as if they had suddenly found themselves shut up within the confines of their island, far from the din and clamour of the world.

The officer took out his pipe, and, looking straight at the Frenchman, said: 'Have you any tobacco on you?'

'No, Monsieur,' replied Monsieur Dubuis.

The German went on: 'Then go and buy some when the train stops.'

He added with a laugh: 'I'll give you a tip.'

The train whistled and slowed down. It passed the burnt out buildings of a station and came to a stop.

The German opened the door and took Monsieur Dubuis by the arm.

'Go and do what I told you,' he said, 'and be quick about it.'

The station was occupied by a detachment of Prussian troops. More soldiers were standing behind the wooden barriers looking on. Monsieur Dubuis jumped down on the platform, and, despite the gesticulations of the stationmaster, clambered into the next compartment.

He was alone! His heart was pounding so wildly that he had to unbutton his waistcoat. He mopped his forehead, panting for breath. The train stopped again at another station. Suddenly the officer appeared at the door and entered the compartment, followed by the two Englishmen, who were actuated by curiosity. The German sat down opposite the Frenchman and, still laughing, said: 'So you refused to do as I told you?'

'Yes, Monsieur,' replied Monsieur Dubuis.

The train moved off again.

'I'll cut off your moustache,' said the officer, 'to fill my pipe.'

And he stretched out his hand towards the Frenchman's face.

The Englishmen, as impassive as ever, watched intently.

The German had already caught hold of the moustache and was pulling at it when Monsieur Dubuis struck up his arm with the back of his hand and, seizing him by the collar, flung him down on the seat. Then, mad with rage, his temples swollen and his eyes suffused with blood, throttling the Prussian with one hand, he started punching him furiously in the face with the other. The Prussian struggled wildly, trying to draw his sword and to get a grip on his adversary, who was lying right on top of him. But Monsieur Dubuis pinned him down with the huge bulk of his belly and went on punching him, without pausing to draw breath and without knowing where his blows were

falling. Blood flowed freely while the German, choking and gasping for breath, spat out broken teeth and struggled in vain to shake off the infuriated fat man who was pummelling him.

The Englishmen had stood up and drawn nearer to get a better view. They stood watching, full of delighted curiosity, ready to lay a bet on one or other of the combatants.

Then, all of a sudden, exhausted by his exertions, Monsieur Dubuis stood up and resumed his seat without saying a word.

The Prussian was too astounded, too numb with astonishment and pain, to fling himself upon his adversary. When he had got his breath back he said: 'Either you give me satisfaction in a pistol duel or I shall kill you.'

Monsieur Dubuis replied: 'Whenever you wish.'

'We are just coming into Strasbourg,' the German continued. 'I will find two other officers to be my seconds. There will be just enough time before the train leaves again.'

Monsieur Dubuis, who was puffing as hard as the engine, said to the Englishmen: 'Will you act as my seconds?'

They both replied at the same time: 'Oh, yes!'

And the train stopped.

In less than a minute the Prussian had found two brother officers who fetched a pair of pistols, and they all set off for the ramparts.

The Englishmen, worried in case they should miss the train, kept pulling out their watches, quickening their pace, speeding up the preparations.

Monsieur Dubuis had never held a pistol in his life. He was positioned twenty paces from his opponent. Then he was asked: 'Are you ready?'

As he was replying, 'Yes, Monsieur,' he noticed that one of the Englishmen had opened his umbrella to protect himself from the sun.

A voice gave the word of command.

'Fire!'

Monsieur Dubuis fired straight away, without waiting to take aim, and was amazed to see the Prussian standing in front of him stagger, throw up his arms, and fall forward on his face. He had killed him.

'Oh, I say!' exclaimed one of the Englishmen, in a voice quivering with delight, gratified curiosity and joyful impatience. His companion, who still had his watch in his hand, seized Monsieur Dubuis by the arm and hurried him off at a run in the direction of the station.

The first Englishman marked time as he ran along, his fists clenched and his elbows tucked into his sides.

'One, two, one, two.'

All three trotted along in line, regardless of their paunches, like three grotesque figures in a comic paper.

The train was just moving off. They jumped into their carriage. The Englishmen took off their travelling caps, waved them in the air, and shouted three times: 'Hip, hip, hooray!'

Then, one after the other, they solemnly shook hands with Monsieur Dubuis and sat down again side by side in their corner of the compartment.

NOTES

the war	:	the story refers to the Franco-Prussian War (1870-71) in which France was humbled. The war ended with the fall of Paris on 28 February 1871. Later, the Treaty of Frankfurt was signed in May 1871 under which France ceded Alsace and Lorrain to Prussia and had to pay heavy war indemnity. German army was to occupy France till indemnity was paid.
'famished	:	very hungry
'Prussian	:	belonging to Prussia, a former North European state, which remained a kingdom in the German Empire from 1871 until Germany became a republic in 1918. Prussia was abolished as a state in 1947 and divided among West Germany, East Germany, the U.S.S.R. and Poland
Mon'sieur	:	(French) Mr, sir, gentleman—title used before the name of a man or used alone as a formal and polite term of address (for pronunciation look the word up in a dictionary)
National Guard	:	an armed force that took part in the French Revolution, first formed in 1789
siege	:	the surrounding of a town, fortress, etc., by armed forces
'ramparts	:	defensive wall around a fort, etc., consisting of a wide bank of earth with a path for walking along the top
'prudence	:	carefulness in conduct, discretion
in'quisitive	:	curious
Teutonic French	:	French spoken with a German accent
'prostrate	:	lying on the ground, face downward, showing submission
'Bismarck	:	Otto von Bismarck (1815–98) a German statesman (known as 'the Iron Chancellor')
ob'livious	:	forgetful or unaware of something
de'tachment	:	a group of soldiers who are separated from the main group in order to perform a particular duty
ˌgesticu'lations	:	using gestures (movement of hands, etc.) while speaking

'clamber	:	climb with difficulty
'actuated	:	activated, motivated
im'passive	:	emotionless
in'tently	:	with eager interest and concentration
suf'fuse	:	spread slowly over the surface of something
eyes suffused with blood	:	eyes looking red with anger
'throttle	:	to try to kill someone by squeezing their throat in order to stop them from breathing
in'furiated	:	made extremely angry
'pummel	:	beat somebody repeatedly with fists
as'tound	:	overcome with surprise or shock
'second	:	a second is a person whose role is to help and support somebody taking part in a boxing match or, in the past, in a duel
tuck	:	draw (something) together into a small space
paunch	:	fat belly
gro'tesque	:	comically distorted, laughable

COMPREHENSION

1. What sight did France present immediately after the Prussian occupation?
2. Where had Monsieur Dubuis served during the siege of Paris?
3. How did Monsieur Dubuis look at the Prussian soldiers?
4. Why had the two Englishmen come to France?
5. In the beginning the two Englishmen were quite keen to know about the Prussian officer's exploits in the war. Shortly afterwards, they lost all interest because the officer said something not to their liking. What was it?
6. What did the Frenchman do when he was asked to go and buy tobacco?
7. How did the Frenchman react when the German pulled at his moustache?
8. Why did the German challenge the Frenchman to a duel?

COMPOSITION

1. In what ways was Monsieur Dubuis humiliated by the Prussian officer before he lost his patience?
2. Describe the sequence of events which led to the duel.
3. Describe the behaviour of the Englishmen during the entire episode.
4. Narrate the story in your own words.
5. Draw a character sketch of the Prussian officer.
6. Draw a character sketch of Monsieur Dubuis.

Exercise 1

Punctuate the following sentences:

1. neither hunger nor hardship had reduced his pot belly the belly of a well to do peace loving tradesman
2. he was a tall man dressed in a tight fitting uniform with a flaming red beard up to his eyes
3. the englishmens interest was immediately aroused and they asked oh really
4. he went on in another twenty years the whole of europe every bit of it will belong to us prussia is stronger than all the rest
5. he sneered at austria defeated a few years before
6. no monsieur replied monsieur dubuis
7. i'll cut off your moustache said the officer to fill my pipe
8. then all of a sudden exhausted by his exertions monsieur dubuis stood up and resumed his seat without saying a word
9. we are just coming into strasbourg the german continued
10. oh i say exclaimed one of the englishmen in a voice quivering with delight gratified curiosity and joyful impatience

Exercise 2

Change the *narration* (See detailed description of *narration* in Chapter 1 on pp. 14-15):

1. The Prussian officer said, "I killed twelve Frenchmen in that village. I took over one hundred prisoners."
2. He went on to say, "I took those French rogues by the ears."
3. He said, "In another twenty years the whole of Europe, every bit of it, will belong to us."
4. The officer said, "Have you any tobacco on you?"
5. The German said, "Then go and buy some when the train stops."
6. "Go and do what I told you," he said, "and be quick about it."
7. "I'll cut off your moustache," said the officer, "to fill my pipe."
8. He said, "Either you give me satisfaction in a pistol duel or I shall kill you."

GRAMMAR: SENTENCE

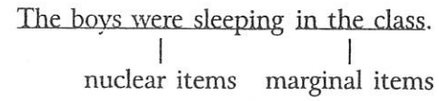
A *sentence* is a sequence of words, complete in itself, conveying a statement, a question or a command, usually containing a subject and a predicate which must carry the verb.

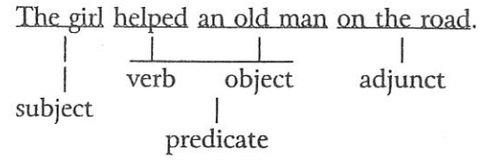
In written English, sentences begin with a capital letter and end with a full stop (.), a question mark (?) or an exclamation mark (!):

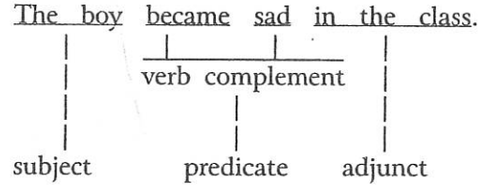
John went home.
Were they members of a family?
How brave he is!

Those items which are essential to the construction of a sentence are

called *nuclear items*. Those items which can be left out in the construction are called *marginal items* (also known as *adjuncts*).





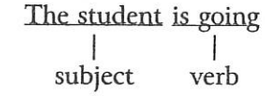


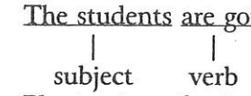
Subject

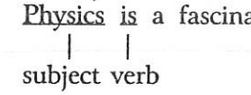
In a sentence the verb agrees grammatically with the subject. In the sentence 'My cat keeps catching birds', 'My cat' is the subject.

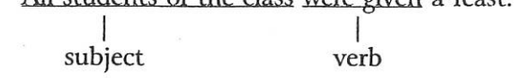
Two important characteristics of the 'subject' are:

(a) The 'verb' agrees with the 'subject': if the subject is singular, the verb must also be singular; if the subject is plural, the verb must be plural too. This feature is called *agreement* or *concord*.









(b) When an interrogative sentence is formed out of a declarative sentence, the first verbal element (the auxiliary) is shifted to the front of the 'subject'.

The students are attending class. (Declarative)
1 2 3

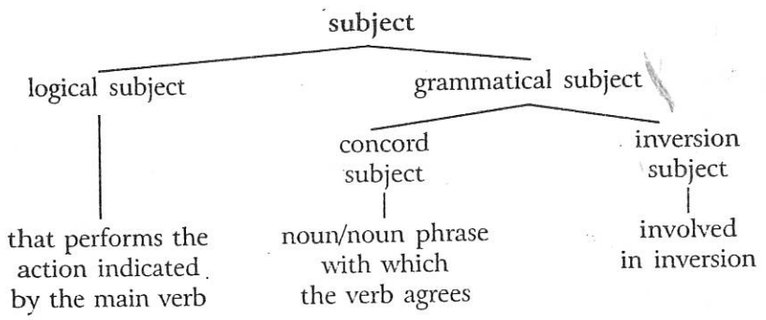
Are the students attending class? (Interrogative)
2 1 3

This shifting is called *inversion* and occurs in all interrogative sentences.

Why are you standing alone?
2 1 3

(In the above examples 1 = the subject, 2 = the first verbal element or the auxiliary, 3 = the main verb)

The noun or the noun phrase which is involved in such inversion is the inversion subject. In most sentences, the concord subject and the inversion subject are the same. However, in the sentence 'There are five books in this packet', 'There' is the inversion (dummy) subject, and 'five books' is the logical and the grammatical subject. Similarly, in the sentence 'There was a tiger in the zoo', 'There' is the inversion (dummy) subject, and 'a tiger' is the logical and the grammatical subject.



In *active voice* the subject usually represents the person(s) or thing(s) that performs the action expressed by the main verb. In active voice, the grammatical subject is also the logical subject. However, in passive voice, the grammatical subject is not the logical subject.

Let us consider the following sentences:

Surjit opened the door.	'Surjit' is both the logical subject and the grammatical subject.
The door was opened by Surjit	'the door' is the grammatical subject. 'Surjit' is the logical subject.
There weren't many boys in the class.	'There' is the inversion (dummy) subject. 'many boys' is the logical and the grammatical subject.

Predicate

The part of a sentence which tells us something about the subject is called the *predicate* of the sentence.

In the sentence 'A cow attacked a farmer', 'A cow' is the grammatical subject, and 'attacked a farmer' is the *predicate*.

Exercise 1

In the following sentences find out the *grammatical subject*, *predicate* and *adjunct*:

Example: A few days ago, a blind man conquered Mount Everest.
adjunct | grammatical subject | predicate

1. The writer calls Jim and Della 'the magi'.
2. All my friends are dear to me.
3. Does he go for a bath in the river?
4. Generally, I do not talk to strangers.
5. One morning I went for a walk.
6. He made another attempt to disclose his secret.
7. I find myself in a situation which leaves me with no other alternative.
8. She replied almost with the zeal of a poet.
9. Everything was settled that evening.
10. The wheels were only one yard away from him.
11. It might lead to all sorts of complications.
12. The teacher was most pleased by the student's performance.

Exercise 2

Given below are some incomplete sentences. Complete them by selecting an appropriate verb from the given list. Ensure that in each sentence the *verb* agrees with the *subject*. You can use the same verb more than once:

1. Many questions _____ asked by the judge.
2. I _____ no complaints against anyone.
3. They _____ strict instructions not to cheat in the exams.
4. You _____ aware of her talent in music.
5. Our team _____ victorious in the test match.
6. I _____ disgusted by his behaviour.
7. Measles _____ an infectious disease.
8. The second innings _____ over in an hour.
9. By learning to type for the first time at the age of seventy, Sheela proved that you _____ never too old to learn a new skill.
10. Politics _____ an interesting topic.

is	are	was	were	have

Object

A noun/noun phrase in an active sentence, which becomes the grammatical subject when the sentence is turned into the passive, can be described as an *object.*

The police arrested a thief.
subject verb object

The passive construction of this sentence is:

A thief was arrested by the police.
grammatical subject — verb — logical subject (since it is the real subject that performs the action conveyed by the main verb 'arrested')

In the sentence 'She opened the door', the noun phrase 'the door' is the object of the verb 'opened'.

Sometimes, we may have two objects in a sentence.

(a) The teacher taught her grammar.
1 2
(b) She brought me books.
1 2
(c) The boy showed him a toy truck.
1 2

We can have passive constructions of these sentences as follows:

(a) She was taught grammar by the teacher. *or*
Grammar was taught to her by the teacher.
(b) I was brought books by her. *or*
Books were brought for me by her.
(c) He was shown a toy truck by the boy. *or*
A toy truck was shown to him by the boy.

However, it is more usual for a passive sentence to begin with the person.

Those objects which are numbered (1): 'her' in sentence (a), 'me' in sentence (b), and 'him' in sentence (c) are called *Indirect Objects.*

Those objects which are numbered (2): 'grammar' in sentence (a), 'books' in sentence (b), and 'a toy truck' in sentence (c) are called *Direct Objects.*

Usually the direct object is a thing and the indirect object is a person.

Indirect objects take the preposition 'to' or 'for' when they succeed the direct objects. In that case, the sentences (a), (b) and (c) shall become:

(a) The teacher taught grammar to her.
(b) She brought books for me.
(c) The boy showed a toy truck to him.

Complement

The term *complement*, in a general sense, refers to something that is necessary to complete a grammatical construction.

A *complement* is an adjective phrase or noun phrase. A complement relates to the subject: it describes the subject or identifies it (says who or what it is). Between the subject and complement is the linking verb. For example, *be*

In the following sentences the complement has been italicised:

1. He is *angry*.
2. He became *an architect.*
3. The girl looks *ill*.
4. He appears to be *a perfectly healthy person.*
5. You seem *happy*.
6. The experiment turned out to be *a success*.

Adjunct

A *complement* must not be confused with an *adjunct*. An *adjunct* is an inessential part of a sentence, while a complement *completes* a sentence.

Here is a list of the most common verbs that take complements:

Linking Verbs

appear, be, become look, prove, remain, seem	+	adjective or noun phrase
feel, get, go, grow, smell, taste, turn	+	adjective

While *verb, object, complement* are the necessary parts of a sentence, the *adjunct* is an optional part and can be deleted without destroying the sentence.

Exercise 3

In the following sentences locate the *subject*, *object*, *complement* and *adjunct*:

For example: They are probably at home.
subject — adjunct — complement

1. The beggar stretched out his hand.
2. Della finished her cry and attended to her cheeks with a powder rag.
3. There was a pier glass between the windows of the room.
4. Suddenly she whirled from the window and stood before the glass.
5. The teacher sat down opposite the student.
6. Jim was never late.
7. The door opened and Jim stepped in and closed it.

Exercise 4
In the following sentences locate the *subject*, *object*, *complement* and *adjunct*. In case a sentence has two objects, specify the *direct object* and the *indirect object*:

Example: I wrote you a very long letter.

subject	indirect object	direct object

1. Words form sentences.
2. I will send you presents from Naini prison.
3. I dislike sermonising.
4. Hiuen Tsang became very learned.
5. He carried a light on his head.
6. We have discussed many things today.
7. Beyond our world lie other wonderful and mysterious worlds.
8. They missed the joy of discovery.
9. I have made you a suggestion.
10. In India today we are making history before our eyes.

3

NITYA

R.K. Narayan

R.K. Narayan (1906–2001) was born in Madras and educated mostly in Mysore. He was not good at studies and, in fact, completed his B.A. at the age of twenty-four. He worked briefly as a school teacher and also as a clerk, but he gave up these jobs because he was irresistibly drawn to literature. He had a brief but happy married life, which ended abruptly when his wife died of typhoid in the fifth year of their marriage. Narayan was devastated by the loss, but his intense suffering helped him gain a profound understanding of human predicament.

Narayan embarked on his literary career with *Swami and Friends*, which was published on the recommendation of Graham Greene. Narayan has often been described as something of a writer's writer: besides Greene, his admirers include V. S. Naipaul, John Updike and Saul Bellow. He was a recipient of numerous awards such as the Sahitya Akademi Award, the Padma Bhushan, and the A. C. Benson Medal awarded by the Royal Society of Literature. He was a nominated member of the Rajya Sabha, and a fellow of the American Academy and Institute of Arts and Letters. His major works include *The Guide, Malgudi Days, The Vendor of Sweets, The Bachelor of Arts* and his autobiography *My Days*.

Although Narayan's fiction shows affinity for traditional Indian story telling, his deceptively simple English and ironic outlook make him particularly accessible to western readers. He offers a penetrating analysis of human conduct and human relationships, without ever resorting to didactic overtones. Malgudi, the quintessential, microcosmic Indian town of Narayan's imagination, provides a realistic setting for his fiction. Like Jane Austen, he works on his 'two inches of ivory', but within his limited sphere he has achieved rare literary distinction for himself.

The present story revolves around a twenty-year-old boy, Nitya, who fiercely disagrees with his parents regarding a vow they had taken for his well-being when at the age of two he was struck with whooping cough and convulsions. As part of the vow, if his life was spared, Nitya's head had to be shaved clean and his hair offered with due rites to God in the temple located on a distant hill. However, when Nitya recovered from his illness, his parents forgot about the holy vow they had taken. Many years later, while turning the leaves of an old diary, Nitya's father stumbles upon the promise made to God. Immediately, a trip is planned amidst a spirited protest from Nitya who fails to see the point of the whole exercise. Had it been done when he was still a child, the proposed

ceremony would not have invited such resistance. However, at the age of twenty, Nitya has a will of his own and he resents the idea of a shaven head. Notwithstanding his objections, Nitya's parents pursue the idea with suitable enthusiasm and soon the three are on their way to the temple on the hill. Once they arrive at the temple, they are met with a fresh set of problems: the barber who is meant to perform the ceremony, they discover, is away on a visit to another village. This development lifts up Nitya's sagging spirits. His happiness, however, is short-lived as the barber soon appears on the scene. But by now Nitya is in no mood to oblige and he manages to wriggle out of the situation without losing even a tuft of hair, not even the four inches of hair he had promised to part with when the barber was not in sight.

'Nitya' juxtaposes the contrasting viewpoints of the two generations: the God-fearing parents and the irreverent Nitya. The story is characterized by a tone that is gentle much more than it is judgemental. Narayan succeeds in evoking laughter by subjecting the foibles of both youth and age to a satire that invites us to reflect upon human nature rather than subject it to an impassioned critique.

'Nitya, at six on Friday morning,' said his father determinedly, 'we leave by bus.' Nitya had noticed preparations at home for this trip, Mother planning a packed lunch for three and filling a basket with coconut, flowers, and incense for worship at the temple. Nitya very well knew how much he was involved in their plans. His mother had talked of nothing else whenever he stepped into the kitchen for coffee. 'After all, a vow has to be fulfilled,' she would keep repeating. Nitya would try to change the subject, banter, joke about it, and run away. They had made a vow to God in a distant hill that Nitya's head would be shaved clean and his hair offered with due rites if his life was spared. That was when he was two years old and stricken with whooping cough and convulsions. Now he was twenty, and although the time limit for fulfilment seemed to be past, yet, they felt, it would not be safe or proper to postpone further. When casually turning the leaves of an old diary, Father discovered the record of their promise to God. Mother, too, recollected having knotted a little coin in a piece of cloth as a reminder, although she could not trace it now. The promise and the diary were lost sight of during Nitya's growing years when the family suddenly found itself drawn into a legal battle over their property. The case was prolonged year after year through the labours of a specially gifted lawyer on the opposite side who could manoeuvre a postponement out of the toughest judge at a crucial point, with the idea of starting it all over again before a new judge in due course. Father was determined to fight it out as the will was unequivocally in his favour and made him sole heir to the property. By the time the final decision came, his assets had dwindled, his lawyer

himself had changed from a scintillating youth of promise to a toothless character in a frayed gown haunting the corridors of the civil court.

Today, when Father mentioned a firm date for the trip, Nitya protested, 'It doesn't concern me, your twenty-year-old promise. You had no business to pawn my scalp without consulting me.'

'You were only two years old then.'

'You should have done it when you could handle my head as you pleased.'

'But you were very sick and for a long time, too.'

'I have survived, which proves that the disease died rather than me and so where is God's hand in this, if there is a God and if he is interested in my hair?'

His parents were aghast at his manner of talk. Mother pleaded, 'Whatever you do, don't talk like that.'

Father admonished, 'Nitya, you must not be blasphemous. If God hadn't responded to our prayers and saved your life. . .' He could not complete the sentence.

'Was it a bargain?' Nitya asked leeringly.

'Yes,' replied his father. 'It was indeed a bargain and there can be no going back on it.'

'Very well, but the head offered for a shave was not yours. You have been carrying on negotiations with a commodity that did not belong to you.'

'It was for your welfare.'

'Did I ask for it?' Nitya asked puckishly. His mother burst into tears. Father remarked with a scowl, 'You talk like a sinner, cold and godless. Wonder where you inherited it from.'

At this point their neighbour, an alcoholic who had stationed himself in front of the house listening to their debate, suddenly thundered from the street, 'Silence! I am wifeless. Others have two or three—selfish bastards!' He had been a chief engineer in government service, but was dismissed for drunkenness, and later abandoned by his family, too. Nitya loved his antics as he strode up and down the street shouting obscenities after visits to the tavern at the market. Nitya had noted in his private journal: 'The merry engineer mistook the kitchen for the toilet, and that proved too much for his better half.' Now on the pretext of sending him away, Nitya went down the steps and escaped his parents. Later, however, his father kept a close watch on him and clung to him till they reached their seats in the yellow bus at the market gate on Friday.

Father looked triumphant with Nitya secure at his side in the bus, and engaged him in small talk. Mother sat away from them in a back row, enjoying the company of women returning to their villages. The

bus passed through Ellaman and crossed Nallappa's Grove and climbed the other bank of the river, splashing up water. The driver displayed immense self-assurance and goaded his bus on with reckless gusto. Passengers were tossed sideways and jolted up and down, but no one minded except Nitya. 'What sort of journey is this?'

'You must learn to be patient, my boy, ours is a poor country. We cannot afford the luxuries they have in Bombay or Madras.' The passengers, mostly villagers, were happy chatting and laughing and also exchanging jokes with the conductor from time to time. Passengers got in and out all along the route whenever the bus stopped with its wheels screeching and churning up dust. At certain points the bus became almost empty, at others overcrowded, the conductor shouting, 'Move up, move up.' People got in somehow and stayed on somehow, packed to the windscreen. No one protested, but parted with their coins cheerfully. The conductor, hanging on the footboard precariously, pocketed all the cash, which inspired Nitya to note in his diary, 'The bus rocks and sways, and sighs with its burden, but won't burst yet. Perhaps the last straw is yet to arrive. But the real question is, Who owns this? Definitely not this conductor, though he grows heavier every minute with the coins dropping like manna into his pocket.'

'You should get down here and walk up to that hill, the bus can't take you there,' said the conductor at a stop. They struggled their way out of the bus, Mother carrying her bundle of offerings and food delicately through the crush. As the bus started on its way again, Father asked the driver, 'When are you returning?'

'At five, six, or seven; if you miss, tomorrow morning.'

The temple perched on a hillock was visible across the field, but it was impossible to judge the distance. A track formed by the tread of feet meandered through the fields. They had to cross in single file with Nitya in the middle, Father ahead, and Mother bringing up the rear. Nitya reflected, 'Afraid I might run away, they are sandwiching me. But what chance have I, trapped by slush and vegetation on both sides of this narrow path.'

An hour's walk brought them to a hamlet skirting the base of the hillock. Nitya was on the point of asking, Why come so far, if God is everywhere? I could as well have surrendered my head to our Vinayak Street barber, who shaves you at your doorstep. As if reading his mind, Father began to explain, 'This temple was established by our ancestors five hundred years ago—earlier; it's on this hill that Kumara annihilated the demon whose name I can't recollect now.'

'Demon is a demon, whatever the name,' said the young man. Father ignored his quip and continued, 'The temple was built by a Chola king who ruled these parts, and in course of time it was turned over to the care of our ancestors.'

'How are you sure?' Nitya asked.

'You've got into the habit of questioning everything.'

'I just want to know, that's all.'

'Well, it is all recorded in copper plate, stone pillars, and palm leaves, from which deductions are made by scholars. Don't imagine you are the only wise man. There is a document in the temple in palm leaf mentioning my great-grandfather by name and committing our family to the expenses of the annual Chariot Festival. I pay them two hundred rupees a year and twenty measures of rice for a public feast on that day. They come to the town for collections in December, ten days before the festival. . . . Luckily, a copy of this document is in my possession with the receipts of annual payments which clinched the issue in our favour at the appellate stage.' Nitya noted later in his diary, 'Even at this distance and on a consecrated spot my father is unable to keep his mind off the civil court, verily like the engineer off his wifelessness.' When they came to the border of the village, Father slowed his steps and, with a slight frown, threw a general question in the air: 'Where is everybody?' as if the reception committee had failed him.

He halted at a corner and shouted, 'Hey, Rama,' and a group of women and boys emerged from some corner and came running on seeing him. They invited him into their homes. Father said impatiently, 'Yes, later. First the temple. Call the headman.'

'They are all away weeding,' said a woman, and turning to a young man jabbed his cheek with her forefinger and said, 'Run up and tell Rama that the Trustee is come.' The boy shot off like an arrow. They dragged out of their homes an assortment of furniture and put it up in the shade of a tree, and then bustled about and conjured up a bunch of bananas and a jug of milk for the visitors and laid the fare on a wooden stool. Nitya cried, 'Oh, just what I need,' and tried to reach out for a fruit, but Father said, 'Not now, after the vow.' (Nitya noted in his diary, 'Not now, but after the vow, says God through my father in a perfect rhyme, while the banana wilts in the tray and milk curdles irreparably.') The headman arrived. After the initial courtesies, much business talk ensued, with a crowd standing around and listening intently. Father inquired authoritatively, 'Where is the priest? The temple must be opened. We have to leave by the evening bus.'

The headman said out of courtesy, 'Must you? You may spend the night at the rest house, sir. You have come after a long time.'

Immediately, Nitya protested, 'You may both stay back if you choose, but I want to catch the bus,' feeling nostalgic for his evening group at the College Union. Mother said, 'Be patient.' But Nitya replied, 'I've much to do this evening.' Father said, 'What could be

more important than your duty to God? Be patient, having come so far.'

The temple priest, his forehead ablaze with sacred ash and vermilion, shoulder wrapped in a red shawl, a lanky person with a booming voice, arrived, dangling a large key in an iron hoop. After greeting the Trustee in the correct manner, he plunged straight into business, cataloguing his demands.

'The well at the temple needs to be deepened. The temple lock must be replaced. It is worn out, sir. These are very bad days. We are finding it difficult to get flowers for the worship. We were getting supplies from the other village. But they raise their rates each time and are very irregular too. They have to come up from the other side of the hill and don't like it, and so have started a rumour that they see a wolf or panther prowling around, and have stopped coming altogether.'

'Nonsense, only an excuse,' cried Father. 'No panther or tiger in these parts, never heard such rubbish in my life.'

'He mentioned wolf, not tiger,' corrected Nitya.

'What if? It is just gossip and nonsense—the rumour-mongers!' Father cried with passion, looking outraged at the notion of any wild life in the vicinity of his ancestral temple. He dismissed the subject peremptorily and commanded, 'Get the barber down. My son's tonsure today whatever happens,' and the assembly looked with fresh interest at Nitya's head, at which he simpered, squirmed, and ran his fingers through his crop. The priest turned to a little fellow in the crowd and said, 'Don't bite your nail, you fool!' Go to the tank bund and tell Raghavan to come up with his tin box immediately, this very second. Run, run.' The little messenger was off like a shot again.

They started up the hill, led by the priest, a crowd following. It was a short climb, but Nitya's mother panted and rested in three places, while Father hovered around her and fidgeted impatiently. The climb ended at the door of the temple, which was unlocked, and two large doors were pushed open. It was a little shrine with a granite-pillared hall and paved corridor around the sanctum, which housed an image on a pedestal. Father became grim and devout. Mother shut her eyes and recited a prayer. The priest lit the wicks in the sanctum and the image began to glow with the oil anointed on it and gradually took shape. The priest was grumbling, 'Even this oil is adulterated nowadays.' He had managed to secure a handful of marigolds and nerium and stuck them on the image. While they were all in this state of elation, the young messenger returned from his mission and bellowed from the door, 'The barber's house is locked, not a soul there.'

'Did you ask the neighbours?'

'They don't know. They only saw the family go out for the bus with their baggage.'

Nitya cried aloud, 'God is great, really.'

Father commented, 'This is the worst of it, having one barber for the whole place. He thinks he can do what he pleases. One and only Padmavathi for a whole city, as the saying goes,' he said, unable to contain himself. His wife said with a frown, 'Hush! What awful words to utter in this place' (Padmavathi was a reference to a whore). Father glowered at her for checking him, but they were all assembled in the presence of God and could not engage in acrimony. Nitya giggled but suppressed himself when his father glanced in his direction. The headman said in a respectful whisper, 'Raghavan cannot make both ends meet unless he ekes out with the fee for playing the pipe at weddings. It is their family tradition.' Father leaned over to Mother and whispered, 'For thousands of years somehow barbers have also been outstanding pipers and custodians of pure classical music.' While this was going on, the priest sounded a bell and circled a camphor flame around the image and they stopped talking and were lost in meditation.

When the priest came out of the sanctum, bearing a tray with camphor flame, a discussion began as to what course of action the scriptures prescribed when an essential barber was absent.

'We are at the mercy of a single man,' Father kept repeating monotonously, firmly suppressing the name 'Padmavathi,' which kept bobbing up again and again on his tongue. The priest put the tray back in the sanctum, came out, and joined the discussion. He finally said, gaping at Nitya's crop, which was the main topic of discussion and purpose of the trip, 'Sometimes, the vow is taken to be fulfilled through a token performance with penalty added. These days young men will not allow barbers to come near them.'

'They won't allow their terrifying whiskers to be touched either!' added Father.

'No tonsure is possible unless done in babyhood,' said the priest.

'Too true, well spoken,' said Nitya, pleased with the tenor of talks, and offered, 'Get me a pair of scissors, and I will give you four inches of my front lock, the best available—that's all, and God will be satisfied. After all, with so many offerings, where can he keep his collection?'

The priest said, 'The fruits and coconuts you have brought are adequate, leave them behind, and add whatever cash you can spare.'

Father and Mother looked disappointed and kept throwing covetous glances at Nitya's head. Nitya felt relieved, but the relief threatened to be short-lived. Soon there was a commotion. Someone at the doorway announced excitedly, 'Raghavan is coming up,'

followed by the appearance of a fat barber holding in his hand a tiny tin box. He was panting and perspiring; he stared at the gathering from the doorway, and without a word went straight to the well at the backyard, peeled off his vest, drew a pot of water and emptied it over his head, and reappeared, dripping and ready. 'He never opens his razor box without a bath at first when he has to perform a tonsure ceremony,' explained the priest admiringly. The barber explained, 'I had only gone to a nearby farm for a baby's first shave, that was all.'

'Not to play the pipe at a wedding?' someone asked.

'Oh, no. I have jealous neighbours who create false rumours to spoil my business. If I had known the Trustee was coming I would not have accepted even a thousand pieces of gold anywhere outside. When the boy came on a bicycle and told me, I snatched it from his hand and rode down immediately. Now I am ready, my master.' Father and Mother looked pleased at this turn of events. Nitya giggled at the thought of the fat barber on the boy's bicycle. Father took Nitya by hand. 'Let us sit on that stone platform in the corridor, that's where he shaves—'

Nitya shook himself free and said, 'I agreed to give four inches of hair, it was up to you to have taken it. Now you have lost the opportunity, which must be seized by the forelock.'

'Now, with this man here, we must fulfil the vow as originally promised,' said Mother.

'Let Father use the barber if he likes. I'm not interested.'

The barber started pleading and arguing. The priest edged up to Nitya with his pleas and said ingratiatingly, 'You must not hurt your parents' feelings. Please move on to that platform, the barber is ready.'

'But my head is not ready. You promised to accept four inches of my hair. Now you are demanding my head itself. Have you no logic or reason? No contentment or consistency? How can God tolerate fickle-minded people like you! Now I have changed my mind—I won't give even an inch . . .'

Both Father and Mother cried simultaneously, 'Don't talk to the priest like that in his own temple.' Nitya was angry, also hungry. They would not let him touch even one plantain out of the dozens offered by the villagers under the tree. While his parents stood staring at him helplessly, Nitya suddenly turned on his heel, dashed out, and sped downhill saying, 'I will wait for you both at the bus stop, but only till the bus arrives . . . .'

NOTES

de'terminedly : showing a strong will
'incense : substance that gives off pleasant smell when lit, used especially in religious ceremonies

'banter : light-hearted conversational exchange
vow : a solemn and binding promise
con'vulsions : violent, involuntary movements of the body
ma'noeuvre : handle something carefully and skilfully, often using inventiveness or deceit
,une'quivocally : clearly and unmistakably
'dwindle : become less or smaller
,scinti'llating : brilliant or sparkling
frayed : worn, so that individual threads come loose
pawn (fig.) : person or group whose actions are controlled by others
scalp : skin of the head
a'ghast : filled with fear or horror
ad'monish : to scold or issue a mild but firm warning
'blasphemous : showing contempt or disrespect for God and sacred things
leeringly : immodestly
negoti'ation : formal discussion aimed at reaching an agreement
com'modity : product, article
'puckishly : impishly, mischievously
scowl : angry look on the face
,alco'holic : a heavy drinker
'antics : playful tricks, absurd behaviour
ob'scenities : indecent words
'tavern : a pub, a public house
better half : an old-fashioned term for one's wife
'pretext : excuse
tri'umphant : feeling happy on being victorious, successful, etc.
goad : urge or provoke somebody to action
'reckless : rash or impulsive
'gusto : zest
pre'cariously : unsafely
'manna (fig.) : unexpected gift which gives great pleasure. (Literally, it means food provided by God for the Israelites during their forty years in the desert.)
crush : a crowd of people pressed close together
me'andered : a route with a series of twists and turns
slush : soft mud
'hamlet : a small village
'skirting : moving along the edge of something
an'nihilate : destroy completely
quip (n) : witty or sarcastic remark
de'duction : conclusion reached by reasoning
'measure (n) : standard quantity of something
clinched the issue : settled the issue finally
a'ppellate stage : the stage at which it is possible to appeal in a court or a tribunal
'consecrated (adj). : holy
frown (n) : expression of displeasure, a serious or angry look on the face
jabbed : poked
a'ssortment : a collection of different things

bustle about	:	move busily and energetically
conjure up	:	make something appear as if by magic
wilt	:	lose freshness
en'sued	:	followed
nos'talgic	:	a mixed feeling of happiness, sadness, and longing when recalling a person, place or event from the past
a'blaze	:	bright, shining
ver'milion	:	bright red colour
'lanky	:	ungracefully tall and thin
'dangling	:	hanging or swinging loosely
prowl	:	move quietly and cautiously
vi'cinity	:	the area around a particular place
pe'remptorily	:	insisting upon obedience
'tonsure	:	shaving the top or all of the head
'simper	:	smile in a foolish way
squirm	:	twist the body (from embarrassment or shame)
'fidget	:	make small restless movements
'sanctum	:	a holy place
a'noint	:	apply oil or water on an image as a part of religious ceremony
'bellowed	:	roared, shouted
whore	:	a prostitute
'acrimony	:	bitterness
'giggle	:	laugh in a nervous or silly way
eke out	:	contrive to make (a livelihood) or support (an existence)
bob up	:	to appear or reappear suddenly
'whiskers	:	hair growing on a man's face, especially on the cheek
'covetous	:	greedy
com'motion	:	noisy confusion
in'gratiatingly	:	trying to please or gain favour
fickle-minded	:	changeable, lacking constancy of mind
simul'taneously	:	happening or done at the same time as something else
'plantain	:	a fruit like a large banana, but less sweet

COMPREHENSION

1. What was the vow that Nitya's parents had taken when he was two years old?
2. How are the parents reminded of the vow?
3. How does Nitya react when he learns about his parents' decision to fulfil the vow?
4. Where was the temple located?
5. Why does Nitya's father call him blasphemous?
6. What historical information does the father share with his son about the temple?
7. What happens to Nitya's hair at the end of the story?

COMPOSITION

1. Describe in your own words the journey Nitya and his parents undertake to the temple.
2. Discuss Nitya's attitude towards the vow and the rituals related to it.
3. Describe in your own words the scene at the temple.
4. How does Nitya succeed in his efforts to save his hair? Discuss.
5. Bring out the element of humour in the story.

Exercise 1
Fill in the blanks with appropriate *articles* (See also p. 58):

1. Mother, too, recollected having knotted _____ little coin in _____ piece of cloth as _____ reminder, although she could not trace it now.
2. _____ case was prolonged year after year through _____ labours of _____ specially gifted lawyer on _____ opposite side.
3. At this point their neighbour, _____ alcoholic who had stationed himself in front of_____ house listening to their debate, suddenly thundered from _____ street.
4. Now on _____ pretext of sending him away, Nitya went down _____ steps and escaped his parents.
5. Mother sat away from them in _____ back row, enjoying _____ company of women returning to their villages.
6. You must learn to be patient, my boy, ours is _____ poor country.
7. _____ track formed by _____ tread of feet meandered through _____ fields.
8. After _____ initial courtesies, much business talk ensued, with _____ crowd standing around and listening intently.
9. After greeting _____ Trustee in _____ correct manner, he plunged straight into business.
10. It was _____ little shrine with _____ granite-pillared hall and paved corridor around _____ sanctum, which housed _____ image on _____ pedestal.

Exercise 2
Fill in the blanks with appropriate *prepositions* (See details on *prepositions* in Chapter 7 on pp. 96-97):

1. His mother had talked _____ nothing else whenever he stepped _____ the kitchen _____ coffee.
2. When casually turning the leaves _____ an old diary, Father discovered the record _____ their promise _____ God.
3. The promise and the diary were lost sight _____ during Nitya's growing years.

4. His parents were aghast _____ his manner _____ talk.
5. Father looked triumphant _____ Nitya secure _____ his side _____ the bus, and engaged him _____ small talk.
6. The temple perched _____ a hillock was visible _____ the field, but it was impossible to judge the distance.
7. An hour's walk brought them _____ a hamlet skirting the base _____ the hillock.
8. I pay them two hundred rupees a year and twenty measures _____ rice _____ a public feast _____ that day.
9. We are _____ the mercy _____ a single man.
10. I snatched it _____ his hand and rode down immediately.

Exercise 3

Punctuate the following sentences:

1. nitya at six on friday morning said the father determinedly we leave by bus
2. after all a vow has to be fulfilled she would keep repeating
3. nitya would try to change the subject banter joke about it and run away
4. mother too recollected having knotted a little coin in a piece of cloth as a reminder although she could not trace it now
5. mother pleaded whatever you do dont talk like that
6. yes replied his father it was indeed a bargain and there can be no going back on it
7. at this point their neighbour thundered from the street silence i am wifeless others have two or three selfish bastards
8. as the bus started on its way again father asked the driver when are you returning
9. nitya reflected afraid i might run away they are sandwiching me
10. father said impatiently yes later first the temple call the headman

GRAMMAR: PARTS OF SPEECH

Words in sentences perform certain grammatical functions. According to the functions they perform, we classify them as different parts of speech. In the following sentence:

Seema wrote beautifully.

'Seema' is a *noun*
'wrote' is a *verb*
'beautifully' is an *adverb*

Traditionally, there are eight parts of speech:
Noun, Pronoun, Adjective, Verb, Adverb, Preposition, Conjunction and *Interjection.*

Though very useful, the eight parts of speech are now considered inadequate for describing how words function in sentences. Some words may fall in more than one class.
For example,

act	can be used both as a *verb* and a *noun*
principal	can be used as a *noun* and an *adjective*
other	can be used as an *adjective* and a *pronoun*
one	can be used as a *determiner* and a *pronoun*
on	can be used as a *preposition* and an *adverb*
motor	can be used as a *noun*, an *adjective* and a *verb*
for	can be used as a *preposition* and a *conjunction*
monthly	can be used as an *adjective*, an *adverb* and a *noun*
round	can be used as a *noun*, a *verb*, an *adjective*, an *adverb* and a *preposition*

Study these sentences:
She looked *round*-eyed with terror. (adjective)
I owe you Rs 49.45 but I'll *round* it up to Rs. 50. (verb)
We ran *round/around* the block looking for the dog. (preposition)
There are trees all *round* the house. (adverb)
He ordered three *rounds* of kababs. (noun)

Besides these eight parts of speech, there are some other grammatical categories that help us understand how words function in sentences. They are *articles, determiners, demonstratives, intensifiers*, etc. We will now study one of the most important and frequently used grammatical categories.

Nouns

A *noun* is a naming word.

Example: Shyam, girl, chair, happiness, grammar, etc.

(i) A noun can be identified by the plural suffix -s, or possessive suffix 's. The other suffixes that go with nouns are -ity (ability, scarcity), -ness (meanness, kindness), -age (roughage, coverage), -hood (childhood, neighbourhood), -er (engineer, dancer), etc.

(ii) Nouns are further classified into four groups. They are:

(a) *Common noun*—A common noun is a name given in common to every person or thing in the same class or kind. For example, boy, teacher, town, country.
(b) *Proper noun*—A proper noun is the name of a particular person or place. We use capitals for proper nouns. For example, Mumbai, Rita, McDonald, Sahara.
(c) *Abstract noun*—An abstract noun is usually the name of a quality, action or state considered apart from the object to which it belongs. For example, darkness, laughter, poverty, arts.

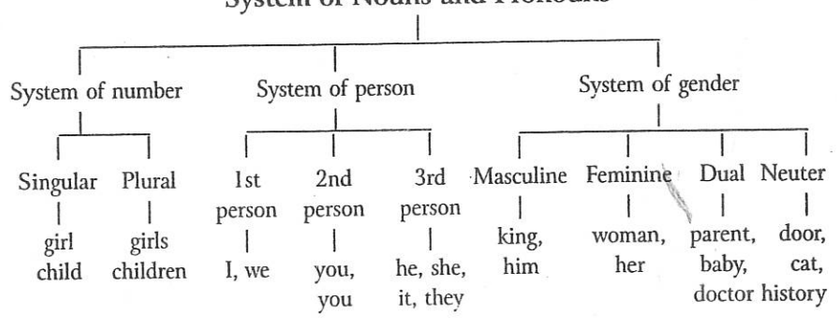
(d) *Collective noun*—A collective noun is the name of a collection of persons or things taken together and spoken of as a whole. For example, crowd, team, audience, flock, family, committee, parliament, fleet, etc.

(iii) A noun can have any of the following positions or functions in a sentence:

(a) The student bought a book. (Subject of a sentence)
(b) The student bought a book. (Object of a sentence)
(c) Manoj is a doctor. (Complement of a verb)
(d) Rajiv is standing behind the table. (Object of a preposition)
(e) My friend, Sudha, is an athlete. (In apposition to a noun)

(iv) A noun and a noun substitute like a pronoun have some common features. Both nouns and pronouns carry information related to number, person and gender. Study the table below:

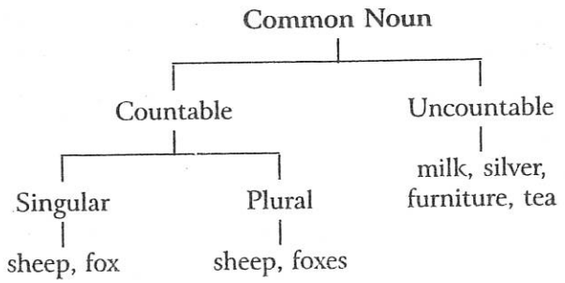
System of Nouns and Pronouns



The system of number does not always work logically. Nouns like *trousers*, *shorts*, *tongs*, *scissors* are plural nouns but refer to single objects with two equal parts. And, nouns like *news*, *mumps*, *measles*, *economics*, look plural but are used with singular verbs. For example,

This pair of trousers is dirty. *Or*
Flared trousers are in fashion
The news is bad today.
Mathematics is an interesting subject.

(v) Common nouns are further sub-divided into two groups:



Countable nouns are those that can be counted and can take plurals. For example, a table—ten tables.

Uncountable nouns are those that do not take plurals and cannot be counted. They are usually weighed or measured. For example, furniture, rice, (half a kg of rice); tea (cups of tea), milk, etc.

Exercise 1

Given below are some *nouns*. With the help of a dictionary, if required, list those nouns which are *countable* and those which are *uncountable:*

advice	bedding	soldier	furniture
chief	watchman	clothing	machinery
paper	scenery	belief	grammar
gold	sand	sugar	blood
gift	pair	air	water

Exercise 2

Underline the *nouns* in the paragraph given below. Mention whether each is a *common*, *proper*, *abstract* or *collective noun.*

People call Gangu a Brahmin. He considers himself one, too. All my other servants bow to me. But Gangu never greets me like this. Probably he expects me to bow to him. He never touches any of the used utensils. I lack the courage to ask him even to fan me in the hot weather. Sometimes when nobody else is around and I am dripping with perspiration, he does pick up a fan, but his attitude is that he is doing me a great favour. He is short-tempered and cannot tolerate even the slightest rebuke.

4

THE FATALIST

Isaac Bashevis Singer

Isaac Bashevis Singer (1904–91) was born in Leoncin, Poland, and educated at Tachkemoni Rabbinical Seminary, Warsaw. His surname 'Singer' is anglicised from Zynger and his middle name is derived from his mother's name, Bathsheba. Singer emigrated to the USA in 1935 and took American citizenship in 1943. He wrote most of his early fiction in Yiddish, which was subsequently translated into English. With the publication of *The Family Mosket*, simultaneously in English and Yiddish, Singer began his career as an 'English' writer. His novels such as *The Magician of Lublin, The Estate, The Slave, The Manor* and numerous collections of short stories including *Gimpel the Fool and Other Stories* and *A Friend of Kafka and Other Stories* have received much critical acclaim. Singer also wrote plays and several volumes of stories for children. He was honoured by many American colleges and universities for his contribution to literature. The ultimate recognition, however, came in the form of the coveted Nobel Prize awarded to him in 1978.

Singer's fiction is deeply influenced by his East European Jewish heritage. It registers the devastating impact of the Holocaust (mass killings of the Jews in Nazi Germany) on Jewish life. Magic, mysticism and folk traditions are familiar motifs in his work. He often portrays characters struggling to resist temptation, but instead of being judgemental, he offers a sympathetic understanding of human weaknesses and foibles.

'The Fatalist' is the story of a young man, Benjamin Schwartz, who comes to be known as such for his avowed faith in the philosophical doctrine of fatalism. Upon being questioned about his belief in Special Providence, Schwartz speaks on the subject for a whole hour. He claims before a group of puzzled young men and women that everything in life is pre-determined and that there is little scope for individual enterprise. Members of the 'Young Zionist Organization' before whom these observations are made get so enamoured of the concept that all their subsequent discussions invariably veer towards fatalism.

Matters take a curious turn when Schwartz proposes marriage to a sharp-tongued girl Heyele, asserting that she was fated to marry him. An enraged Heyele challenges him to demonstrate the depth of his convictions by lying down on railway tracks a few minutes before the train is due to pass. Schwartz readily accepts the proposition but on the condition that if perchance he survives, Heyele would marry him. As it turns out, Schwartz fulfils his part of

the deal, only to escape unhurt and victorious, on account of the timely stopping of the train by an alert engine driver.

The story is remarkable for its interest and ambiguity: it cannot be established with any degree of certainty that the Fatalist is indeed a firm believer in the doctrine he professes. When confronted by Heyele, he is left with no choice but to accept the challenge since any attempt to evade the situation can compromise his credibility. It is quite possible that he risks his life more for the love he has for Heyele than for his faith in the doctrine of fatalism, for his survival would ensure his marriage to the girl he loved. The fact that he escapes unhurt is not necessarily a vindication of the concept of fatalism. The narrative offers no clues as to whether the writer subscribes to the doctrine of fatalism or not. This element of uncertainty regarding the writer's stance sustains the interest of the reader all through the story. The note on which the story ends also lends credence to the thesis that the fatalist had been driven more by impulse of love than by faith in fatalism.

Nicknames given in small towns are the homely, familiar ones: Haim Bellybutton, Yekel Cake, Sarah Gossip, Gittel Duck, and similar names. But in the Polish town to which I came as a teacher in my young days I heard of someone called Benjamin Fatalist. I promptly became curious. How did they come to the word 'fatalist' in a small town? And what did that person do to earn it? The secretary of the Young Zionist Organisation where I taught Hebrew told me about it.

The man in question wasn't a native here. He stemmed from somewhere in Courland. He had come to town in 1916 and posted notices that he was a teacher of German. It was during the Austrian occupation, and everyone wanted to learn German. German is spoken in Courland and he, Benjamin Schwartz—that was his real name—got many students of both sexes. Just as the secretary was talking, he pointed to the window and exclaimed, 'There he goes now!'

I looked through the window and saw a short man, dark, in a derby and with curled moustache that was already long out of style. He was carrying a briefcase. 'After the Austrians left', the secretary continued, 'no one wanted to study German any more and the Poles gave Benjamin Schwartz a job in the archives. If someone needed a birth certificate, they came to him. He had a fancy handwriting. He had learned Polish, and he also became a kind of hedge lawyer.'

The secretary said, 'He came here as if dropping from heaven. At that time, he was a bachelor of some twenty-odd. The young people had a club, and when an educated person came to our town this was cause for a regular celebration. He was invited to our club and a box evening was arranged in his honor. Questions were placed in a box, and he was supposed to draw them out and answer them. A girl asked whether he believed in Special Providence, and, instead of replying

in a few words, he spoke for a whole hour. He said that he didn't believe in God, but that all things were determined, every trifle. If one ate an onion for supper, it was because one had to eat an onion. It had been so preordained a billion years ago. If you walked in the street and tripped over a pebble, it was fated that you should fall. He described himself as a fatalist. It had been destined that he come to our town, though it appeared accidental.

'He spoke too long; nevertheless a discussion followed. "Is there no such thing as chance?" someone asked, and he replied, "No such thing as chance." "If that is so," another asked, "what's the point of working, of studying? Why learn a trade or bring up children? Well, and why contribute to Zionism and agitate for a Jewish homeland?"

"The way it is written in the books of fate, that's how it has to be," Benjamin Schwartz replied. "If it was destined that someone open a store and go bankrupt, he has to do this. All the efforts man made were fate, because free choice is nothing but an illusion." The debate lasted well into the night and from that time on, he was called the Fatalist. A new word was added to the town's vocabulary. Everyone here knows what a fatalist is, even the beadle of the synagogue and the poorhouse attendant.

'We assumed that after that evening the crowd would get tired of these discussions and turn back to the real problems of our time. Benjamin himself said that this wasn't a thing that could be decided by logic. Either one believed in it or not. But somehow all our youth became preoccupied with the question. We would call a meeting about certificates to Palestine or about education, but instead of sticking to these subjects, they would discuss fatalism. At that time our library acquired a copy of Lermontov's *A Hero of Our Time*, translated into Yiddish, which describes a fatalist, Pechorin. Everyone read this novel, and there were those among us who wanted to test their luck. We already knew about Russian roulette and some of us might have tried it if a revolver were available. But none of us had one.

'Now listen to this. There was a girl among us, Heyele Minz, a pretty girl, active in our movement, a daughter of a wealthy man. Her father had the biggest dry-goods store in town, and all the young fellows were crazy about her. But Heyele was choosy. She found something wrong in everybody. She had a sharp tongue, what the Germans call "schlagfertig". If you said something to her she came right back at you with a sharp and cutting retort. When she wanted to she could ridicule a person in a clever, half-joking way. The Fatalist fell in love with her soon after he arrived. He wasn't at all bashful. One evening he came up to her and said, "Heyele, it's fated that you marry me, and since that is so, why delay the inevitable?"

'He said this aloud so that everyone would hear, and it created an uproar. Heyele answered, "It's fated that I should tell you that you're

an idiot and that you've got lots of nerve besides, and therefore I'm saying it. You'll have to forgive me, it was all preordained in the celestial books a billion years ago."

'Not long afterward, Heyele became engaged to a young man from Hrubieszow, the chairman of the Poale Zion there. The wedding was postponed for a year because the fiancé had an older sister who was engaged and who had to be married first. The boys chided the Fatalist, and he said, "If Heyele is to be mine, she will be mine," and Heyele replied, "I am to be Ozer Rubinstein's, not yours. That's what fate wanted."

'One winter evening the discussion flared up again about fate, and Heyele spoke up, "Mr Schwartz, or Mr Fatalist, if you really believe in what you say, and you are even ready to play Russian roulette if you had a revolver, I have a game for you that's even more dangerous."

'I want to mention here that at that time the railroad didn't reach to our town yet. It passed two miles away, and it never stopped there at all. It was the train from Warsaw to Lvov. Heyele proposed to the Fatalist that he lie down on the rails a few moments before the train passed over them. She argued, "If it's fated that you live, you will live and have nothing to fear. However, if you didn't believe in fatalism, then . . ."

'We all burst out laughing. Everyone was sure that the Fatalist would come up with some pretext to get out of it. Lying down on the tracks meant certain death. But the Fatalist said, "This, like Russian roulette, is a game, and a game requires another participant who must risk something, too." He went on: "I'll lie down on the tracks as you propose, but you must make a sacred vow that if I should live you'll break your engagement to Ozer Rubinstein and marry me."

'A deadly silence fell over the hall. Heyele grew pale, and she said, "Good, I accept your conditions." "Give me your sacred vow on it," the Fatalist said, and Heyele gave him her hand and said, "I have no mother, she died of cholera. But I swear on her soul that if you will keep your word, I will keep mine. If not, then let my honor be stained forever." She turned to us and went on, "You are all witnesses. If I should break my word, you can all spit in my face."

'I'll make it short. Everything was settled that evening. The train would pass our town around two in the afternoon. At one-thirty our whole group would meet by the tracks and the Fatalist would demonstrate whether he was a real Fatalist or just a braggart. We all promised to keep the matter secret because if the older people had found out about it there would have been a terrible fuss.

'I didn't sleep a wink that night, and as far as I know, none of the others did either. Most of us were convinced that at the last minute the Fatalist would have second thoughts and back out. Some also

suggested that when the train came into sight or the rails started to hum, we should drag the Fatalist away by force. Well, but all this posed a gruesome danger. Even now as I speak of it a shudder runs through me.

'The next day we all got up early. I was so scared that I couldn't swallow any food at breakfast. The whole thing might not have happened if we hadn't read Lermontov's book. Not all of us went; there were only six boys and four girls, including Heyele Minz. It was freezing cold outside. The Fatalist, I remember, wore a light jacket and a cap. We met on the Zamosc road, on the outskirts of town. I asked him, "Schwartz, how did you sleep last night?" and he answered, "Like any other night." You actually couldn't tell what he was feeling, but Heyele was as white as if she had just gotten over the typhoid. I went up to her and said, "Heyele, do you know that you're sending a person to his death?" And she said, "I'm not sending him. He has plenty of time to change his mind."

'I'll never forget that day as long as I live. None of us will ever forget it. We walked along and the snow kept falling on us the whole time. We came to the tracks. I thought that on account of the snow the train might possibly not be running but apparently someone had cleared the rails. We had arrived a good hour too early, and, believe me, this was the longest hour I ever spent. Around fifteen minutes before the train was due to come by, Heyele said, "Schwartz, I've thought it all over and I don't want you to lose your life because of me. Do me a favour and let's forget the whole thing." The Fatalist looked at her and asked, "So you've changed your mind? You want that fellow from Hrubieszow at any price, huh?" She said, "No, it's not the fellow from Hrubieszow, it's your life. I hear that you have a mother and I don't want her to lose a son on account of me." Heyele could barely utter these words. She spoke and she trembled. The Fatalist said, "If you will keep your promise, I'm ready to keep mine, but under one condition: stand a little farther away. If you try to force me back at the last minute, the game is over." Then he cried out, "Let everyone move twenty paces back!" He seemed to hypnotize us with his words, and we began to back up. He cried out again, "If someone tries to pull me away, I'll grab him by his coat and he will share my fate." We realized how dangerous this could be. It happens more than once that when you try to save someone from drowning, both are dragged down, and drown.

'As we moved back, the rails began to vibrate and hum and we heard the whistle of the locomotive. We began to yell as one, "Schwartz, don't do it! Schwartz, have pity!" But even as we yelled, he stretched out across the tracks. There was then just one line of tracks. One girl fainted. We were sure that in a second we would see

a person cut in half. I can't tell you what I went through in those few seconds. My blood literally began to seethe from excitement. At that moment a loud screech was heard and a thud, and the train came to a halt no more than a yard away from the Fatalist. I saw in a mist how the engineer and the fireman jumped down from the locomotive. They yelled at him and dragged him away. Many passengers disembarked. Some of us ran away out of fear of being arrested. It was a real commotion. I myself stayed where I was and watched everything. Heyele ran up to me, put her arms around me, and started to cry. It was more than a cry, it was like the howling of a beast—Give me a cigarette. I can't talk about it. It chokes me. Excuse me . . .'

I gave the secretary a cigarette and watched how it shook between his fingers. He drew in the smoke and said, 'That is actually the whole story.'

'She married him?' I asked.

'They have four children.'

'I guess the engineer managed to halt the train in time,' I remarked.

'Yes, but the wheels were only one yard away from him.'

'Did this convince you about fatalism?' I asked.

'No. I wouldn't make such a bet even if you offered me all the fortunes in the world.'

'Is he still a fatalist?'

'He still is.'

'Would he do it again?' I asked.

The secretary smiled. 'Not for Heyele.'

NOTES

'fatalist	:	one who believes in the philosophical doctrine that all events are controlled by fate, and happen by unavoidable necessity, so that humans cannot control them
'Hebrew	:	the ancient Semitic language of the Hebrews, revived and spoken in a modern form as the formal language by Jews in Israel
stemmed from	:	arose from, originated
'derby	:	a man's hat with a round hard top, usually black
'archives	:	a place where historical documents or records of a government, town, etc. are kept
hedge lawyer	:	(fig.) a lawyer as though born, brought up, sheltered by, or working under hedges, or by the roadside (a contemptuous use), a petty lawyer
'Providence	:	God or Nature regarded as an all-seeing protector of the world
ˌpre-or'dained	:	decided beforehand
trip	:	to catch one's foot on something and fall or almost fall

Zionism	:	the movement which worked for the establishment of a national homeland in Palestine for the Jews and now supports the state of Israel
'beadle	:	a minor parish official
'synagogue	:	building used by the Jews for religious worship or teaching
'poorhouse	:	workhouse; a building where very poor people are sent to live and given work to do
'Lermontov	:	Mikhail Yurevich Lermontov (1814–41) was a Russian romantic poet and novelist. His novel *A Hero of Our Time* about a disenchanted nobleman is a classic of psychological realism. Lermontov was killed in a duel.
'Yiddish	:	a composite language with borrowings from German, Slavonic languages and English, and written in Hebrew characters, spoken by about 4 million Jews all over the world, especially in Argentina, Canada, France, Israel, Mexico, Romania, the USA and the former USSR
Russian roulette	:	an act of daring, especially that of spinning the cylinder of a revolver which is loaded with one bullet only, pointing the revolver at one's own head, and pulling the trigger
schlagfertig	:	(German) quick-witted
re'tort	:	a quick, witty or angry reply
'bashful	:	shy and easily embarrassed
in'evitable	:	that cannot be avoided
to have lots of nerve	:	to be shamelessly bold
ce'lestial	:	divine, heavenly
'Warsaw	:	capital city of Poland
Lvov	:	a Ukrainian city
'pretext	:	an excuse
'braggart	:	boastful, one who talks too proudly of oneself
'gruesome	:	frightful, disgusting
'hypnotize	:	to produce a state of mind in which a person's responses may be controlled by another person
ˌdisem'bark	:	leave a ship or an aircraft

COMPREHENSION

1. Why did Benjamin Schwartz come to be known as Benjamin Fatalist?
2. From where had the Fatalist come?
3. What did the Fatalist do for a living?
4. What did the Fatalist do when asked about his belief in Special Providence?
5. What was Heyele's challenge to the Fatalist?
6. What condition did the Fatalist lay down to accept Heyele's challenge?
7. How was the Fatalist's life saved?
8. Which book in the town library became popular with the young men because of the Fatalist's influence?

9. What were Heyele and Benjamin's states of mind immediately before the rail-track episode?
10. Why did Heyele put her arms around the Secretary and cry at the end?

COMPOSITION

1. Was the Fatalist able to prove his views about fatalism?
2. Narrate the sequence of events which led to Heyele's accepting the offer of the Fatalist.
3. Discuss the ending of the story.
4. Draw a character sketch of Heyele Minz.
5. Draw a pen-portrait of the Fatalist.

Exercise 1

Fill in the blanks with appropriate *articles*:

1. How did they come to _____ word 'fatalist' in _____ small town?
2. The man in question wasn't _____native here.
3. I looked through _____window and saw _____short man, dark, in _____ derby and with curled moustache.
4. _____ young people had _____club, and when _____educated person came to our town this was cause for _____ regular celebration.
5. _____ new word was added to _____ town's vocabulary.
6. There was _____ girl among us, Heyele Minz, _____ pretty girl, active in our movement, _____daughter of _____ wealthy man.
7. _____deadly silence fell over _____ hall.
8. _____ train would pass our town around two in _____ afternoon.
9. I didn't sleep _____ wink that night, and as far as I know, none of _____ others did either.
10. _____ Fatalist, I remember, wore _____ light jacket and _____ cap.

Exercise 2

Fill in the blanks with appropriate *conjunctions* (See detailed description of *conjunctions* in Chapter 7 on p. 97):

1. Expenses had been greater _____ she had calculated.
2. It reached below her knee _____ made itself almost a garment for her.
3. One evening he came up to her _____ said, "Heyele, it's fated _____ you marry me, and _____ that is so, why delay the inevitable?"
4. You actually couldn't tell what he was feeling, _____ Heyele was as white _____ she had just gotten over the typhoid.
5. Benjamin himself said _____ this wasn't a thing that could be decided by logic. _____ one believed in it _____ not.

Exercise 3
Fill in the blanks with appropriate tense form of the *verbs* given in brackets (See detailed description of *verbs* in Chapter 5 on pp. 70–75):

1. But in the Polish town to which I _____ as a teacher in my young days I _____ of someone called Benjamin Fatalist. (come, hear)
2. How _____ they _____ to the word 'fatalist' in a small town? (come)
3. The Secretary of the Young Zionist Organization where I _____ Hebrew _____ me about it. (teach, tell)
4. It _____ during the Austrian occupation, and everyone _____ to learn German. (be, want)
5. I _____ through the window and _____ a short man, dark, in a derby and with curled moustache that _____ already long out of style. (look, see, be)
6. He _____ Polish, and he also _____ a kind of hedge lawyer. (learn, become)
7. He _____ that he _____ in God, but that all things were determined, every trifle. (say, not believe)
8. If you _____ in the street and _____ over a pebble, it was fated that you should fall. (walk, trip)
9. Everyone _____ this novel, and there _____ those among us who _____ to test their luck. (read, be, want)
10. The Fatalist _____ in love with her soon after he _____. (fall, arrive)

Exercise 4
Change the *voice* (See detailed description of *voice* in Chapter 1 on pp. 12-13):

1. He was carrying a briefcase.
2. She found something wrong in everybody.
3. You'll have to forgive me.
4. We all promised to keep the matter secret.
5. All this posed a great danger.
6. I'll never forget that day as long as I live.
7. Heyele could barely utter these words.
8. We realized how dangerous this could be.

GRAMMAR: PARTS OF SPEECH

Pronouns

A *pronoun* is typically a little word that stands in place of a *noun* or a *noun phrase*. Therefore, like nouns they can be subjects, objects and objects of prepositions in sentences. The main types of pronouns are as follows:

Personal pronouns: We use personal pronouns to refer back to someone or something that has already been mentioned. There are two sets of

personal pronouns for subject and object positions. We use 'you' or 'they' to refer to people in general.

For example, Rakhee loves Sushil and he loves her.
You should wear a helmet if you wish to be safe.

Reflexive pronouns: Also called reciprocal pronouns. We use a *reflexive pronoun* as object or complement when it refers to the same person or thing as the subject. For example,

I fell down and hurt myself.

Sometimes we use a reflexive for emphasis or to make the meaning clear. For example,

I bought these chocolates for myself.
The town itself is very ordinary.

Possessive pronouns: We use a *possessive pronoun* to express a relation, such as the fact that someone has something or that something belongs to someone. Possessive pronouns are often confused with possessive adjectives/ deteminers. For example,

This is my book. (Possessive adjective/determiner)
This book is mine. (Possessive pronoun)

Pronouns are used *in place of* nouns, while determiners are used *before* nouns.

Demonstrative pronouns: We use *demonstratives* to 'point' to something in the situation. 'This' and 'these' refer to something near the speaker, 'that' and 'those' to things further away, both in space and time. We can also use 'this' and 'that' when we identify someone. For example,

Mother, this is my friend Pushpinder.

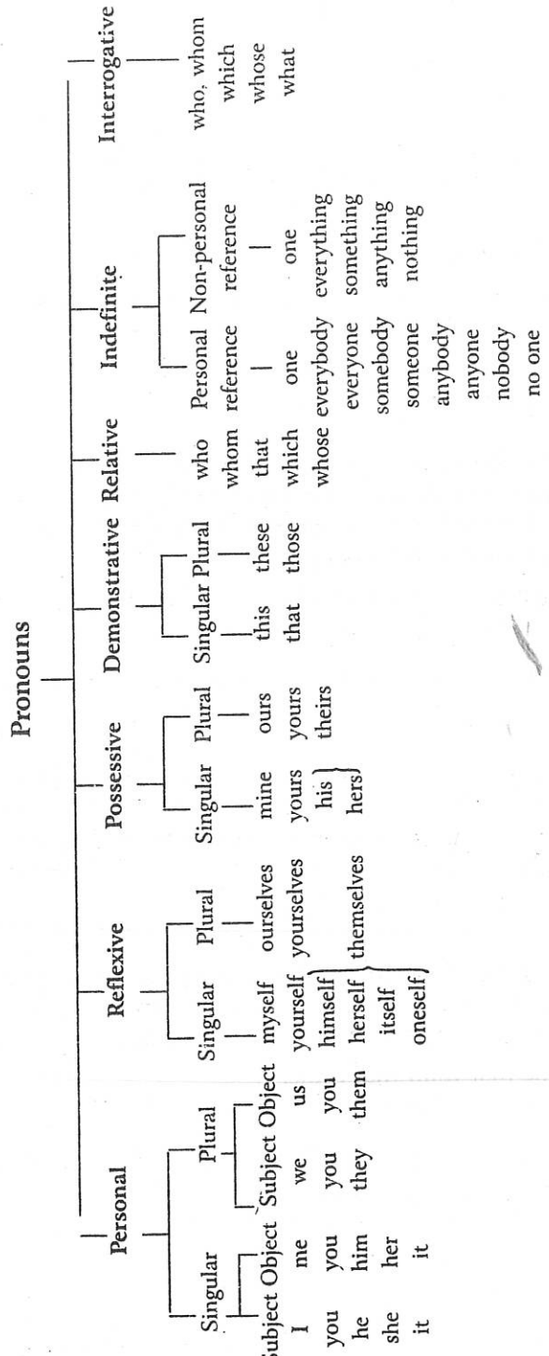
Relative pronouns: They are used to introduce relative clauses. We use 'who' or 'that' for people and 'which' or 'that' for things. These pronouns can be subject or object of the clause. For example,

We took the first train that came.
Do you know who she is working with?

Interrogative pronouns: Also called Wh-question words, they are used to ask open-ended questions, as different from yes-no questions where the responses are limited to yes or no. For example,

Did you beat her? Response: Yes/No
What is your name? Response: My name is . . . .

Indefinite pronouns: They refer to people or things without saying ex-



actly who or what they are. When an indefinite pronoun is the subject, it always takes a singular verb. However, we often use a plural pronoun to refer back to an indefinite pronoun. For example,

Ask anyone. They'll tell you.
Has everyone eaten as much as they want?

Exercise 1
In the given sentences locate the *nouns* and the *pronouns*. Also state the type to which each belongs.

1. There was a pier glass between the windows of the room.
2. There were two possessions of the James Dillingham Youngs.
3. So Della did it.
4. Once she faltered for a minute.
5. She fluttered out of the door and down the stairs to the street.
6. Della doubled the fob chain in her hand.
7. Jim drew a package from his overcoat pocket and threw it upon the table.
8. They were expensive combs, she knew, and her heart had simply craved and yearned over them.
9. She hugged them to her bosom.
10. Jim had not seen his beautiful present.
11. The magi, as you know, were wise men, wonderfully wise men, who brought gifts to the Babe in the manger.

Exercise 2
Fill in the blanks with *personal pronouns*:

Last night when my wife and I were returning home, a young boy stopped ___ and asked ___ the way to the chemist. ___ gave ___ directions and ___ thanked ___ politely, then ran off quickly in the opposite direction. ___ put my hand in my pocket and found that my wallet was missing. ___ felt cheated!

Exercise 3
Complete the following sentences by using one of the *indefinite pronouns* given in brackets:

1. No, thanks, I don't want ___. I'm not hungry. (nothing/anything)
2. The house was empty. There was ___ in it. (no one, anyone)
3. Does ___ need a lift? I'm leaving now. (nobody, anybody)
4. ___ wanted to know how the Indian team had performed. (anyone, everyone)
5. ___ went to see the film but ___ enjoyed it very much. (someone, no one, anyone, everyone)

Determiners

Determiners are words used before nouns which specify the range of reference of a noun in various ways. For example, by making it definite (the boy), indefinite (a boy), or by indicating quantity/number (many boys).

The choice of determiner is dependent on the type or nature of the noun it determines. There are three classes of common nouns relevant to the choice of determiners: they are *single countable nouns* (e.g. girl), *plural countable nouns* (e.g. girls), and uncountable or mass nouns (e.g. milk, music). Generally, proper nouns do not take determiners.

Determiners always precede the noun they determine, but they have different positions relative to one another. The most important category is that of *central determiners*. These *may* be preceded by *pre-determiners* and/or followed by *post-determiners*. The table below gives the category of words possible within each:

DETERMINERS

Pre-determiners	Central Determiners	Post-determiners
a. all, both, half	a. Articles: a, an, the	a. Cardinal numerals: one, two, etc.
b. double, twice, etc.	b. Demonstratives: this, these, that, those	b. Ordinal numbers: first, second, etc.
c. one-third, etc.	c. Possessives: my, your, his, etc.	c. General ordinals: next, last, other, etc.
d. what, such, etc.	d. Quantifiers: some, any, no, every, each, either, neither, enough, much	d. Quantifiers: many, few, little, several, more, less, etc.
	e. Wh-determiners: what(ever), which(ever), whoever, whose	

The categories are explicit and indicate clearly the category of words that can appear and the sequence in which they may appear. Attention must be paid to expressions like:

'a little' and 'little'
'a few' and 'few'

'A little' and 'a few' mean *some but not much/many*. The idea is positive.
'Little' and 'few' mean *nearly nothing* or *none*. The idea is negative.

For example, The Sharmas have *a little* money and send their children to school.
The Varmas have *little* money; they don't send their children to school.

Exercise 4
Study the table given above and fill in the blanks in the passage below with *determiners*:

He stared with mingled fear and irritation at _____ armed and bearded foreigners who had made themselves at home on _____ soil of France, and he felt in _____ heart _____ sort of fever of helpless patriotism and at _____same time _____ instinct of self-preservation, _____ newly acquired sense of prudence _____ has never left us since.

In _____ same compartment were _____ Englishmen who had come to France as sightseers, and who looked at everything with calm, inquisitive eyes. They were _____ very stout too, and chatted together in _____ own language, occasionally referring to _____ guidebook and reading out extracts aloud while trying to identify _____ places mentioned.

Exercise 5
Fill in the blanks with **much, many, a little** or **a few**

1. 'Does your friend speak German?' Yes, _____ '.
2. Sunita hasn't got _____ money.
3. Were there _____ people at the party?
4. 'Are there any shops in this area?' 'Yes, _____ '.
5. Shahid wasn't very hungry so he didn't eat _____ .

Exercise 6
Underline the *determiners* in the following paragraphs:

1. The villagers of little Hangleton still called it 'the Riddle House', even though it has been many years since the Riddle family had lived there. It stood on a hill overlooking the village, some of its windows boarded and ivy spreading unchecked over its face.
2. Jiji, no strength comes to you from that kitchen; nor from that necklace nor bangle nor forehead jewel. Authority cannot come to you from these things. How could you think that your strength came from food that was given in the appropriate measure and jewellery that weighs down your ears and neck and forehead?

Exercise 7
Fill in the blanks using appropriate *determiners* from those given in the brackets:

1. May I borrow _____ sugar? (a little/little)
2. We don't have _____information about him. (some/any)

3. This is the moment we have _____ been waiting for. (many/all)
4. _____ plan is ridiculous. It will never succeed. (the whole/all the)
5. _____ cricket team has eleven players. (each/every)
6. I was the _____ to come. The _____ student came a good fifteen minutes later. (one/next/first)
7. The hall looked empty. _____ the seats were taken. (all of/not all)
8. _____ summer, students leave the hostel and head for home _____ student has to carry his/her belongings. (each/every)

Exercise 8
Write sentences about the categories of people and things given. Use **both (of), all (of), neither** or **none (of)** in your own sentences.

For example: cricket, table-tennis, hockey
They are *all* popular games.

1. Aamir Khan and Shahrukh Khan.
2. You and your best friend.
3. Watching television and going to the movies.
4. You, your mother and your father.
5. Roses, marigolds, jasmine

5

THE CHILD

PREMCHAND

Premchand (1880–1936) was born in a small village called Lamhi, near Varanasi. His parents named him Dhanpat Rai Srivastava, but he adopted the pen name Premchand when his first collection of short stories, *Soze Watan*, was banned for its nationalist fervour. His childhood and youth were marked by extreme poverty and domestic problems. His first marriage was devoid of love but his second marriage turned out to be more successful.

A product of Indo-Persian culture, Premchand grew up in an atmosphere where both Hindi and Urdu were freely used in speech and writing. He began his career by writing in Urdu but turned to Hindi soon after. He wrote ten novels and around three hundred short stories, many of which have been translated into English. *Premashram, Seva-Sadan, Sapt-Saroj, Sangram, Ranga Bhoomi*, and *Godan* are some of his well-known works. He translated into Hindi George Bernard Shaw's *Back to Methuselah,* Anatole France's *Thais*, and short stories by Tolstoy and Maupassant.

Premchand was deeply influenced by Gandhi, Tolstoy, Gorky, Victor Hugo, and Romain Rolland. Although he was drawn to Karl Marx, he did not subscribe to revolutionary social change. When Gandhi launched the Non-cooperation Movement in 1920, he resigned from his government job and immersed himself in political and literary writings.

Premchand had an intimate knowledge of rural India and depicted the life of the peasantry with astonishing empathy and insight. His fiction is replete with characters of struggling peasants, cruel moneylenders, inhuman landlords and ill-treated widows. Premchand brought a new sense of social awareness and purpose to Hindi fiction. He had a progressive outlook and presided over the first session of the Progressive Writers' conference held in Lucknow in 1936. This supreme exponent of Hindi fiction died prematurely at the age of fifty-six, worn out by perpetual financial worries and chronic ill-health.

'The Child' revolves around the character of Gangu, a poor and 'old-fashioned' Brahmin servant, who works for the narrator. Apparently proud of his upper caste descent, Gangu maintains a certain distance from fellow servants. Even his master at times seems afraid of treating him with anything but utmost respect. One morning, however, Gangu surprises the narrator by informing him about his decision to marry Gomti, a local widow of doubtful reputation. Despite his master's attempts to dissuade him, Gangu marries Gomti. In an apparent confirmation of the master's belief that Gomti 'would not stick to him

for more than a few days', she runs away from home and is ultimately traced to a hospital in Lucknow where she is found to have given birth to a child. An ecstatic Gangu demonstrates great pride in Gomti's newborn baby, much to the perplexity of the narrator who cannot seem to ignore the fact that the couple had not been married for more than six months. Gangu, however, skirts the issue of paternity and declares his unqualified love for Gomti's baby, whom he chooses to see as a gift of God.

The story contrasts the narrator's unquestioning adherence to conventional morality with the remarkable equanimity with which Gangu lets his love for Gomti override a narrow societal preoccupation with sexual morality. Gangu's moral courage, compassion and his unflinching belief in the essential nobility of human kind cannot easily be challenged by implicit or explicit social pressures.

People call Gangu a Brahmin. He considers himself one, too. All my other servants bow to me. But Gangu never greets me like this. Probably he expects me to bow to him. He never touches any of the used utensils. I lack the courage to ask him even to fan me in the hot weather. Sometimes when nobody else is around and I am dripping with perspiration, he does pick up a fan, but his attitude is that he is doing me a great favour. He is short-tempered and cannot tolerate even the slightest rebuke. He has very few friends and considers it below his dignity to sit with the syce or the bearer. I have never seen him being friendly with anyone. Nor does he ever go to a fair or a show. He is not even fond of bhang, which is a common addiction amongst people of his class.

He never prays: nor does he go for a bath in the river; and he is completely illiterate. Yet he expects all the respect due to a Brahmin.

Why shouldn't he? If other people can claim respect on the basis of wealth left to them by their forefathers, surely Gangu can also claim respect on account of his ancestry.

I do not talk to my servants except when it is necessary. They have strict instructions not to invade my privacy unless they are sent for. Such small matters as getting a glass of water, or putting on the shoes, or lighting the lamp, I prefer to do myself rather than send for them. It gives me a feeling of independence and self-reliance. The servants know my habits by now and they seldom bother me.

If ever they pay an unsolicited visit to me it is either that they want an advance against their salary or that they wish to complain about other servants. Both these practices I consider reprehensible. When I pay them regularly and enough I do not see any reason why they should finish a month's salary in fifteen days. And backbiting I consider a sign of weakness or a mode of flattery both of which are ignoble.

One morning Gangu came to me without being sent for. I felt annoyed and asked him, irritably, what he had come for. From Gangu's face it appeared that he wanted to say something but in spite of his best efforts the words refused to come to the lips. I said again after a little pause, 'What is the matter? Why don't you speak out? You know it is getting late for my morning walk.' Gangu replied, haltingly, 'Please do not delay yourself. I shall come some other time.' This was worse, I knew. Now that I was in a hurry, Gangu would have cut short his tale. If he came when he thought I had more leisure he would perhaps waste my time for hours. He only considered me busy when I was reading or writing. When he found me just alone, sitting in a contemplative mood, he thought that I was merely idling. And it was almost certain that he would inflict himself on me in one of those moments, little realizing how precious they were for me.

I wanted to dispose of him right then and said, 'If you have come for an advance, you can rest assured that you will not get it.'

'I do not want an advance,' said Gangu, 'I have never asked you for one.'

'Then you must be wanting to complain against someone,' I said. 'You know how I hate backbiting.'

'No sir,' said Gangu, 'I have no complaints against any one.'

'What have you come to bother me about then?' I asked impatiently.

Gangu made another attempt to disclose his secret. I could see from his face that he was trying to muster up strength to do it. At last he said, 'I wish to be relieved of my duties, sir. I shall not be able to serve you any longer.'

This was the first request of its kind and I felt hurt. I was considered an ideal employer and the servants thought it their good fortune to stay on with me. 'Why do you want to leave?' I asked.

'You are the image of kindness, sir,' said Gangu. 'Who would want to leave you unless there was a very good reason? I find myself in a situation which leaves me with no other alternative. I do not want people to raise their fingers at you on my account.'

This was most intriguing. I forgot all about my morning walk and seating myself in a chair, said, 'Why do you talk in riddles? Why don't you say clearly what is on your mind?' Gangu replied haltingly again: 'Sir, the thing is that . . . that woman who has just been turned out of the Widows' Home . . . that Gomti Devi. . .' and he stopped without finishing the sentence. I asked impatiently, 'What has she to do with your job?'

'I want to marry her, sir,' said Gangu.

I looked at him in sheer bewilderment. How had this old-fashioned Brahmin, who had not even been touched by modern civilization,

decided to marry a woman, whom no self-respecting man would even allow near his house? Gomti had created quite a stir in the placid atmosphere of our mohalla. She had entered the Widows' Home some years ago. Twice the Home authorities had got her married off but both times she had come back after a week or so. Ultimately the Home had decided to expel her. She had now taken a room in the mohalla and was an object of great interest to all the lovelorn young men.

I felt both annoyed with and sympathetic towards Gangu. 'Why couldn't this stupid man find another woman to marry?' I said to myself. I was certain that she would not stick to him for more than a few days. If he had been better off financially, she might have stuck on for six months or so but now I was sure the marriage would not last more than a few days.

'Are you aware of her past?' I asked him.

'It's all lies, sir,' he said with great conviction. 'People have given her a bad name for nothing.'

'What nonsense!' I said, 'Can you deny that she has left three husbands?'

'What could she do,' replied Gangu unperturbed, 'if those people turned her out?'

'What a fool you are!' I added, 'Can you really believe that a man comes all the way to marry a woman, spends thousands of rupees on the marriage, only to turn her out in the end?'

Gangu replied almost with the zeal of a poet, 'Where there is no love, you cannot expect a woman to stay on. You cannot win a woman with mere board and lodging. Those people who married her thought that they were doing her a great favour by marrying a widow and took it for granted that she would do everything for their sake. But to win someone over one has first to forget about oneself. And besides, sir, she gets fits, sometimes, starts talking all sorts of nonsense and becomes unconscious. People say that she is under the influence of a witch.'

'And you want to marry such a woman,' I said. 'Don't you realize that you are asking for trouble?'

Gangu replied in the tone of a martyr, 'God willing, I shall make something of myself, if I get her.'

'So you have decided finally,' I asked him.

'Yes, sir,' he replied.

'All right,' I said, 'in that case I accept your resignation.'

Normally, I don't believe in old customs and meaningless traditions. In this particular case, however, I considered it definitely dangerous to keep in the house a man who was intent on marrying a woman of such doubtful reputation. It might lead to all sorts of complications.

To my mind, Gangu, in marrying this woman, was behaving like a starving man. That the piece of bread was dry and tasteless was immaterial to him. I considered it wise to keep aloof.

Five months passed. Gangu had married Gomti and was living in the same mohalla in a thatched hut. He was now earning a living as a hawker. Whenever I met him on the road, I stopped to enquire about his welfare. His life was a matter of great interest to me. I was impatient to know how it would all end. However, I always found him happy. His face had a glow which only comes with complete lack of worry. He earned about a rupee every day. After buying his stock, he was left with about ten annas or so. There must have been some supernatural power in those ten annas to give him such complete contentment.

One day I heard that Gomti had run away. I don't know why, but this gave me a great pleasure. It was perhaps that Gangu's self-confidence and ease had always made me envious. I was happy that I had been proved right, after all. He would now realize that the people who had dissuaded him from marrying Gomti were really his well-wishers. 'What a fool he was,' I thought to myself, 'to consider marrying Gomti a matter of good fortune, even to consider it as entering paradise.' I was impatient to meet him.

He looked completely shattered when I met him that afternoon. Seeing me he started to cry and said, 'Babuji, Gomti has left me.'

I replied with feigned sympathy, 'I told you in the beginning to keep away from her but you did not listen. Has she taken away your belongings also?'

Gangu put his hands on his heart as if I had blasphemed and said, 'Don't say that, Babuji, she hasn't taken a thing. Her own stuff is still lying here. I don't know what shortcomings she found in me that she decided to leave. I am sure I wasn't good enough for her. She was educated and I am an absolute illiterate. If I could have stayed on with her a little longer she would have made a man out of me. Whatever she might have been for other men, for me she was definitely a goddess. I must have been at fault somewhere that she decided to leave.'

I was most disappointed at Gangu's words. I had been certain that he would tell me a tale of faithlessness on the part of Gomti and that I would have to show sympathy towards him. But it seemed that this fool still had his eyes closed or perhaps he had lost his sense of perception. I said, half in jest, 'So she hasn't taken away anything from the house!'

'No, not even a penny's worth.'

'And she loved you very much?'

'What more can I say, Babuji? I shall not forget her till I die.'

'And yet she decided to leave you?'

'This is what surprises me.'

'Have you ever heard the old saying, "Frailty, thy name is woman".'

'Oh, don't say that, Babuji. I would never for a moment believe that in respect of her.'

'Then go and find her out if you are still so attached to her.'

'Yes, master, I won't get any respite till I have found her. If only I knew where to look for her! I am certain that she will come back to me. I must go and search for her. I will see you when I come back if I am still alive.' And saying this he went away.

After this incident I had to go to Nainital, and returned after nearly a month. I had barely taken off my clothes when I saw Gangu standing with a new-born baby. He was bursting with joy. Even Nanda could not have felt such joy at getting Krishna. His face had the same glow that appears on the face of a starved man after a full meal. I asked him again in jest, 'Have you had any news of Gomti Devi? I believe you went in search of her.' Gangu said, beaming with joy, 'I have found her at last, Babuji. She was in the Women's Hospital in Lucknow. She had told a friend here that if I was very upset I should be informed about her whereabouts. As soon as I heard it I went to Lucknow and brought her back. I have also got this child in the bargain.' He showed me the child almost with the pride of an athlete showing off a newly won medal.

I was surprised at his shamelessness. He had not been married to Gomti for more than six months and yet he was displaying the child with great pride. I said tauntingly, 'Oh, so you have got a boy also. That is perhaps why she ran away. Are you sure this is your child?'

'Why mine, Babuji, it is God's.'

'It was born in Lucknow, wasn't it?'

'Yes, Babuji, it was a month old only yesterday.'

'How long have you been married?'

'This is the seventh month.'

'So this child was born within six months of your marriage.'

'Yes,' said Gangu, undisturbed.

'And still you consider it your child?'

'Yes, sir.'

'Are you in your senses?' I asked. I was not quite certain whether he did not understand what I was trying to hint at or whether he was intentionally misunderstanding me.

'She had a very difficult time,' said Gangu in the same tone.

'It is almost a new life for her, Babuji. For full three days and three nights she was in pain. Oh, it was unbearable.'

This was the point for me to interrupt and I said, 'This is the first time I have heard of a child being born within six months of marriage.'

This question surprised Gangu; he said with an impish smile, 'This has never bothered me. This was the reason perhaps why Gomti had left the house. I told her that if she did not love me she could leave me by all means and I would never bother her again. But if she did love me she must not let the child separate us. I would love it as my own. After all, when one takes a harvested field one does not refuse the crop merely because someone else has sown it.'

He gave a hearty laugh.

I was most touched by Gangu's sentiments and felt an utter fool. I extended my hands, took the child from Gangu and kissed it. Gangu said, 'Babuji, you are the embodiment of goodness. I often talk to Gomti about you and have many times asked her to come and pay her respects to you. But she is so bashful.'

I, the embodiment of goodness! My middle-class morality stood ashamed at Gangu's courage and sincerity.

'You are the embodiment of goodness,' I said, 'and this child adds charm to it. Let me come with you and meet Gomti.' And we both went to Gangu's house.

NOTES

bow	:	bend the head or body as a sign of respect or as a greeting
ˌperspi'ration	:	sweat
re'buke	:	reprove, express sharp disapproval
syce	:	an Arabic word meaning 'a person in charge of horses'
'ancestry	:	line of ancestors
ˌself-re'liance	:	dependence on one's own ability
ˌunso'licited	:	which has not been asked for
ˌrepre'hensible	:	(of a person's behaviour) very bad, deserving blame
ig'noble	:	shameful
'irritable	:	easily annoyed or made angry
'haltingly	:	slowly or hesitantly, as if lacking in confidence
'leisure	:	spare time
con'templative	:	thoughtful
inflict oneself on somebody	:	force somebody to accept one's unwelcome presence
dis'close	:	make something known
'muster up	:	gather together
in'triguing	:	fascinating, full of interest, unusual
'riddle	:	puzzling question, statement or description
sheer	:	complete, thorough
be'wilderment	:	state of being puzzled
'placid	:	calm and peaceful
'lovelorn	:	unhappy because one's love is not returned
ˌunper'turbed	:	not feeling agitated

zeal	:	great enthusiasm
'martyr	:	person who is killed or made to suffer greatly because of his beliefs
a'loof	:	keeping oneself away, taking no part (in some activity or development)
con'tentment	:	state of being satisfied with what one has
'shattered	:	shocked, heartbroken
feign	:	pretend
blas'pheme	:	speak in a disrespectful way about God or sacred things
per'ception	:	ability to understand
'frailty	:	weakness in character or morals
beaming	:	happy, smiling
tauntingly	:	making unkind remarks intended to hurt or provoke
'impish	:	mischievous
'bashful	:	shy and self-conscious

COMPREHENSION

1. Up to what level was Gangu educated?
2. Why did Gangu want to leave his job?
3. What was the narrator's reaction when he learnt about Gangu's decision to marry Gomti?
4. What was people's opinion about Gomti?
5. What was Gangu's state of mind after his marriage to Gomti?
6. Why did Gomti run away barely six months after her marriage?
7. Where was Gomti found after her disappearance?
8. How did Gangu accept the child born within six months of his marriage to Gomti?

COMPOSITION

1. How did Gangu defend his decision to marry Gomti?
2. Describe Gangu's life in the first six months of his marriage to Gomti?
3. What opinion do you form of Gomti's character from a reading of the story?
4. How does the story treat the question of morality?
5. Draw a character sketch of Gangu.
6. Why does the narrator call Gangu 'the embodiment of goodness' at the end? Does it mark any change in his attitude towards Gangu and his affairs?

Exercise 1
Fill in the blanks with appropriate *prepositions*:

1. It gives me a feeling _____ independence and self-reliance.
2. What has she to do _____ your job?

3. I looked _____ him _____ sheer bewilderment.
4. Gomti had created quite a stir _____ the placid atmosphere _____ our mohalla.
5. I felt both annoyed _____ and sympathetic _____ Gangu.
6. Gangu replied almost _____ the zeal _____ a poet.
7. People say that she is _____ the influence _____ a witch.
8. Whenever I met him _____ the road, I stopped to enquire _____ his welfare.
9. He would now realize that the people who had dissuaded him _____ marrying Gomti were really his well-wishers.
10. He was bursting _____ joy.

Exercise 2
Change the *voice:*

1. People call Gangu a Brahmin.
2. He never touches any of the used utensils.
3. I have never seen him being friendly with anyone.
4. Gangu made another attempt to disclose his secret.
5. You cannot win a woman with mere board and lodging.
6. I considered it wise to keep aloof.
7. However, I always found him happy.
8. He earned about a rupee every day.

Exercise 3
Change the *narration:*

1. I said again after a little pause, "What is the matter? Why don't you speak out?"
2. "I do not want an advance," said Gangu, "I have never asked you for one."
3. "What have you come to bother me about then?" I asked impatiently.
4. At last he said, "I wish to be relieved of my duties, sir."
5. "Why do you want to leave?" I asked.
6. "1 want to marry her, sir," said Gangu.
7. "Why couldn't this stupid man find another woman to marry?" I said to myself.
8. "Are you aware of her past?" I asked him.

Exercise 4
Fill in the blanks with proper tense form of the *verbs* given in brackets:

1. He never _____ any of the _____ utensils. (touch, use)
2. Sometimes when nobody else is around and I am _____ with perspiration, he does pick up a fan, but his attitude is that he is _____ me a great favour. (drip, do)

3. From Gangu's face it _____ that he _____ to say something but in spite of his best efforts the words _____ to come to the lips. (appear, want, refuse)
4. This was worse, I _____. (know)
5. He only _____ me busy when I was _____ or _____. (consider, read, write)
6. When he _____ me just alone, sitting in a contemplative mood he _____ that I was merely idling. (find, think)
7. Why _____ you _____ to leave? (want)
8. I _____ myself in a situation which _____ me with no other alternative. (find, leave)
9. Gomti _____ quite a stir in the placid atmosphere of our mohalla. (create)
10. One day I _____ that Gomti _____ away. (hear, run)

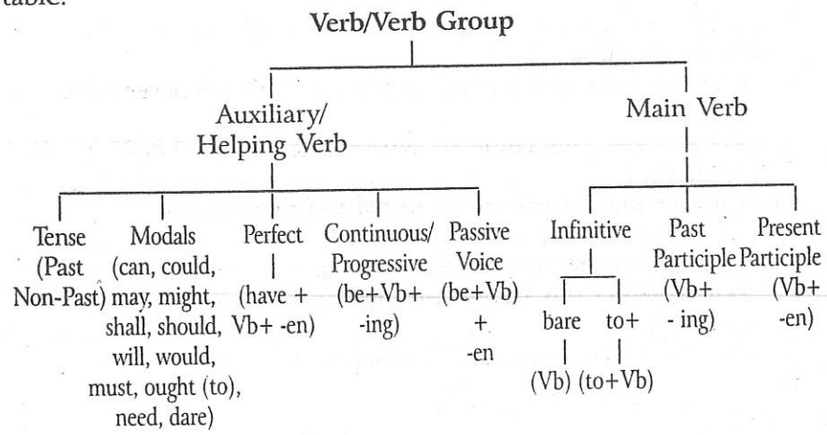
GRAMMAR: PARTS OF SPEECH

Verbs

The *verb* is the most important part of a sentence; one cannot have a sentence without a verb. Typically verbs are action words—they express actions or states. Less typically, verbs may express meanings such as events, habits, tendencies and relationships between people and things.

For example: run, sleep, drink, exist, be, ought to, express

Information regarding types and forms of verbs is given in the following table.



Auxiliary verbs

Auxiliary verbs are, as their name suggests, 'helping verbs'. They do not make up a verb group alone but must be accompanied by a main verb.

Auxiliary verbs are a small class of words—modals, be, have and do.

All sentences have *tense* but need not have the other aspects of the auxiliary. However, *the order within the auxiliary is fixed and cannot be changed.* If you decide to have more than one, you must use them in the order given above.

For example, Renu has been working in Delhi since 1988.
He could have waited for me.

Please note that *tense* is a grammatical concept; time and tense do not mean the same things. There isn't a neat one-to-one correspondence between the forms of the verb (given in the table above) used to form different types of tenses and the units of time. For example, in English future time can be shown by 'will/shall+verb' as well as the present continuous tense.

For example, The train will leave at 5.30.
The train is leaving at 5.30.

Modals

Language is not always used just to impart information by making simple statements and asking questions. Sometimes we want to make requests or suggestions, or to express our wishes or intentions. We may want to be polite or tactful, or to indicate our feelings about what we are saying.

We can do all these things by using a set of verbs called *modals*. Modals are always used in combination with other verbs. They are sometimes called **modal verbs** or **modal auxiliaries**. Modals consist of four paired forms—*can, could*; *may, might*; *shall, should*; *will, would*; and four simple forms—*must, ought (to), need, dare.* In some grammars, 'used to' is also referred to as a modal. In some contexts 'could', 'would' and 'might' function like past tense form of 'can', 'will' and 'may' respectively (for example, in indirect speech). But they also have other important functions, in polite requests, etc., even in the context of present time, for example: 'Would you lend me your pen?' 'Could you open the window, please?' They may also be used to refer to future time, e.g.: 'I could come tomorrow.' The modal verbs 'need' and 'dare' differ from other modals in that 'dare' can follow the grammatical patterns of either modal auxiliaries or regular verbs, while the modal 'need' contrasts grammatically with the regular verb 'to need'.

Special Features of Modals

(i) Modals are followed by the infinitive of a verb without 'to' (except in the case of 'ought' which is always followed by 'to')
(ii) No –s is added to modals even in case of third person singular subject in the present tense, unlike regular verbs.

(iii) Negatives are formed by adding 'not' after the modal verb.
(iv) Interrogatives are formed by placing the modal before the subject.

The Uses of Modal Auxiliaries

Modal		*What it indicates*	*Examples*
Can	(i)	Ability	He can speak French but he can't write it.
	(ii)	Permission	Can I take your book?
	(iii)	Theoretical possibility (In this respect it contrasts with 'may' which indicates factual possibility: 'He may not come today'.)	Anybody can make mistakes.
Could	(i)	Past ability	I could swim for hours when I was young.
	(ii)	Present or future permission	Could I use your telephone? (Seeking permission) You could use my telephone. (Granting permission)
	(iii)	Present possibility (theoretical or factual)	The road could be open to traffic.
	(iv)	Ability in unreal conditions	If we had more time, we could decorate the hall more beautifully.
May	(i)	Permission (used in more formal situations)	You may leave if it makes you happy. (Granting permission) May I come in? (Seeking permission)
	(ii)	Possibility	It may rain tonight.
	(iii)	Wish	May you live long and happily!
Might	(i)	Past equivalent of 'may'	I thought he might still be there.
	(ii)	Possibility	Your version might be true.
	(iii)	Suggestion or request	You might make a little less noise.
Shall	(i)	Intention (only with 1st person)	I shall be leaving soon.
	(ii)	Insistence (when used with 2nd person or 3rd person subject)	You shall not open this letter.
	(iii)	Formal instructions/ legal or quasi-legal injunctions	Students shall always carry their Identity Cards.
	(iv)	Offers or suggestions in questions (with 1st person subject)	Shall I make you a cup of tea?
Should	(i)	Obligation	You should obey traffic rules.
	(ii)	Supposition that may not be true	If you should change your mind, please let us know.

	(iii)	A tentative conclusion	The roads should be less crowded today.
Will	(i)	Future possibility or likelihood	You'll be able to catch the bus if you hurry.
	(ii)	Intention	I'll visit Rohtang Pass this summer.
	(iii)	Request with 2nd and 3rd person subjects	Will you please switch off the fan?
	(iv)	Insistence on the part of the subject	He will keep interrupting me, even though he knows I don't like it.
	(v)	Timeless prediction/ General truth	Oil will float on water.
Would	(i)	Polite request	Would you help me with this sum, please?
	(ii)	Characteristic activity in the past	He would sit for hours listening to music.
	(iii)	Past equivalent of 'will'	He said that he would help me in my new business.
	(iv)	Probability	That would be the postman, I think.
	(v)	hypothetical action or event in the past	If I had been more careful, I would not have lost my bag.
Must	(i)	Obligation or compulsion	You must report at 10 a.m. sharp in my office.
	(ii)	Logical conclusion	They resemble so much that they must be twins.
Ought to	(i)	Moral obligation or desirability	We ought to be straight in our dealings.
Used to	(i)	Discontinued habit	I used to play the violin when I was studying in school.
Need	(i)	Necessity or obligation (generally used in negative or interrogative sentences. The regular verb 'need' is used in affirmative statements, e.g.: 'He needs to work hard.')	You need not do this work today. Need I write to him?
Dare	(i)	Be brave enough to (generally used in negative or interrogative sentences)	How dare you contradict me? I dare not ask her for a favour.

Transitive and Intransitive Verbs

Verbs are also classified as *Transitive* and *Intransitive verbs*.

Transitive verbs are those which require an object. In the sentence 'She wrote a letter' the verb 'wrote' is transitive and the word 'letter' is the object. A transitive verb can take two objects—direct and indirect.

For example, She wrote a letter to me.
| |
direct indirect
object object

Intransitive verbs are those which require no object. In the sentence 'He died suddenly' the verb 'died' is intransitive; there is no object after it; 'suddenly' is an adverb. Sentences with intransitive verbs cannot be changed into passive voice.

For example, Birds fly.
Geeta swims well.

Phrasal Verbs

Phrasal Verbs (sometimes called multi-word verbs) are verbs that consist of two or sometimes three words. The first word is a 'verb' and it is followed by a 'particle' which is either an adverb or a preposition. *A phrasal verb functions as a verb.*

Examples: *look up, look into, get by, give up, put up with.*

The meaning of some phrasal verbs is easy to guess because the 'verb' and the 'particle' keep their usual meaning (as in the case of 'fall down') but many phrasal verbs have idiomatic meaning (for example: *bring up, look into, look out!*)

Phrasal verbs can be *transitive* or *intransitive*. Some phrasal verbs can be used in both ways.

Study the *phrasal verbs* in the following sentences:

Suddenly all the lights went out. (Intransitive)
I threw away my old pajamas. (Transitive)
The problem won't just go away. (Intransitive)
The accident held up the traffic for an hour. (Transitive)

Finite and Non-Finite Verbs

A *finite verb* in English is a form of a verb that shows *agreement* with a *subject* and is marked for *tense*. All kinds of verbs, including *main verbs, auxiliary, transitive* and *intransitive* verbs can be in either finite or non-finite form. For example,

The bus stops here.
My friend and I walk to college.

Non-finite verbs include *infinitives, gerunds* and *participles*. They do not change or show agreement with the subject and are not marked for tense:

I love to eat ice-creams in summer.
She loves to eat ice-cream in summer.

Infinitive

A simple *infinitive* is the base form of a verb, with or without *to*. Which one of the two we use depends on the grammatical pattern. For example,

I'd rather sit at the back.
I'd prefer to sit at the back.

In the negative, *not* comes before the infinitive.

For example, I'd rather not sit at the back.

The infinitive can function as the subject, object or complement in a sentence.

For example, To sit here in the sun is foolish. (subject)
I don't want to sit here all day. (object)

Gerund and Present Participle

Gerund and *Present Participle* have the same form (verb+ -ing) but a gerund is a verbal noun whereas a present participle is a verbal adjective. The present participle can also function as an adverb. The gerund can function as the 'subject', 'object' or 'complement' in a sentence.

Smoking is a bad habit. (Gerund as subject)
You should stop talking. (Gerund as object)
Look at the girl wearing the red sari. (Adjectival clause)
Being tired, he fell off to sleep. (Adverbial clause)

Present participle is used in the *continuous tense*. It is also used in compound words. For example, *dining* table, *dancing* girl.

Past Participles are non-finite forms used to form the *perfect* tense and the *passive* voice. For many verbs, the *past tense* and *past participle* forms are identical. However, to describe the formation of past participle it is said that *–en* is added to the verb. For example, written, bitten, sunk, drunk, seen, etc. The past participle can also function as an adjective. For example, a *wounded* soldier, *broken* furniture, *written* word.

Exercise 1
Complete the following sentences by selecting appropriate *present participles* of the verbs from the given list. Make changes in spellings, wherever necessary.

bark	abuse	set	study
drive	promise	thunder	listen
learn			

Example: abuse ⟶ abusing
1. _____ clouds ruined the prospects of a bright day.

2. The _____ sun presented a beautiful sight.
3. _____ dogs seldom bite.
4. The students were _____ in the college library.
5. I heard him _____ Sohan.
6. She likes _____ to gazals and thumris.
7. Students love _____ English.
8. He learnt _____ in a driving school.
9. The manager was _____ his workers a holiday.

Exercise 2
Complete the following sentences by selecting an appropriate *bare infinitive* or *to infinitive* form of the verb from the given list:

live	succeed	go	serve
meet	leave	see	increase
be	meet	taste	give up

1. He was told _____ bad habits.
2. You need not _____ there.
3. He forbade me _____ it.
4. The farmer made every effort _____ production.
5. He is a man _____ avoided.
6. We went _____ the match.
7. I was glad _____ him in the party.
8. We eat _____ .
9. The mango was sweet _____ .
10. It is good _____ the poor.
11. The train is about _____ the station.
12. He hoped _____ in life.

Exercise 3
Complete the following sentences by selecting an appropriate *gerund* from the given list. You can use one word twice:

talking	smoking	gambling	eating
reading	drinking	swimming	sleeping
driving			

1. _____ is a good exercise.
2. They stopped _____ aloud in the class.
3. _____ is prohibited in this bar.
4. _____ is injurious to health.
5. This book is worth _____ .
6. _____ is not allowed on the Mall.
7. They like _____ till late in the morning.

8. _____ ruined his family life.
9. They disliked _____ at roadside dhabas.
10. _____ is a good habit.

Exercise 4
Fill in the blanks with *modals*—**must/could/would/might/cannot:**

1. It's a lovely film. You _____ see it.
2. If he came when he thought I had more leisure he _____ perhaps waste my time for hours.
3. 'What _____ she do,' replied Gangu unperturbed, 'if those people turned her out?'
4. You _____ win a woman with mere board and lodging.
5. It _____ lead to all sorts of complications.

Exercise 5
Fill in the blanks with appropriate *modals:*

1. I was impatient to know how it _____ all end.
2. There _____ have been some supernatural power in those ten annas to give him such complete contentment.
3. Whatever she _____ have been for other men, for me she was definitely a goddess.
4. I _____ not forget her till I die.
5. Even Nanda _____ not have felt such joy at getting Krishna.

Part II
ESSAYS

6

WORK IN THE SUN AND IN THE LIGHT

JAWAHARLAL NEHRU

Jawaharlal Nehru (1889–1964) was born in Allahabad. His father Motilal Nehru was a highly successful lawyer, who loved to live in great style. Jawaharlal had a very privileged upbringing. He was educated at home by a host of English governesses and private tutors until he was admitted to Harrow at the age of sixteen. In 1907 he went to Trinity College, Cambridge, where he took the Tripos in Natural Sciences—Chemistry, Geology and Botany. In order to qualify as a barrister he joined the Inner Temple, London, and was called to the Bar in 1912.

He returned to India at a time when Indian politics was taking a new turn under Gandhiji's leadership. The bloodbath in Jallianwala Bagh had shaken the entire nation. Jawaharlal could not resist the call of the Nationalist Movement and plunged into the freedom struggle. His rise in Indian politics was meteoric and he was nominated by Gandhiji as his political heir. He was elected Congress President five times and became the first Prime Minister of Independent India, continuing in this post till his death in 1964.

Nehru was the architect of India's foreign policy. He pioneered the Non-Aligned Movement and helped establish the Commonwealth of Nations. He set the country on the path of rapid industrialization. He had a scientific bent of mind and a number of scientific laboratories and the Atomic Energy Commission were set up during his tenure.

Nehru was a prolific writer with an enviable command over the English language which he used with the ease and facility of an Englishman. His language becomes poetic when he describes nature or landscape; conversational in his personal letters and jail diaries; in his addresses, forceful, penetrating and occasionally scholastic. *Discovery of India, Glimpses of World History, A Bunch of Old Letters*, and *Autobiography* are some of his major works which are as thought-provoking in terms of their content as they are charming in their style.

Nehru frequently interacted with his daughter through letters. The present piece, reproduced from *Glimpses of World History*, was written to Indira on her thirteenth birthday from the Central Prison at Naini, where Nehru was being held at the time. Although Nehru regrets his inability to present a material birthday gift to his daughter, his present 'of the air and of the mind and spirit' in

the form of a loving letter written in lucid prose, certainly seeks to stir the seeds of greatness in Indira.

Expressing his dislike for sermonizing, Nehru recounts the story of a conceited man from Hiuen Tsang's travelogue to illustrate our limitations in attaining wisdom. Reminding Indira of her childhood ambition to be like Jeanne d'Arc, he places before her examples of two legendary figures of the time—Lenin and Bapu Gandhi—who played epoch-making roles in inspiring millions of people to act heroically and selflessly. Impressing upon Indira the need for honourable conduct, Nehru makes it clear that in the struggle for Independence whatever role we may be called upon to play, it must always be kept in mind that we do no such thing 'which may bring discredit to our cause or dishonour to our people.' The letter ends on an optimistic note that if Indira 'works in the sun and in the light' she will grow into 'a child of the light, unafraid and serene and unruffled.'

FOR INDIRA PRIYADARSHINI ON HER THIRTEENTH BIRTHDAY

Central Prison, Naini
October 26,* 1930

On your birthday you have been in the habit of receiving presents and good wishes. Good wishes you will still have in full measure, but what presents can I send you from Naini Prison? My presents cannot be very material or solid. They can only be of the air and of the mind and spirit, such as a good fairy might have bestowed on you—things that even the high walls of prison cannot stop.

You know, sweetheart, how I dislike sermonizing and doling out good advice. When I am tempted to do this, I always think of the story of a 'very wise man' I once read. Perhaps one day you will yourself read the book which contains this story. Thirteen hundred years ago there came a great traveller from China to India in search of wisdom and knowledge. His name was Hiuen Tsang, and over the deserts and mountains of the north he came, braving many dangers, facing and overcoming many obstacles, so great was his thirst for knowledge. And he spent many years in India learning himself and teaching others, especially at the great university of Nalanda, which existed then near the city that used to be called Patliputra and is now known as Patna. Hiuen Tsang became very learned himself and he was given the title of 'Master of the Law'—the Law of the Buddha—and he journeyed all over India and saw and studied the people that lived in this great country in those far-off days. Later he wrote a book of his travels, and it is this book which contains the story that comes to my mind. It is about a man from South India who came to

* Indira's birthday takes place on November 19. In 1930 it was observed on October 26, according to the *Samvat* era.

(Source of information: *Glimpses of World History*, p. 1)

Karnasuvarna, which was a city somewhere near modern Bhagalpur in Bihar; and this man, it is written, wore round his waist copper-plates, and on his head he carried a lighted torch. Staff in hand, with proud bearing and lofty steps, he wandered about in this strange attire. And when anyone asked him the reason for his curious get-up, he told him that his wisdom was so great that he was afraid his belly would burst if he did not wear copper-plates round it; and because he was moved with pity for the ignorant people round about him, who lived in darkness, he carried the light on his head.

Well, I am quite sure that there is no danger of my ever bursting with too much wisdom and so there is no need for me to wear copper-plates or armour. And in any event, I hope that my wisdom, such of it as I possess, does not live in my belly. Wherever it may reside, there is plenty of room still for more of it and there is no chance of there being no room left. If I am so limited in wisdom, how can I pose as a wise man and distribute good advice to others? And so I have always thought that the best way to find out what is right and what is not right, what should be done and what should not be done, is not by giving a sermon, but by talking and discussing, and out of discussion sometimes a little bit of truth comes out. I have liked my talks with you and we have discussed many things, but the world is wide and beyond our world lie other wonderful and mysterious worlds, so none of us need ever be bored or imagine, like the very foolish and conceited person whose story Hiuen Tsang has told us, that we have learned everything worth learning and become very wise. And perhaps it is as well that we do not become very wise; for the very wise, if any such there are, must sometimes feel rather sad that there is nothing more to learn. They must miss the joy of discovery and of learning new things—the great adventure that all of us who care to may have.

I must not therefore sermonize. But what am I to do, then? A letter can hardly take the place of a talk; at best it is a one-sided affair. So, if I say anything that sounds like good advice, do not take it as if it were a bad pill to swallow. Imagine that I have made a suggestion to you for you to think over, as if we really were having a talk.

In history we read of great periods in the life of nations, of great men and women and great deeds performed, and sometimes in our dreams and reveries we imagine ourselves back in those times and doing brave deeds like the heroes and heroines of old. Do you remember how fascinated you were when you first read the story of Jeanne d'Arc, and how your ambition was to be something like her? Ordinary men and women are not usually heroic. They think of their daily bread and butter, of their children, of their household worries and the like. But a time comes when a whole people become full of

faith for a great cause, and then even simple, ordinary men and women become heroes, and history becomes stirring and epoch-making. Great leaders have something in them which inspires a whole people and makes them do great deeds.

The year you were born in—1917—was one of the memorable years of history when a great leader, with a heart full of love and sympathy for the poor and suffering, made his people write a noble and never-to-be- forgotten chapter of history. In the very month in which you were born, Lenin started the great Revolution which has changed the face of Russia and Siberia. And today in India another great leader, also full of love for all who suffer and passionately eager to help them, has inspired our people to great endeavour and noble sacrifice so that they may again be free and the starving and the poor and the oppressed may have their burdens removed from them. Bapuji lies in prison, but the magic of his message steals into the hearts of India's millions, and men and women, and even little children, come out of their little shells and become India's soldiers of freedom. In India today we are making history, and you and I are fortunate to see this happening before our eyes and to take some part ourselves in this great drama.

How shall we bear ourselves in this great movement? What part shall we play in it? I cannot say what part will fall to our lot; but, whatever it may be, let us remember that we can do nothing which may bring discredit to our cause or dishonour to our people. If we are to be India's soldiers we have India's honour in our keeping, and that honour is a sacred trust. Often we may be in doubt as to what to do. It is no easy matter to decide what is right and what is not. One little test I shall ask you to apply whenever you are in doubt. It may help you. Never do anything in secret or anything that you would wish to hide. For the desire to hide anything means that you are afraid, and fear is a bad thing and unworthy of you. Be brave, and all the rest follows. If you are brave, you will not fear and will not do anything of which you are ashamed. You know that in our great Freedom Movement, under Bapuji's leadership, there is no room for secrecy or hiding. We have nothing to hide. We are not afraid of what we do and what we say. We work in the sun and in the light. Even so in our private lives let us make friends with the sun and work in the light and do nothing secretly or furtively. Privacy, of course, we may have and should have, but that is a very different thing from secrecy. And if you do so, my dear, you will grow up a child of the light, unafraid and serene and unruffled, whatever may happen.

I have written a very long letter to you. And yet there is so much I would like to tell you. How can a letter contain it?

You are fortunate, I have said, in being a witness to this great struggle for freedom that is going on in our country. You are also very fortunate in having a very brave and wonderful little woman for your Mummie, and if you are ever in doubt or in trouble you cannot have a better friend.

Good-bye, little one, and may you grow up into a brave soldier in India's service.

With all my love and good wishes.

NOTES

'sermonize : A sermon is a talk on a moral or religious subject usually given by a priest during a religious service—to sermonize is to moralize, to lecture

dole out : to distribute something in small amounts

staff : a long stick used as a support when walking or climbing, as a weapon, or as a symbol of authority or sign of office

'bearing : behaviour, a person with a 'proud bearing' refers to someone whose behaviour suggests that he/she thinks he/she is better or more important than others

'armour : a protective covering for the body, worn when fighting, usually made of metal

con'ceited : to have too good an opinion of oneself

'reverie : a pleasant state of dreamy thought

'stirring : exciting

Jeanne d'Arc : St Joan of Arc (1412–31), a French saint and national heroine, known as 'the Maid of Orleans'. She led the French armies against the English in the Hundred Years War. She was captured by the English and burnt as a heretic, but was canonized in 1920.

epoch-making : important and remarkable enough to change the course of history and begin a new epoch (period, era)

'Lenin : Vladimir Ilyich Lenin (1870–1924) was a Russian revolutionary leader. Founder of the Soviet Union, he led the Bolshevik revolution in October 1917.

en'deavour : effort

come out of one's shell : cease to be shy

'furtively : done secretly and quietly so as not to be noticed

un'ruffled : calm, undisturbed

COMPREHENSION

1. Where did Nehru write the letter from?
2. What 'present of the air and of the mind and spirit' does Nehru send Indira on her birthday?
3. Which great Chinese traveller visited India thirteen hundred years ago?
4. What did the man mentioned in Hiuen Tsang's book wear on his belly and carry on his head and why?
5. What did the strange-looking man fear?
6. Which great leader led the Russian Revolution?

7. What test does Nehru suggest to Indira to decide what is right and what is wrong?
8. In what manner does Nehru expect Indira to grow?
9. Why does Nehru call Indira 'fortunate'?

COMPOSITION

1. Summarise the story of a 'very wise man' which appears in Hiuen Tsang's book. What lessons do you draw from this story?
2. How do ordinary men and women usually act? What makes them do great deeds?
3. There are moments when we are in doubt as to what we should do. How can we resolve this dilemma?
4. Explain: 'We work in the sun and in the light.'

Exercise 1

Fill in the blanks with appropriate tense form of the *verbs* given in brackets:

1. When I am _____ to do this, I always _____ of the story of a 'very wise man' I once _____. (tempt, think, read)
2. Perhaps one day you _____ yourself _____ the book which _____ this story. (read, contain)
3. Later he _____ a book of his travels, and it _____ this book which _____ the story that _____ to my mind. (write, be, contain, come)
4. I _____ that my wisdom, such of it as I _____, _____ in my belly. (hope, possess, not live)
5. If I _____ so limited in wisdom, how can I _____ as a wise man and _____ good advice to others. (be, pose, distribute)
6. I _____ my talks with you and we _____ many things. (like, discuss)
7. _____ you remember how fascinated you _____ when you first _____ the story of Jeanne d'Arc? (do, be, read)
8. Great leaders have something in them which _____ a whole people and _____ them do great deeds. (inspire, make)
9. In the very month in which you _____ born, Lenin _____ the great Revolution which _____ the face of Russia and Siberia. (be, start, change)
10. Bapuji _____ in prison but the magic of his message _____ into the hearts of India's millions. (lie, steal)

Exercise 2

Fill in the blanks with appropriate *prepositions:*

1. Good wishes you will still have _____ full measure.
2. Thirteen hundred years ago there came a great traveller _____ China _____ India _____ search _____ wisdom and knowledge.
3. If I am so limited _____ wisdom, how can I pose as a wise man and distribute good advice _____ others.

4. In history we read _____ great periods _____ the life _____ nations.
5. They think _____ their daily bread and butter, _____ their children, _____ their household worries and the like.
6. Great leaders have something _____ them which inspires a whole people and makes them do great deeds.
7. Bapuji lies _____ prison but the magic _____ his message steals _____ the heart of India's millions.
8. You know that _____ our great Freedom Movement, _____ Bapuji's leadership, there is no room _____ secrecy or hiding.
9. We are not afraid _____ what we do and what we say.

GRAMMAR: PARTS OF SPEECH

Adjectives

Adjectives tell us more about nouns. There are two main positions for adjectives: in front of a noun, or as the complement of a link verb. There is usually a fixed order of adjectives before a noun.

For example, a large empty house; her new red dress.

Adjectives can be categorised in the following manner.

1. Opinion: nice, wonderful, excellent, lovely, terrible, awful, etc.
2. Size: large, small, long, short, tall, etc.
3. Quality: clear, busy, famous, important, quiet, etc.
4. Age: old, new.
5. Shape: round, square, fat, thin, narrow, etc.
6. Colour: white, green, red, purple, etc.
7. Participle Form: torn, broken, drinking, sewing, etc.
8. Origin: Indian, American, British, etc.
9. Material: wooden, brick, paper, plastic, etc.
10. Type: human, chemical, domestic, financial, etc.
11. Purpose: alarm (clock); tennis (club); frying (pan), etc.

When two adjectives have similar meanings, the shorter one often comes first. For example, a large comfortable chair; a bright, cheerful smile.

Adjectives generally take the *comparative* (-er) and the *superlative* (-est) forms:

warm	warmer	warmest
nasty	nastier	nastiest
carefree	more carefree	most carefree

(*Note*: The superlative form is usually preceded by 'the' in a sentence or a phrase.)

Adjectives go with *intensifiers* like *very* and *quite*:

very comfortable quite nasty

Adverbs

Adverbs are words that tell us more about verbs, adverbs and adjectives. For example, *quickly, safely, now, rather, more, at once, quite, even, perhaps,* etc. are adverbs.

In the case of verbs, adverbs help us focus on nature, manner, time, location and frequency of action. In the case of adjectives and other adverbs, they modify their meaning. They generally answer questions with 'how', 'when' and 'where':

He generally walks to office.
He looked nervously round the room.

The position of an adverb or adverbial phrase depends on what it modifies. Its position also depends on what type it is and whether it is a single word or a phrase. Though some adverbs and adverbial phrases have a fixed position, others can come at the beginning, middle or end of sentences. The usual order is: Manner, then Place, then Time:

Nothing ever happens in this place. (position fixed)
I can't really say. (position not fixed)
The shop on the corner is closed. (position next to word it modifies)
She spoke very well at the meeting last night. (Manner, Place, Time)

Many *adverbs* take *comparative* and *superlative* forms:

comfortably	more comfortably	most comfortably
safely	more safely	most safely

Many *adverbs* take *intensifiers*:

very nicely	quite safely	very boldly	rather quiet

Adverbs usually specify *time, place, manner* or *frequency*:

I met her *yesterday*. (time)
I saw her *here*. (place)
She spoke *gently*. (manner)
We *often* met him at the club. (frequency)

Generally, *adverbs* do not occur immediately before nouns:

'nicely book' is incorrect.
'comfortably journey' is also incorrect.

Exercise 1
In the given sentences locate the *adjectives* and *adverbs*:

1. They were chatting or doing odd jobs.
2. He was on his way to Switzerland to join his wife and daughter whom he had prudently sent abroad before the invasion.
3. He had endured the terrible events of the past few months with sorrowful resignation and bitter comments on the inhumanity of man.
4. They were very stout too, and chatted together in their own language.
5. The train stopped at the station of a little town and suddenly a Prussian officer climbed the two steps into the carriage.
6. The Englishmen promptly began examining him with smiles of gratified curiosity.
7. The train crawled on passing through more and more occupied hamlets.
8. Their faces had become expressionless and looked like wax masks between their long sidewhiskers.
9. The Prussian was too astounded, too numb with astonishment and pain, to fling himself upon his adversary.
10. The first Englishman marked time as he ran along, his fists clenched and his elbows tucked into his sides.

Exercise 2
Rewrite the phrases by putting one of these adjectives in front of the appropriate noun:

agricultural	uncountable	digital	western
indoor	introductory	minimum	neighbouring

1. The first paragraph in an essay is an _____ paragraph.
2. A watch which uses figures to show the time is a _____ watch.
3. Land on which crops are grown is _____ land.
4. Nouns that cannot be counted separately are _____ nouns.
5. The lowest temperature of a region is its _____ temperature.
6. Games that can be played inside the house are _____ games.
7. Countries which share borders are _____ countries.
8. Mountains to the west of India are called_____ Ghats.

Exercise 3
Form the comparative of the *adjectives* in the phrases below to fill in the blanks:

a big house	a good idea	a young man	bad days
a healthy climate			

1. Bangalore certainly has _____than Delhi.
2. I'm sure it won't work. Can't you come up with _____?
3. When my parents come to live with me, I'll need _____.
4. I'm getting too old. This job is for _____.
5. Don't worry too much about him. He has seen _____.

Exercise 4

Use the *adjective* or *adverb* in brackets to complete each of the following pairs of sentences correctly:

1. The children played together very _____. They looked very _____ as they played together. (happily, happy)
2. What's wrong with Sumit? He looked very _____. He shook his head rather _____ when I walked by. (sadly, sad)
3. Use this sofa if you want to sit down _____. It's wide and _____. (comfortable, comfortably)
4. I'm afraid this is a very _____ piece of work. It has been done very _____, indeed. (carelessly, careless)
5. I received a letter quite _____ this morning. It was _____ because my mother never writes. (unexpected, unexpectedly)

Exercise 5

Give suitable replies to the following questions using one of these *adverbs* given below for each answer:

1. Will you marry a film actress?
2. Do you think human beings are naturally kind?
3. Will you support your husband if you discover that he is corrupt?
4. Do you think the best way to learn a language is by living in a country where it is spoken?
5. Do you think that reading a lot in English is a good way to improve your English?

definitely	certainly	probably	definitely not	probably not

7

MY FINANCIAL CAREER

STEPHEN LEACOCK

Stephen Leacock (1869–1944), Canadian humorist and short story writer, was born in Swanmore, Hampshire. His father farmed briefly and unsuccessfully in South Africa before he immigrated to Canada in 1876. To finance his university education, Leacock worked as a school teacher for ten years—a job he disliked intensely. In 1903 he acquired his doctorate in political economy and political science. He took up a teaching assignment at McGill University, Montreal, and rose to be William Dow professor of political economy. During 1907 and 1908 he toured the British Empire and lectured extensively, which brought him fame and a worldwide audience.

Literary Lapses launched him on his career as a humorist and made him a household name. He got into serious trouble with the publication of *Sunshine Sketches of a Little Town*, which offended the people of the town where it was set. After this setback Leacock devoted himself to writing what he called 'funny pieces, just to laugh at' and made a huge commercial success out of the venture.

Leacock is often viewed as Canada's Mark Twain. His comic range varies from inspired nonsense to serious satire. Although he uses a colloquial style, the precision and flavour of his vocabulary speak eloquently of his classical education. His books *Humor: Its Theory* and *Technique* and *Humor and Humanity* raise theoretical issues and discuss the importance of humour in our lives. The last of his forty-six books is his brilliant but incomplete autobiography *The Boy I Left Behind Me*, which was published posthumously in 1946.

'My Financial Career' recounts a painfully embarrassing experience of the narrator whose financial career ends almost as soon as it begins. A hike in salary sets the narrator thinking of the best way to handle his 'wealth' and he decides to open a bank account. He goes to a bank with his fifty-six dollars and a sense of self-importance entirely disproportionate to the amount of money he seeks to deposit, and approaches the manager. At first the manager is unaware of the size of the narrator's 'wealth' and takes him rather seriously. Upon finding out, however, that his potential client was actually carrying a very small sum of money, he directs him to the accountant. This in fact turns out to be the first of a series of embarrassing moments. As soon as the necessary formalities for opening an account are completed and the entire amount is deposited, the narrator decides to withdraw six dollars. As he presents the cheque for withdrawal, he realizes to his horror that instead of writing six he

has written fifty-six. 'Reckless with misery' he finds it difficult to explain the error to the bank clerk and lets that cheque be processed as it is, so that he is given back his entire money, thereby closing his account almost as soon as it had been opened. Instead of admitting his mistake he makes one last effort to save his dignity by pretending to be a man with a 'fearfully quick temper'. But his diffidence is too obvious to be mistaken for self-pride. His awkwardness in the presence of the manager and his subsequent attempts to hide his discomfiture raise laughter. Leacock's remarkable ability to generate humour from behavioural oddities is amply illustrated in this hilarious piece.

When I go into a bank I get rattled. The clerks rattle me; the wickets rattle me; the sight of the money rattles me; everything rattles me.

The moment I cross the threshold of a bank and attempt to transact business there, I become an irresponsible idiot.

I knew this beforehand, but my salary had been raised to fifty dollars a month and I felt that the bank was the only place for it.

So I shambled in and looked timidly round at the clerks. I had an idea that a person about to open an account must needs consult the manager.

I went up to a wicket marked 'Accountant'. The accountant was a tall, cool devil. The very sight of him rattled me. My voice was sepulchral.

'Can I see the manager?' I said, and added solemnly, 'alone'. I don't know why I said 'alone'.

'Certainly', said the accountant, and fetched him.

The manager was a grave, calm man. I held my fifty-six dollars clutched in a crumpled ball in my pocket.

'Are you the manager?' I said. God knows I didn't doubt it.

'Yes,' he said.

'Can I see you,' I asked, 'alone?' I didn't want to say 'alone' again, but without it the thing seemed self-evident.

The manager looked at me in some alarm. He felt that I had an awful secret to reveal.

'Come in here', he said and led the way to a private room. He turned the key in the lock.

'We are safe from interruption here,' he said, 'sit down.'

We both sat down and looked at each other. I found no voice to speak.

'You are one of Pinkerton's men, I presume,' he said.

He had gathered from my mysterious manner that I was a detective. I knew what he was thinking and it made me worse.

'No, not from Pinkerton's,' I said, seeming to imply that I came from a rival agency.

'To tell the truth', I went on, as if I had been prompted to lie about it, 'I am not a detective at all. I have come to open an account. I intend to keep all my money in this bank.'

The manager looked relieved but still serious; he concluded now that I was a son of Baron Rothschild or a young Gould.

'A large account, I suppose.' he said.

'Fairly large', I whispered. 'I propose to deposit fifty-six dollars now and fifty dollars a month regularly.'

The manager got up and opened the door. He called out to the accountant.

'Mr. Montgomery', he said unkindly loud, 'this gentleman is opening an account, he will deposit fifty-six dollars. Good morning.'

I rose.

A big iron door stood open at the side of the room.

'Good morning', I said, and stepped into the safe.

'Come out', said the manager coldly, and showed me the other way.

I went up to the accountant's wicket and poked the ball of money at him with a quick convulsive movement as if I were doing a conjuring trick.

My face was ghastly pale.

'Here', I said, 'deposit it.' The tone of the words seemed to mean, 'Let us do this painful thing while the fit is on me.'

He took the money and gave it to another clerk.

He made me write the sum on a slip and sign my name in a book. I no longer knew what I was doing. The bank swam before my eyes.

'Is it deposited?' I asked in a hollow, vibrating voice.

'It is', said the accountant.

'Then I want to draw a cheque.'

My idea was to draw out six dollars of it for present use. Someone gave me a cheque-book through a wicket and someone else began telling me how to write it out. The people in the bank had the impression that I was an invalid millionaire. I wrote something on the cheque and thrust it in at the clerk. He looked at it.

'What! are you drawing it all out again?' he asked in surprise. Then I realized that I had written fifty-six instead of six. I was too far gone to reason now. I had a feeling that it was impossible to explain the thing. All the clerks had stopped writing to look at me.

Reckless with misery, I made a plunge.

'Yes, the whole thing.'

'You withdraw your money from this bank?'

'Every cent of it.'

'Are you not going to deposit any more?' said the clerk, astonished.

'Never.'

An idiot hope struck me that they might think something had insulted me while I was writing the cheque and that I had changed my mind. I made a wretched attempt to look like a man with a fearfully quick temper.

The clerk prepared to pay the money.

'How will you have it?' he said.

'What?'

'How will you have it?'

'Oh'—I caught his meaning and answered without even trying to think—'in fifties'.

He gave me a fifty-dollar bill.

'And the six?' he asked dryly.

'In sixes,' I said.

He gave it to me and I rushed out.

As the big door swung behind me, I caught the echo of a roar of laughter that went up to the ceiling of the bank. Since then I bank no more. I keep my money in cash in my trouser pockets and my savings in silver dollars in a sock.

NOTES

'rattle(vb.)	:	to make somebody nervous
'wicket	:	a small window or opening as in a teller's (or cashier's) cabin in a bank
'threshold	:	the ground at the bottom of a doorway, considered as the entrance of a building or a room
tran'sact	:	to conduct or carry out business
'shamble	:	to walk or run awkwardly, without raising one's feet
'timidly	:	nervously, in a frightened manner
se'pulchral	:	looking or sounding sad and solemn
a 'conjuring ,trick	:	a trick in which something is made to appear as if by magic, often using a quick movement of the hand
ghastly pale	:	unhealthily and unpleasantly pale
'reckless with 'misery	:	feeling miserable for having done something incautiously
made a plunge	:	took a bold decisive step

COMPREHENSION

1. What are the things which make Leacock nervous?
2. How much money did the narrator want to deposit in his account?
3. Whom did the narrator approach to open an account?
4. What did the manager mistake him for?
5. How has the accountant been described by the narrator?
6. How much money did the narrator wish to withdraw from the bank and how much did he actually withdraw?
7. Why did the narrator write fifty-six on the cheque?
8. How long did he narrator's financial career last?

COMPOSITION

1. Describe the narrator's meeting with the manager.
2. How did the narrator behave in the bank?
3. Bring out the element of humour in the essay.

Exercise 1

Fill in the blanks with appropriate *articles:*

1. _____ moment I cross _____ threshold of _____ bank and attempt to transact business there, I become _____ irresponsible idiot.
2. The accountant was _____ tall, cool devil.
3. He turned _____ key in _____ lock.
4. I am not _____ detective at all.
5. _____ big iron door stood open at _____ side of _____ room.
6. He made me write _____ sum on _____ slip and sign my name in _____ book.
7. Someone gave me _____ cheque-book through _____ wicket and someone else began telling me how to write it out.
8. _____ people in _____ bank had _____ impression that I was _____ invalid millionaire.
9. I made _____ wretched attempt to look like _____ man with _____ fearfully quick temper.
10. As _____ big door swung behind me, I caught _____ echo of _____ roar of laughter that went up to _____ ceiling of _____ bank.

Exercise 2

Fill in the blanks with appropriate tense form of the *verbs* given in brackets:

1. The moment I _____ the threshold of a bank and _____ to transact a business there, I _____ an irresponsible idiot. (cross, attempt, become)
2. I _____ this beforehand, but my salary _____ to fifty dollars a month and I _____ that the bank was the only place for it. (know, raise, feel)
3. So I _____ in and _____ timidly round at the clerks. (shamble, look)
4. I _____ my fifty-six dollars _____ in a crumpled ball in my pocket. (hold, clutch)
5. I _____ what he _____ and it _____ me worse. (know, think, make)
6. A big iron door _____ open at the side of the room. (stand)
7. I _____ up to the accountant's wicket and _____ the ball of money at him with a quick convulsive movement as if I _____ a conjuring trick. (go, poke, do)
8. He _____ me _____ the sum on a slip and _____ my name in a book. (make, write, sign)
9. Someone _____ me a cheque book through a wicket and someone else _____ telling me how to write it out. (give, begin)

10. Then I _____ that I _____ fifty-six instead of six. (realize, write)

Exercise 3
Change the *narration:*

1. "Can I see the manager?" I said.
2. "We are safe from interruption here," he said, "sit down."
3. "You are one of Pinkerton's men, I presume," he said.
4. "To tell the truth," I went on, "I am not a detective at all."
5. I said, "I propose to deposit fifty-six dollars now and fifty dollars a month regularly."
6. "Is it deposited?" I asked in a hollow, vibrating voice.
7. "What! are you drawing it all out again?" he asked in surprise.
8. He said, "You withdraw your money from this bank?"

GRAMMAR: PARTS OF SPEECH

Prepositions

The word *preposition* means 'that which is placed before'. A *preposition* is a word placed before a noun or a pronoun to show in what relation the person or thing denoted by it stands in regard to something else. Many words are both *prepositions* and *adverbs*. The most common *simple* (i.e. consisting of one word) *prepositions* are:

about	above	along	after	around
at	before	below	by	down
up	for	from	off	over
on	since	till	through	

Other prepositions, consisting of more than one word, called *Complex Prepositions*, are:

according to	as for	out of	up to	in comparison with
along with	due to	owing to	in relation to	
by means of	on top of			

Dictionaries indicate which prepositions should be used with which particular words and phrases. For example, appeal *to/for*, hope *for*, insist *on*. There are several rules regarding the usage of prepositions. For example,

1. until + the end of a period:

   Wait here until I come back.
   He won't be back until Friday.

2. since + a time in the past to now:

   I have lived in Delhi since 1988.
   The baby has been crying since I came.

3. for + a period of time:

   I have lived in Delhi for 14 years.
   He kept silent for a long time.

4. during + noun:

   During my vacations we went to Shimla.

5. while + verb:

   We didn't speak while we were eating.

6. by + most forms of transport. For example, by car, by air, by sea.

7. in/into/out of is generally used with cars:

   She was carried out of the van.

8. on/onto/off is used with other forms of transport:

   We were on the same train.

Conjunctions

A *conjunction* is a word used to join together (conjoin) two sentences, clauses, phrases or single words.

The most common type of conjunctions are those which join together statements or clauses of equal importance. Therefore, these are called *co-ordinating conjunctions*. The chief co-ordinating conjunctions are: *and, but, for, or, nor, yet, whereas, only,* e.g.: 'Her eyes were shining brilliantly, *but* her face had lost its colour within twenty seconds.'

Subordinating conjunctions join a subordinate (dependent) clause to a principal clause in a sentence. The chief subordinating conjunctions are: *that, when, whenever, while, as, before, after, until, till, unless, where, wherever, because, since, lest, if, whether, though, although, than,* e.g.: "No tonsure is possible *unless* done in the babyhood," said the priest.

Certain conjunctions are paired to get variety and force in sentence structure. Such pairs are called *correlative conjunctions*, e.g.: *in order that, on condition that, so that, provided that, as though, as if,* etc.

A conjunction must be distinguished from relative pronouns (conjunctive pronouns), relative adverbs (conjunctive adverbs) and prepositions.

The words *who, which, what, that, such as, as much as,* etc. are conjunctive pronouns which perform the function of joining clauses, etc. as well.

The words *also, as well, too, as far as, as well as, as soon as, how, however, again, therefore, furthermore, moreover, accordingly, consequently, indeed, nevertheless, still, hence,* etc. are conjunctive adverbs which perform the function of joining as well.

Interjections

Interjections are words whose only function is to express emotions. Common English interjections are:

Oh! — For surprise. For example, *Oh! What a beautiful present!*
Ah! — For satisfaction, recognition. For example, *Ah! Just what I wanted!*
Aha! — For great satisfaction.
Wow! Yippee! — For great excitement, delight. For example, *Yippee! What fun!*
Ouch! Ow! — For pain. For example, *Ouch, my foot!*
Ugh! — For disgust. For example, *Ugh! What a mess!*

There are other ways of expressing emotions. We often use exclamatory sentences and use certain words like 'so' and 'such' for emphasis:

How charmingly she smiles!
He's such a nice man!
I was so bored.

We sometimes repeat words to denote degree/extent of emphasis. We also use degree adverbs and other degree expressions to intensify the meaning. In spoken language, some adjectives and adverbs have little meaning apart from their emotive force. For example, words like 'terrific', 'tremendous', 'awfully', 'terribly'.

For example, You bad, bad boy!

I'll do exactly as you say—exactly as you say—No changes whatsoever!
I'm terribly sorry! I really am!

Exercise 1
Fill in the blanks using **during, while, for** appropriately:

1. We didn't speak _____the meal but those who sat next to us kept talking _____ they were eating.
2. I stayed in Pune _____ 25 years.
3. Lopa wrote a lot of letters _____ she was on holiday.
4. I don't usually watch TV _____ the day but yesterday I watched TV _____ three hours in the afternoon.
5. I fell out of bed _____ I was asleep.

Exercise 2
Use these *verbs* and *prepositions* in sentences below.
Use the correct form of the *verbs*.

insist on	sympathize with	depend on	refer to	lead to

1. You may _____ a dictionary for words which you do not understand.

2. The accident on Mathura Road _____ the death of five young persons.
3. People _____ the victims of the riots.
4. Delhi Police _____ drivers using seat belts.
5. The buses are often unpunctual, so you can't _____ them.

Exercise 3
Fill in the blanks with appropriate *conjunctions:*

1. Who would want to leave you _____ there was a very good reason?
2. I won't get any respite _____ I have found her.
3. _____ I heard it I went to Lucknow _____ brought her back.
4. So I shambled in _____ looked timidly round at the clerks.
5. He had gathered from my mysterious manner _____ I was a detective.
6. The manager looked relieved _____ still serious; he concluded now _____ I was a son of Baron Rothschild _____ a young Gould.
7. Let us do this painful thing _____ the fit is on me.
8. I didn't want to say 'alone' again, _____ without it the thing seemed self-evident.

Exercise 4
Join each pair of sentences by using a suitable *conjunction*. Make necessary changes.

1. Men have fought for their country. Men have died for their country.
2. The old man fell down the steps. He broke his leg.
3. David works hard. Rahim works harder.
4. There is little information about his journeys. He amused himself with books and his pen.
5. He is rather boastful. He is an entertaining companion.

Exercise 5
Fill in the blanks with words expressing emotions. Study the context to supply the most appropriate word/s. Choose the words from the box below.

Yippee!	Oh!	Aha!	ever	at all	so	such	what	simply

1. Saleha: _____ What a lovely present! You shouldn't have bothered, you know.
   Vikram: _____ No trouble _____ . I'm glad you liked it.
2. Rajni: I'm _____ sad to hear of it. _____ a fine person! _____ an untimely death!
   Salim: What can I say, Rajni. It's all in God's hand. I'd never _____ thought I'd have to live to see this day.
3. Rakesh: _____ ! Savita is organising a party to welcome the newcomer.
   Vikram: _____ fun! I am looking forward to meet him.

8

PRINCIPLES OF GOOD WRITING

L.A. HILL

Leslie A. Hill was British Council's Chief Education Officer for India and in this capacity made significant contribution to English Language Teaching in India. He has written several books in this field, viz. *Prepositions and Adverbial Particles, Workbook, Refresher Courses and Guide to Correct English*—all published by Oxford University Press. He has also co-authored with D.J. May *Advanced Comprehension and Appreciation Pieces* and *Literary Comprehension and Appreciation Pieces*. He prepared a 3275 head-word vocabulary and in accordance with that he prepared the textbook *A Prelude to English* (1969) from which the present essay 'Principles of Good Writing' has been taken.

In 'Principles of Good Writing' L. A. Hill discusses the fundamentals of writing well. He suggests that one of the prerequisites for writing with clarity is the ability to think logically. Everyone may not possess this ability in equal measure. With discipline, however, minds can be taught to focus and to think logically. Written expression can also be improved with the help of a good vocabulary which, in turn, can be increased by reading widely. Keeping a notebook for recording new words and expressions is another useful habit. Ideas which occur to us at odd moments and unusual places slip out of our minds unless they are recorded immediately in a notebook.

Hill insists that one learns to write only by practising writing. As is true of most other skills, inspiration alone is not enough to produce a well-written piece of work. Besides, one cannot *rely* on inspiration: it is not something that comes easily or often. Good writing is achieved mainly through discipline and diligence rather than random bursts of inspiration.

In order to succeed as a writer, it is also important to identify one's readers and to choose subjects which promise to be of interest to the selected readership. On the question of subjects, Hill argues that it is important for writers to be genuinely interested in what they are writing about; when writers have no personal experience of their chosen subjects, they cannot sound convincing to their readers and this detracts from the quality of their writing.

Good writing also benefits from good presentation. An opening paragraph which arrests the attention of the reader, and a closing paragraph which concludes the subject satisfactorily are signs of a well-presented piece of writing. Hill lays a lot of emphasis on a writing style which comes naturally to the writer. He argues that a simple, plain and conversational style is preferable to an elaborate and decorative style, which can seem artificial.

As someone who practises what he preaches, Hill's own style of writing is unaffected. By following the suggestions made in this essay, one can significantly improve the style and quality of one's writing.

To write well, you have to be able to write clearly and logically, and you cannot do this unless you can think clearly and logically too. If you cannot do this yet, you should train yourself to do it by taking particular problems and following them through, point by point, to a solution, without leaving anything out and without avoiding any difficulties that you meet.

For example, you may take the problem, 'What do I mean when I say that I am a free person?' and then try to find a solution along something like the following lines: 'Am I free to do anything I like? No, I am not free to fly to Mars, for example. My freedom is limited to what is possible. Am I then free to do anything that it is possible for me to do? No, I am not free to kill my neighbour, for example. My freedom is limited to what is possible and legal. But am I not in fact free to kill my neighbour provided I can do it without being found out? Well, yes, in fact I am. My freedom is therefore limited to what is possible and legal, unless I can avoid being found out in something illegal. Why are there legal limitations to my freedom? Because if I were free to do harm to others, thereby limiting their freedom, they too would be free to do me harm; and under these conditions, I would have a less chance of freedom than if I and everybody else accepted certain legal limitations on our freedom in order to protect the latter against arbitrary interference by others. Etc.'

At first, you may find clear, step-by-step thought very difficult. You may find that your mind continually wanders. But practice will improve your ability to think clearly and logically.

In order to increase your vocabulary and to improve your powers of expression, you should read widely and carefully, and keep a notebook in which to write down words and expressions that particularly strike you; for example, *sparkle, glitter, twinkle, blaze, gleam,* etc. Use a good dictionary to help you with the exact meanings and uses of words.

Always remember that regular and frequent practice is essential if you are to learn to write well. You learn to write by writing. It is no good waiting until you have an inspiration before you write. Even with the most famous writers, inspiration is rare. Writing is 99 per cent hard work and 1 per cent inspiration, so the sooner you get into the habit of disciplining yourself to write, the better.

If you keep your eyes and ears open, you will find plenty of things

to write about around you. Often a little piece of conversation heard in the street can start you thinking along interesting new lines. Imagine that you are a stranger who is not familiar with the things that you see around you, and start from there.

Read the newspaper carefully. Every day there are examples of human joy and human tragedy in it which can give you ideas for articles, essays or short stories.

Keep a notebook in which to put down things that you notice, or ideas that come to you when you are out walking, when you are reading a book or a magazine, or at any other time. Some people get ideas in the bath, or when they wake up during the night. Unless they write these ideas down at once, they often forget them.

Try to develop a warm, human understanding of people, their problems, their joys and their sorrows, so that you are genuinely interested in everyone you meet and every incident you see. You will then find material for your work as a writer where before you could perhaps see nothing of interest.

To be a successful writer, you must write interestingly; but different kinds of people have different interests, and it is most unlikely that you will be able to appeal to all of them. You therefore have to know exactly what type of reader you are writing for, and exactly what kinds of things interest such a reader.

By carefully reading magazines which are written for particular kinds of readers (e.g. women's magazines, magazines for teenagers, magazines for well-educated men), you can find out the things that interest particular types of readers.

Most people are interested in the present. Even when they read about the past or the future, it is the latter's connections with, or relevance to, the present that particularly interests them. You should therefore choose subjects of topical interest—the latest fashions in some particular field, problems which worry people nowadays, and so on. You should write about Christmas when people are making preparations for this festival, and about summer holidays when the summer is approaching.

As much as possible, choose subjects of which you have personal experience. You will be able to write on these much more convincingly and with greater authority than on subjects about which you have only second-hand information.

Presentation is of very great importance in good writing. Your opening paragraph should arrest the reader's attention and show him what you are writing about and why. If you are going to give the reader some information, tell him what subject you are going to deal with. If you are going to argue in support of a particular point of

view, say what this point of view is. There is no harm in startling the reader in this first paragraph by putting forward a new and apparently paradoxical point of view, provided you have convincing arguments to support it in the rest of what you write.

The main body of your piece of writing should collect together and present the ideas promised in the first paragraph, or give good arguments to support the view put forward there. You should come to the point at once, say what you promised to say, avoiding irrelevant material, and then finish.

Your last paragraph or sentence should bring what you have written to a neat, satisfying end, leaving the reader with a clear idea of what you have been saying.

To write interestingly, you must yourself be intensely interested in what you are writing, and you must convey this feeling of eagerness to your readers. You must also believe intensely in what you are writing, and convince your readers of your honesty. You cannot arouse their interest and sympathy unless they feel that you yourself are interested, and that you feel strongly about what you are saying.

Do not, however, force upon the reader those of your own private problems which few, if any, other people share. People are very interested in problems which they too face, or which they may easily have to face in the near future, but they do not want to read the personal complainings and protests of someone whom they consider a crank, or whom they suspect of being mentally unbalanced.

Do not strive to create an impression. Forget about yourself, think only of the reader, and write naturally, avoiding self-consciousness. If you have something interesting to write about and can express it clearly, simply and with the human touch, it is sure to appeal to some classes of readers. But if you deliberately try to copy a style which is not your own, this will quickly become obvious to the reader, he will feel that you are not sincere, and he will not go on reading what you have written. As you read more and more works written in a particular style, your own will gradually change; but this will be a natural process, and your new style will be yours, because it comes up from your unconscious, unlike a style which you are deliberately copying.

This does not mean that you should not cultivate vivid expression. If you train yourself to see and hear things keenly and responsively, as an artist or a musician does, you will be able to describe them vividly yet without artificiality.

It is best to write simply and in a conversational tone. Clean, plain English is the fashion these days, and an elaborate, decorated style is quite out of date. Avoid jargon (e.g. *re your letter to hand* meaning

'with reference to the letter which I have received from you') and officialese (e.g. *it is apprehended that* meaning 'I suppose'), hackneyed expressions (e.g. *Adam's ale* for 'water' and *do one's level best* for 'do the best one can'), rhetorical flourishes (e.g. *This is a subject of great importance to many people nowadays, and therefore one which I feel I should discuss seriously and honestly.* The reader knows whether he thinks it important or not; and he certainly does not need to be told that, if it is of great importance, it deserves to be discussed seriously and honestly), empty verbiage (e.g. *I feel obliged to add that, doubtless, many people appreciate that it is a matter of the greatest importance that information about possible cases of cruelty to children should be passed on to the appropriate authorities immediately*, in which the first 20 words are empty verbiage) and circumlocutions (e.g. *I will cause investigations to be made with a view to ascertaining the information*, instead of 'I will find out').

Prefer the concrete to the abstract word whenever possible, be definite, call a spade a spade, and avoid euphemisms. The latter have been called the Cult of Cosiness, which means the pretence that everything is all right when it is not. In Hitler's Germany, for example, the expression *special treatment* was used as a euphemism for torture and murder of the most savage kinds.

Here is an example, taken from Dickens' novel *David Copperfield*, of the sort of things to avoid:

My dear Sir,

Years have elapsed, since I had an opportunity of ocularly perusing the lineaments, now familiar to the imaginations of a considerable portion of the civilized world. But, my dear sir, though estranged (by the force of circumstances over which I have had no control) from the personal society of the friend and companion of my youth, I have not been unmindful of his soaring flight. Nor have I been debarred from participating in the intellectual feasts he has spread before us.

I cannot, therefore, allow of the departure from this place of an individual whom we mutually respect and esteem, without, my dear sir, taking this public opportunity of thanking you, on my own behalf, and, I may undertake to add, on that of the whole of the inhabitants of Port Middlebay, for the gratification of which you are the ministering agent.

Go on, my dear sir! You are not unknown here, you are not unappreciated. Though 'remote', we are neither 'unfriended', 'melancholy', nor (I may add) 'slow'. Go on, my dear sir, in your eagle course! The inhabitants of Port Middlebay may at least aspire to watch it, with delight, with entertainment, with instruction!

Among the eyes elevated towards you from this end of the globe,
will ever be found, while it has light and life,
The
Eye
Appertaining to
Wilkins Micawber,
Magistrate.

We should now write, instead of the above, something like this:

Dear Sir,

It is many years since I last had an opportunity to see you, and you have now become famous throughout a considerable part of the civilized world. Although circumstances beyond my control have made it impossible for me to continue the close association with you which I enjoyed in my youth, I have followed your progress and read your books with great pleasure.

Now that you are leaving Port Middlebay, I would therefore like to thank you, on my own behalf and on behalf of the inhabitants of this town, for the pleasure you have given us, and to wish you even greater success in the future.

Yours faithfully,
etc.

Avoid stating the obvious; e.g. your readers do not want to be told that aeroplanes sometimes crash, or that children learn from their parents as well as from their teachers.

Use the same style throughout whatever you are writing. If you are writing formally, do not introduce slang expressions; and if you are writing in a conversational style, do not introduce literary or learned expressions. A mixture of styles, such as the following is absurd: 'In the absence, on home leave, of my boss, your application for sympathetic consideration of your claim to a pension has been pushed on to me. I have had no alternative but to give it the thumbs down, owing to the fact that your old man had ceased to be in the service of Her Majesty when he kicked the bucket.'

If, while you are writing you cannot think of the right word at once, it is a good idea to put in another, or to leave a blank, so as not to interrupt your flow of thought. Then, when you have finished, you can go back and find exactly the right word for what you were trying to say.

In any case, read your work over critically after you have finished it, replacing weak, vague, inexact words by others which say just what you mean.

NOTES

'arbitrary	:	based on opinion or impulse, not on reason
ˌpara'doxical	:	a statement that seems contradictory because it has two opposite features but is or may be true
'vividly	:	in a manner producing clear pictures in one's mind
'jargon	:	words or expressions that are used by particular groups of people, especially in their work, and are difficult for others to understand
o'fficial'ese	:	language often used in government documents which is formal and often difficult to understand
'hackneyed	:	used too often and therefore boring
rhe'torical	:	intended to create an impression
'verbiage	:	the use of too many words, or of more difficult words than are needed, to express an idea
ˌcircumlo'cution	:	saying something in an indirect manner, using more words than are necessary
'euphemism	:	an indirect word or phrase that people often use to refer to something embarrassing or unpleasant, sometimes to make it more acceptable than it really is
e'lapse	:	to pass (a period of time)
'ocularly	:	visually
'lineaments	:	the typical features of something
e'stranged	:	no longer friendly
ˌapper'taining to	:	(phr. v.) relating to somebody or something
slang	:	very informal words and expressions that are more common in spoken language
kick the bucket	:	(slang) die
vague	:	imprecise, not exact

COMPREHENSION

1. What does one need to do before one can write clearly and logically?
2. Clear, step by step thinking is difficult because the mind continually wanders. How can one improve one's ability to think clearly and logically?
3. What should be done to increase one's vocabulary and to improve one's expression?
4. To what extent is inspiration essential for writing?
5. What should one do to save the ideas that come to one's mind?
6. Why is it advisable to write on subjects of which one has personal experience?
7. How should the last paragraph of a piece of writing be written?
8. What does Hill say about elaborate, decorated style of writing?

COMPOSITION

1. What are Hill's views regarding keeping a notebook?
2. In what way is presentation important in good writing?
3. Describe the few things that need to be *avoided* in good writing.
4. Summarize Hill's views on the principles of good writing.

Exercise 1

Fill in the blanks with appropriate *prepositions:*

1. My freedom is limited _____ what is possible.
2. Use a good dictionary to help you _____ the exact meanings and uses _____ words.
3. You can learn to write _____ writing.
4. Often a little piece _____ conversation heard _____ the street can start you thinking _____ interesting new lines.
5. Some people get ideas _____ the bath, or when they wake up _____ the night.
6. You should write _____ Christmas when people are making preparations _____ this festival.
7. Presentation is _____ very great importance _____ good writing.
8. If you are going to argue _____ support _____ a particular point _____ view, say what this point _____ view is.
9. There is no harm _____ startling the reader _____ this new first paragraph _____ putting forward a new and apparently paradoxical point _____ view.
10. You must also believe intensely _____ what you are writing, and convince your readers _____ your honesty.

Exercise 2

Change the *voice:*

1. You may find that your mind continually wanders.
2. Practice will improve your ability to think clearly and logically.
3. Read the newspaper carefully.
4. You should choose subjects of topical interest.
5. You must convey the feeling of eagerness to your readers.
6. Prefer the concrete to the abstract word whenever possible.
7. I have followed your progress with great pleasure.
8. Use the same style throughout whatever you are writing.

GRAMMAR: PHRASES

A *phrase* is a part of a *sentence* or *clause* which holds together as a meaningful unit on its own, and contributes in a unified way to the meaning of the whole *sentence* or *clause*. Phrases often consist of several words clustered around a particular *head word*, which in some sense carries the central idea in the meaning of the whole phrase. Phrases can be long, and may contain other phrases inside them.

A phrase does not contain a finite verb (that is, a verb with a proper tense form) but may contain a non-finite part of a verb (participle, infinitive, gerund).

In itself a phrase cannot make complete sense in a sentence, but can have meaning only through its relation to some other part(s) of the sentence in which it stands.

In the following sentences the underlined parts are phrases:

1. A sentence is a group of words in a specific order.
2. The cashier made a mistake.
3. A stitch in time saves nine.
4. I visit Delhi every now and then.
5. We went to Delhi by way of Ambala.
6. The police admonished nasty boys.
7. They wanted to visit a temple.
8. The students were happy participating in the workshop.
9. The old man hired a yellow coloured taxi.

The Noun Phrase

Consider the following sentences in group 'A' and group 'B':

Group A	
1. Raman is away.	Raman is the 'subject'.
2. This is Raman.	Raman is the 'complement'.
3. I helped Raman.	Raman is the 'object'.
4. I brought Raman a book.	Raman is the 'indirect object'.
5. I went to college with Raman.	Raman is the 'object' of the preposition 'with'.

Group B
1. The angry young man is away.
2. This is the angry young man.
3. I helped the angry young man.
4. I brought the angry young man a book.
5. I went to college with the angry young man.

Whatever function is performed by 'Raman' in group 'A' is also performed by the group of words 'the angry young man' in group 'B'.

A *noun phrase* is thus a phrase with a noun as its *head word*. At its simplest a pronoun such as 'they' or a proper noun such as 'Meena' can constitute a *noun phrase*. But a noun phrase may be a long and complex structure with a noun as head, preceded by other words such as an *article*, an *adjective*, or another *noun*, and followed by a *prepositional phrase* or by a *relative clause*.

For example, The new T-shirt that I'd bought from the Mall has a stain on it.

In a sentence, a *noun phrase* can function as a *subject*, an *object*, a *complement* or as the *object* of a *preposition*. Consider the following sentences:

1. A group of students stoned a bus.
   The noun phrase 'A group of students' is the *subject* and the noun phrase 'a bus' is the *object*.
2. The village became the centre of activity.
   The noun phrase 'The village' is the *subject* and the noun phrase 'the centre of activity' is the *complement*.
3. They played games with their young children.
   The noun phrase 'their young children' is the *object* of the preposition 'with'.

A noun phrase may be preceded by:

i.	a determiner	the book, his book, which book
ii.	a determiner + an ordinal	the first book, his last book
iii.	a determiner + an ordinal + a quantifier	the first four books, his first ten children
iv.	a determiner + an ordinal + a quantifier + an adjectival phrase	the first ten healthy children, the last four very bulky books
v.	a determiner + an ordinal + a quantifier + an adjectival phrase + a classifier	the first ten very healthy school children, the last four very bulky Geography books

Exercise 1
In the given passages, locate the *noun phrases.*

For example, When I go into a bank, I get rattled. The clerks rattle me, the wickets rattle me; the sight of the money rattles me; everything rattles me.

I, a bank, the clerks, me, the wickets, the sight of the money are the *noun phrases* in this passage.
(single noun words and pronouns have also been considered as noun phrases)

1. These beautifully tailored salwar-kurta suits were available in the shop. I bought this pale green cotton set.
2. So I shambled in and looked timidly around at the clerks. I had an idea that a person about to open an account must needs consult the manager.
3. He had gathered from my mysterious manner that I was a detective. I knew what he was thinking, and it made me worse.
4. My idea was to draw out six dollars from it for present use. Someone gave me a cheque book through a wicket and someone else began telling me how to write it out. The people in the bank had the impression that I was an invalid millionaire. I wrote something on the cheque and thrust it in at the clerk. He looked at it.
5. As the big door swung behind me, I caught the echo of a roar of

laughter that went up to the ceiling of the bank. Since then I bank no more. I keep my money in cash in my trouser-pockets and my savings in silver dollars in a sock.

6. An idiot hope struck me that they might think someone had insulted me while I was writing the cheque and that I had changed my mind. I made a wretched attempt to look like a man with a fearfully quick temper.

Adjectival Phrase

An adjectival phrase consists of an intensifier and an adjective. However, the intensifier is optional. In the following sentences the underlined parts are adjectival phrases:

1. Those girls were very nice.
2. The students seemed extremely happy.
3. The old man was quite humorous.
4. The lectures were very useful.

Prepositional Phrase

A *prepositional phrase* is a phrase consisting of a *preposition* followed by a *noun phrase.* Consider the following examples:

1. The young girls were dancing in a room.
2. This letter was for John.
3. They were helping him in the examination.
4. We met on a lovely Sunday afternoon.

Adverbial Phrase

An *adverbial phrase* consists of an adverb or a phrase with an adverb as its head word. The underlined parts in the following sentences are adverbial phrases:

1. The dog ran very quickly.
2. They welcomed the guests heartily.
3. The snake appeared at once from nowhere.

Exercises 2

In the following sentences locate the *phrases*. Mention whether the phrase is a *noun phrase*, a *prepositional phrase*, or an *adjectival phrase.*

1. No one is free to kill his neighbour.
2. I took those French rogues by the ears.
3. He sat huddled in a corner like a thief.
4. Most people are interested in the present.
5. Presentation is of very great importance in good writing.
6. You can find out things of your interest.
7. Practice will improve your ability to think clearly and logically.

8. Their faces looked like wax masks.
9. Every day there are examples of human joy and human tragedy in the newspapers.
10. Prefer the concrete to the abstract word, whenever possible.

Exercise 3

Examine the statements given below and state whether they are true or false. If possible, give reasons for your choice.

Example: Any group of words makes a sentence. False

The above statement is false. Jumbled up words do not make a sentence. In a sentence words are placed in a specific order according to the rules of grammar.

1. Sentences in English begin with a capital letter. True/False
2. All sentences must have an object. True/False
3. An adjunct is a necessary part of a sentence. True/False
4. The finite verb agrees with the grammatical subject. True/False
5. All sentences have complements. True/False
6. In a sentence the finite verb carries the tense. True/False
7. A prepositional phrase must begin with a preposition. True/False
8. A phrase does not contain a finite verb. True/False
9. A prepositional phrase must contain a noun phrase. True/False
10. A noun phrase may function as a 'subject', an 'object', a 'complement' or an 'adjunct' in a sentence. True/False
11. A noun phrase may have a noun or pronoun as the only single member in it. True/False
12. An adjectival phrase functions as an adjective in a sentence. True/False

9

THE ELIXIR OF LIFE

C.V. RAMAN

Sir Chandrasekhara Venkata Raman (1888–1970) was born in Trichinapally in Tamil Nadu. Raman entered the Presidency College, Madras (Chennai) in 1903 and achieved the highest distinctions in his B.A. and M.A. examinations. He joined the Civil Services in 1907, but resigned from the job when he was offered professorship of Physics in a science college in Calcutta University. At the young age of eighteen, Raman published original findings in optical research in the *Philosophical Magazine*. Over the years, he published some thirty papers in *Nature*, the *Philosophical Magazine* and the *Physical Review*, which turned him into a well-known figure amongst scientists in Europe and America.

Raman's doctoral thesis on the *Molecular Diffraction of Light*, published by the University of Calcutta, won him worldwide acclaim. The Royal Society elected Raman to its Fellowship in 1924 and in 1930 bestowed on him the Hughes Medal. In the same year, he was awarded the Nobel Prize for Physics for the discovery of the effect on monochromatic light when passed through a transparent medium. This discovery, now famously known as the 'Raman Effect', was useful in obtaining information about the structure of molecules. For his contribution to the field of science the Queen of England conferred Knighthood on C.V. Raman in 1929.

From 1933 to 1949 Raman served as a professor of Physics (and briefly as Director) at the Indian Institute of Sciences in Bangalore. He founded the Indian Academy of Sciences in 1934, supervised the regular publication of its proceedings, and officiated as its president until his death. In 1949 Raman moved to an independent scientific institution which is now known as Raman Research Institute. Late in life he was venerated as the father of Indian Science, and the Indian Government bestowed on him the first of its National Professorships.

In 'The Elixir of Life' Raman underlines the importance of water in human and plant life and suggests some traditional and modern ways for its conservation. This colourless and tasteless liquid is, in fact, so valuable that it deserves to be called the elixir of life. Flowing rivers and streams not only add to the beauty of the plains through which they run, they also make them fertile and green. Water has, indeed, played a significant part in shaping the history of mankind. Water has remarkable p[illegible] of carrying silt or finely-divided soil in suspension. Large tracts of fertile land are f[illegible]med wherever this silt is deposited.

This process, however, can also turn destructive if it is allowed to proceed unchecked. Running water can wash away top soil which is essential for agricultural activities. Soil erosion, if not tackled in time through construction of bunds, contour cultivation and planting of appropriate vegetation, can lead to the formation of deep gullies and ravines, making the land unfit for cultivation.

Water is the basis of all life forms and no physiological activity is possible in its absence. Hence conservation and proper utilization of water is inextricably linked with human welfare. Conservation of excess rainwater, which runs off the ground and is wasted, needs urgent attention, especially in a country like India where agriculture largely depends upon seasonal rainfall, which is not only irregular but often also inadequate.

Though water is the commonest of liquids, its amazing properties make it a unique resource. Investigations into the nature and properties of water could constitute an area of great scientific interest.

Man has through the ages sought in vain for an imaginary elixir of life, the divine *Amrita*, a draught of which was thought to confer immortality. But the true elixir of life lies near to our hands. For it is the commonest of all liquids, plain water! I remember one day standing on the line which separates the Libyan Desert from the valley of the Nile in Egypt. On one side was visible a sea of billowing sand without a speck of green or a single living thing anywhere visible on it. On the other side lay one of the greenest, most fertile and densely populated areas to be found anywhere on the earth, teeming with life and vegetation. What made this wonderful difference? Why, it is the water of the River Nile flowing down to the Mediterranean from its sources a couple of thousands of miles away. Geologists tell us that the entire soil of the Nile valley is the creation of the river itself, brought down as the finest silt in its flood waters, from the highlands of Abyssinia and from remote Central Africa, and laid down through the ages in the trough through which the Nile flows into the sea. Egypt, in fact, was made by its river. Its ancient civilization was created and sustained by the life-giving waters which come down year after year with unfailing regularity.

I gave this example and could give many others to emphasize that this common substance which we take for granted in our everyday life is the most potent and the most wonderful thing on the face of our earth. It has played a role of vast significance in shaping the course of the earth's history and continues to play the leading role in the drama of life on the surface of our planet.

There is nothing which adds so much to the beauty of the countryside as water, be it just a little stream trickling over the rocks or a little pond by the wayside where the cattle quench their thirst of an evening. The rain-fed tanks that are so common in South India—

alas often so sadly neglected in their maintenance—are a cheering sight when they are full. They are, of course, shallow, but this is less evident since the water is silt-laden and throws the light back, and the bottom does not therefore show up. These tanks play a vital role in South Indian agriculture. In Mysore, for example, much of the rice is grown under them. Some of these tanks are surprisingly large and it is a beautiful sight to see the sun rise or set over one of them. Water in a landscape may be compared to the eyes in a human face. It reflects the mood of the hour, being bright and gay when the sun shines, turning to dark and gloomy when the sky is overcast.

One of the most remarkable facts about water is its power to carry silt or finely divided soil in suspension. This is the origin of the characteristic colour of the water in rain-fed tanks. This colour varies with the nature of the earth in the catchment area and is most vivid immediately after a fresh inflow following rain. Swiftly flowing water can carry fairly large and heavy particles. The finest particles, however, remain floating within the liquid in spite of their greater density and are carried to great distance. Such particles are, of course, extremely small, but their number is also great, and incredibly large amounts of solid matter can be transported in this way. When silt-laden water mixes with the salt water of the sea, there is a rapid precipitation of the suspended matter. This can be readily seen when one travels by steamer down a great river to the deep sea. The colour of the water changes successively from the muddy red or brown of silt through varying shades of yellow and green finally to the blue of the deep sea. That great tracts of land have been formed by silt thus deposited is evident on an examination of the soil in alluvial areas. Such land, consisting as it does of finely divided matter, is usually very fertile.

The flow of water has undoubtedly played a great part and a beneficent one in the geological processes by which the soil on the earth's surface has been formed from the rocks of its crust. The same agency, however, under appropriate conditions, can also play a destructive part and wash away the soil which is the foundation of all agriculture, and if allowed to proceed unchecked can have the most disastrous effects on the life of the country. The problem of soil erosion is one of serious import in various countries and especially in many parts of India. The conditions under which it occurs and the measures by which it can be checked are deserving of the closest study. Soil erosion occurs in successive steps, the earliest of which may easily pass unnoticed. In the later stages, the cutting up and washing away of the earth is only too painfully apparent in the formation of deep gullies and ravines which make all agriculture impossible. Sudden bursts of excessively heavy rain resulting in a large run-off of surplus water are the principal factors in causing soil erosion. Contributory

causes are the slope of the land, removal of the natural protective coat of vegetation, the existence of ruts along which the water can flow with rapidly gathering momentum, and the absence of any checks to such flow. Incredibly large quantities of precious soil can be washed away if such conditions exist, as is unhappily too often the case.

The menace which soil erosion presents to the continuance of successful agriculture is an alarming one in many parts of India, calling urgently for attention and preventive action. The terracing of land, the construction of bunds to check the flow of water, the practice of contour cultivation and the planting of appropriate types of vegetation are amongst the measures that have been suggested. It is obvious that the aim should be to check the flow of water at the earliest possible stage before it has acquired any appreciable momentum and correspondingly large destructive power.

Water is the basis of all life. Every animal and every plant contains a substantial proportion of free and combined water in its body, and no kind of physiological activity is possible in which the fluid does not play an essential part. Water is, of course, necessary for animal life, while moisture in the soil is equally imperative for the life and growth of plants and trees, though the quantity necessarily varies enormously with the species. The conservation and utilization of water is thus fundamental for human welfare. Apart from artesian water the ultimate source in all cases is rain or snowfall. Much of Indian agriculture depends on seasonal rainfall and is therefore very sensitive to any failure or irregularity of the same. The problems of soil erosion and of inadequate or irregular rainfall are closely connected with each other. It is clear that the adoption of techniques preventing soil erosion would also help to conserve and keep the water where it is wanted, in other words on and in the soil, and such techniques therefore serve a double purpose.

It is evident however that in a country having only a seasonal rainfall an immense quantity of rainwater must necessarily run off the ground. The collection and utilization of this water is therefore of vital importance. Much of it flows down into the streams and rivers and ultimately finds its way to the sea. Incredibly large quantities of the precious fluid are thus lost to the country. The harnessing of our rivers, the waters of which now mostly run to waste, is a great national problem which must be considered and dealt with on national lines. Vast areas of land which at present are mere scrub jungle could be turned into fertile and prosperous country by courageous and well-planned action.

Closely connected with the conservation of water supplies is the problem of afforestation. The systematic planting of suitable trees in every possible or even in impossible areas, and the development of

what one can call civilized forests, as distinguished from wild and untamed jungle, is one of the most urgent needs of India. Such plantation would directly and indirectly prove a source of untold wealth to the country. It would check soil erosion and conserve the water, and would provide the necessary supplies of cheap fuel, and thus render unnecessary the wasteful conversion of farmyard manure into a form of fuel.

The measures necessary to control the movement of water and conserve the supplies of it can also serve subsidiary purposes of value to the life of the countryside. By far the cheapest form of internal transport in a country is by boats and barges through canals and rivers. We hear much about programmes of rail and road construction, but far too little about the development of internal waterways in India. Then, again, the harnessing of water supplies usually also makes possible the development of hydro-electric power. The availability of electric power would make a tremendous difference to the life of the countryside and enable rural economy to be improved in various directions. In particular, it would enable underground water to be tapped to a greater extent than at present, and thus help to overcome the difficulties arising from irregularity or inadequacy of other sources of supply.

In one sense, water is the commonest of liquids. In another sense, it is the most uncommon of liquids with amazing properties which are responsible for its unique power of maintaining animal and plant life. The investigation of the nature and properties of water is, therefore, of the highest scientific interest and is far from an exhausted field of research.

NOTES

e'lixir : a liquid supposed to make people live eternally
'billowing sand : stretches of sand that roll like waves
speck : a very small mark or piece
teeming with : full of
'highlands : a mountainous region
,Aby'ssinia : a former name for Ethiopia
trough : a shallow channel for conveying liquids
'catchment ,area : the area from which a river or a reservoir is fed
pre,cipi'tation : chemical process in which solid material is separated from a liquid
a'lluvial : made of sand and earth deposited by rivers or floods
'gully : a small channel, usually formed by a stream or by rain
ra'vine : a deep, very narrow valley with steep sides
rut : a deep track in soft ground
'terracing : to form a series of raised level banks of earth, used for cultivation

mo'mentum : the force that an object gains in movement
contour cultivation : cultivation along lines of constant altitude to minimize soil erosion
artesian water : water coming out of an artesian well. An artesian well is a well bored into the ground through which water rises to the surface by natural pressure
'harness : to control and use the force or strength of something to produce power or to achieve something else
scrub jungle : a jungle of small bushes and trees
sub'sidiary : connected with something but of lesser importance
barge : a large boat with a flat bottom used for carrying goods and people on canals and rivers
tap (verb) : to make use of a source of energy, knowledge, etc. that already exists
i'nadequacy : the state of not being enough or good enough; a weakness or lack of something

COMPREHENSION

1. With what does Raman compare water?
2. Which ancient civilization does Raman refer to that was created and sustained by waters of an important river?
3. "There is nothing which adds so much to the beauty of the countryside as water," says Raman. Give some examples to illustrate this statement.
4. What is a common sight in South India?
5. Why is it difficult to know the depth of the rain-fed tanks of South India?
6. To which part of human body does the writer compare water in a landscape? Why?
7. What is silt?
8. What happens when silt-laden water mixes with the salt water of the sea?
9. What is soil erosion?
10. What is afforestation and in what way is it useful?

COMPOSITION

1. Based on your reading of the essay, write a paragraph on the conservation of rainwater.
2. In what way are rainwater, soil erosion and afforestation related?
3. Discuss the measures suggested in the essay to tackle the menace of soil erosion.
4. What subsidiary purposes can be served by the measures to control the movement of water and its conservation?

GRAMMAR: CLAUSES

A *clause* is a part of a *sentence*, which itself has all or many of the basic ingredients of a whole sentence, including a *verb* and a *subject*, and perhaps *direct* and/or *indirect objects*.

It is important to note that clauses may contain other clauses inside them. Some clauses look exactly like whole sentences, just inserted into another sentence. However, other clauses may appear somewhat different from whole sentences—by omitting a subject or an object. Though any simple sentence is also a clause, it is not very useful to refer to simple sentences as *clauses*.

In the sentences below, the clauses are underlined. Double underlining indicates one clause being contained within another:

1. Reena sat where no one could see her.
2. John must eat what is served.
3. Tell Suhail that Archana wants to be dropped home.

Clauses are of three types:

1. **Main Clause:** The main clause is the sentence itself in its simple form—the clause, that is, on which the rest of the construction depends in both syntax and meaning.

   In the sentence 'They go to a Chinese restaurant because they love Chinese food', the clause They go to a Chinese restaurant is the main clause. The rest of the construction, i.e. the clause because they love Chinese food depends on the main clause and is called a subordinate clause.

2. **Subordinate Clause:** A subordinate clause is dependent on another clause, and cannot stand by itself. Consider this sentence:

   The rain-fed tanks, that are so common in India, are a cheering sight when they are full.

   The clauses that are so common in India, and when they are full are subordinate clauses.

3. **Coordinate Clause:** A sentence with coordinate clauses is a sentence with two or more main clauses linked together by coordinating conjunctions like *and*, *but*, etc.

   In the sentence, 'He is rather lazy but she works hard'. He is rather lazy and she works hard are coordinate clauses.

Exercise 1
Identify which of the following are *complete sentences* and which of them are *clauses* or *phrases*: Change the clauses/phrases into sentences by adding words of your own. Change the punctuation marks if necessary.

1. Mahatma Gandhi was born in Porbundar, Gujarat.
2. While Sakina got up early in the morning to catch the train.
3. By the time Rajiv reached college.
4. He was privately educated.
5. If I win a lottery.
6. Having received many awards.
7. He was injured while playing football.
8. My uncle who is a doctor.

Exercise 2
Complete the following sentences by using *clauses* or *phrases*:

1. George and I have been close friends since _____ .
2. When I heard the explosion _____ .
3. If you ask me, I will _____ .
4. Rahim will help you if _____.
5. Susheel is so enthusiastic that _____ .
6. It was such a difficult problem that _____ .
7. Although we began late, _____.
8. She did her best despite _____.

10

STREAMLINING

C. BEVERS

In the present essay C. Bevers highlights the importance of the principle of streamlining in designing fast-moving vehicles and futuristic buildings. Streamlining is not a new concept. The Red Indians employed this principle in designing their canoes and arrowheads. However, in modern times, the principle is being applied to design means of transport in a more technology-conscious and scientific manner. In the past, cars were patterned on horse-driven carriages and the locomotives had a flat front. Their shapes produced considerable air-resistance, but since they moved at a slow speed, minimizing air-resistance was not a priority. As there arose the need for rapid transport, designers and technicians focused their attention on devising means for reducing air-resistance. Examples of reducing air-resistance were drawn from nature and applied to technology.

Bevers predicts that in future the principle of streamlining will be applied to other things besides cars, aeroplanes, locomotives, etc. In times to come there will be far fewer projections in tall buildings than are now commonly seen. However, there is a possibility that large-scale changes in the shapes of trains, ships, factories, shops and houses in accordance with the principle of streamlining will invite resistance from people and prove prohibitively expensive.

Streamlining is really a very old idea used in a modern way. Long ago when the Red Indian shaped his canoe or carved his arrowheads he was following out this idea. He found that he could paddle his boat more swiftly through the water if he built it with a sharp prow and slim sides. Probably he learnt his craft by watching fishes swimming in the rivers and birds gliding overhead, for he noticed how their bodies were built to produce as little resistance as possible against the water or air in which they moved. This knowledge was sufficient for him to design his simple boats and weapons.

In the modern world many new problems have arisen owing to the invention of the steam engine and the petrol engine, inventions which have made it possible to travel at very high speeds. Speed of transport has become the greatest feature of the modern industrial

world. Rapid transport saves so much valuable time, that designers and mechanics everywhere are doing their utmost to increase the speeds of motor-cars, ships and aeroplanes.

There are three chief ways by which speed can be increased. We can improve the engine, we can improve the fuel which drives the engine, we can reduce the air-resistance. Until a few years ago little attention was given to air-resistance, but today streamlining of vehicles is being developed to overcome it.

What exactly is air-resistance? To understand the answer to this question it must be realized that air like water or other fluids has weight and volume. On every square inch of our body the air presses with a weight of fourteen pounds, and this weight has to be pushed aside when we walk or run, just as water is pushed away by a swimmer. The air resists our efforts to push it aside, and this sets up friction—or drag which acts like a brake upon our speed. To reduce this friction to the lowest possible fraction is the object of streamlining.

The chief aim in the construction of modern cars and aeroplanes has been to reduce the surface area of those parts which press against the air, just as the prow of a ship is given a sharp edge to plough through the sea. In other words, the streamlined car is made to 'cut' the air instead of push it aside. Most of our older types of vehicles were designed without any attention to the surface they offered to the air. The motor-cars which can be seen at the rallies of 'Old crocks', and the flat fronts of our locomotives are bad examples of streamlining. The first motor-car simply followed the pattern of the horse-drawn carriages of earlier times, but as their highest speed remained below twenty or thirty miles an hour the air-resistance was not of great importance. It is when vehicles reach the terrific speeds of today that the problem becomes a serious one.

Let us understand the reason for this. If we walk slowly we do not feel the air on our face, but if we run, or ride in an open car, it seems as if a strong wind is blowing at us. This is called air-pressure, and it increases at a very rapid rate, for if we run twice as fast as we walk the air-pressure increases four times, and if we run four times as fast as we walk, the air-pressure is sixteen times as great; we can, therefore, understand that at very high speeds the air-pressure becomes tremendous.

Nature affords many examples of the way to overcome air-resistance. A hare flattens its ears when running; birds draw up their legs when in flight. The first step in streamlining has been to cut out all sharp angles and projections. Let us suppose that a manufacturer brought his car to us and asked us to turn it into a streamlined model. How should we begin?

First of all we would bend the front of the radiator in such a way that it had a curved surface instead of a flat one; we would similarly

shape the back of the car. Then we would tilt back the windscreen, remove the wide mudguards and fit narrow tapered ones called 'spats', and we would fix the spare wheel at the back instead of at the side. Finally, we would sink the lamps, door-handles and other projections into the body of the coach-work so that the whole surface of the car was as smooth as possible.

In aeroplanes the streamlines are a very important feature. The nose is tapered, the engines are made narrow and slender, the wing-struts have sharp edges, and the whole machine is built as low as possible with the cockpit almost invisible. In high-speed aeroplanes a device is used to retract the wheels when the plane has left the ground.

Our locomotives have not been so quick as our cars and aeroplanes to adopt streamline principles because of the vast expense which would be necessary to make alterations and new designs, but early experiments were made by curving the flat surfaces on the front of the engine and by giving a streamline shape to the funnel and other projections. Germany and America were the first to experiment with streamlined trains made up of a single coach. These coaches held about sixty people and they rapidly reached speeds of over one hundred miles an hour. One of the earliest of these streamlined trains was the German 'Hamburger'.

If we look at a picture of a rifle bullet in its flight we can see the ripples in the air caused by the bullet. They look much like the ripples caused by the wash of a ship, but they also show that after air has been pushed aside by the nose of the bullet it closes in again at a certain distance behind. The shape of this air-flow, as it is called, is very important as regards streamlining, for in it lies the secret of how to build a perfect streamlined model.

The perfect model is one which follows exactly the line of the air-flow. The streamlined bodies of fishes and birds are accurately formed by Nature to cause practically no friction with the flow of the air or water, through which they glide. In motor vehicles the ideal shape looks rather like a cigar with its narrow end pointing backwards. If a car is built squarely at the back it will cause suction which lessens speed. Any gaps or projections at the sides will also cause eddies in the air of a similar kind. The open window of a moving train causes suction, so the perfect streamlined model would have to keep its windows shut and use other means to purify the air inside the carriages.

In time the principle of streamlining will be applied to other things besides cars and aeroplanes. Tall factory chimneys are built to offer as little resistance as possible to the wind. The new lofty factories are designed with the same object in view, and probably, in time, there

will be far fewer projections in ordinary buildings than are now common. It will take, however, many years for the science of streamlining to accomplish much in this direction. In the first place, it would be expensive to scrap all our present trains, ships, factories, shops and houses, and secondly, most people do not like to have ways of life changed too suddenly.

At the same time we do not gain anything by simply copying old ideas. There are always improvements to be made, for it is a law of life that everything must either change or perish.

NOTES

'streamline	:	to give something a smooth even shape so that it can move quickly and easily through air or water
Red Indians	:	Original inhabitants of North America whose skin is the colour of copper. Contemporary native Americans are usually referred to as American Indians (or in the USA as just Indians)
ca'noe	:	a light narrow boat moved by one or more paddles
prow	:	the pointed front part of a ship or a boat
old crocks	:	old cars in bad condition
pro'jection	:	extensions beyond or above a surface, something that protrudes from a surface
'radiator	:	a device for cooling the engine of a vehicle or an aircraft
'taper	:	make or become gradually narrower towards one end
'slender	:	thin or narrow
'wing-,strut	:	a bar used to support or strengthen wings of an aircraft
re'tract	:	to draw something in or back. In the context of an aircraft: to draw up (landing equipment, etc.) into main body
'funnel	:	a vertical exhaust pipe on a steam engine through which smoke escapes
the wash of a ship	:	an area of water that has waves and is moving a lot, especially after a ship/boat has moved through it; the sound made by this
'eddies	:	circular movements of air, dust or water

COMPREHENSION

1. What are the three chief ways by which speed can be increased?
2. What is air-resistance?
3. Why do birds draw up legs when they are in flight?
4. What should be done to sharp angles and projections if we want to streamline a car or an aeroplane?
5. Where are the wheels positioned in high-speed aeroplanes when the planes leave the ground?
6. Which was one of the earliest streamlined trains introduced in Germany?
7. What happens if a car is built squarely at the back?
8. What does friction do to the speed of a vehicle?

COMPOSITION

1. Why has streamlining gained significance in modern times?
2. How is air-resistance related to streamlining?
3. What are the possible ways in which air-resistance can be minimized?
4. Besides cars and aeroplanes, to which other things will the principle of streamlining be applied in future?

Exercise 1
Fill in the blanks with appropriate *conjunctions:*

1. Always remember _____ regular _____ frequent practice is essential _____ you are to learn to write well.
2. _____ they write these ideas down at once, they often forget them.
3. It is many years _____ I last had an opportunity to see you, _____ you have now become famous.
4. Such particles are, of course, extremely small, _____ their number is also great, _____ incredibly large amounts of solid matter can be transported in this way.
5. _____ a few years ago little attention was given to air-resistance, _____ today streamlining of vehicles is being developed to overcome it.
6. If we walk slowly we do not feel the air on our face, _____ if we run, _____ ride in an open car, it seems _____ a strong wind is blowing at us.
7. _____ we look at a picture of a rifle bullet in its flight, we can see the ripples in the air caused by the bullet.

Exercise 2
Fill in the blanks with appropriate *articles:*

1. Streamlining is really _____ very old idea used in _____ modern way.
2. In _____ modern world many new problems have arisen owing to _____ invention of _____ steam engine and _____ petrol engine.
3. Speed of transport has become _____ greatest feature of _____ modern industrial world.
4. We can improve _____ engine, we can improve _____ fuel which drives _____ engine, we can reduce _____ air-resistance.
5. To reduce this friction to _____ lowest possible fraction is _____ object of streamlining.
6. Most of our older types of vehicles were designed without any attention to _____ surface they offered to _____ air.
7. It is when vehicles reach _____ terrific speeds of today that _____ problem becomes _____ serious one.
8. If we walk slowly we do not feel _____ air on our face, but if we run, or ride in _____ open car, it seems as if _____ strong wind is blowing at us.
9. In aeroplanes _____ streamlines are _____ very important feature.
10. _____ perfect model is one which follows exactly _____ line of _____ airflow.

Exercise 3
Change the *voice:*

1. Long ago when the Red Indian shaped his canoe or carved his arrowheads he was following out this idea.
2. Rapid transport saves valuable time.
3. There are three chief ways by which speed can be increased.
4. The air resists our efforts to push it aside.
5. Let us understand the reason for this.
6. If we walk slowly we do not feel the air on our face.
7. Nature affords many examples of the way to overcome air-resistance.
8. The open window of a moving train causes suction.

GRAMMAR: TYPES OF SENTENCES

A *complex sentence* is a sentence that has a main clause and one or more subordinate clauses.

The sentence, 'I know that she works hard' is a complex sentence and the clause 'that she works hard' is a subordinate clause. The following sentences are examples of complex sentences:

1. Read your work over critically after you have finished it.
2. I gave this example to emphasize that this common substance is the most wonderful thing on the face of our earth.
3. Imagine that you are a stranger who is not familiar with the things that you see around you.

A *compound sentence* contains two or more coordinating or main clauses.

The sentence 'Men played golf, women enjoyed riding, and children played football' is a compound sentence as it contains three coordinating clauses. Some examples of compound sentences are:

1. Forget about yourself, think only of the reader and write naturally.
2. You learn to write by writing and you learn to speak by speaking.
3. Prefer the concrete to the abstract word whenever possible, be definite, call a spade a spade, and avoid euphemisms.

A sentence which is neither compound nor complex can be said to be a *simple sentence.*

'She works hard' is a simple sentence as it contains only one clause which is the main clause. The following sentences are also simple sentences:

1. Use a good dictionary to help you with the exact meaning of words.
2. You are a stranger in this town.
3. Try to develop a warm, human understanding of people.

Exercise 1

In the following sentences locate the *clauses*. If a sentence has more than one clause, identify each of them as *main clause*, *subordinate clause/coordinate clause*:

1. The true elixir of life lies near our hands.
2. The conservation and utilization of water is fundamental for human welfare.
3. I could give this example and I could give many others.
4. Geologists tell us that the entire soil of the Nile valley is the creation of the river.
5. Water is the basis of all life but man seems ignorant of this fact.
6. It has played a role of vast significance in shaping the course of the earth's history and it continues to play the leading role in the drama of life on the surface of our planet.

Exercise 2

Given below are some sentences. Identify the following sentences as *simple*, *compound* or *complex*.

1. Read the newspaper carefully.
2. What made this wonderful difference?
3. It is best to write simply and in a conversational tone.
4. Leave your scripts on your desk and leave the room.
5. Plain English is the fashion these days and an elaborate decorated style is quite out of date.
6. Every day there are examples of human joy and human tragedy in the newspapers which can give you ideas for articles, essays or short stories.
7. Much of Indian agriculture depends on seasonal rainfall so it is very sensitive to any failure or irregularity of rain.
8. He could not bear the sight of the accident.
9. When I got home, it was past four o'clock.
10. The availability of electric power would make a tremendous difference to the life in the countryside and enable our rural economy to be improved in various ways.

Part III
POETRY

11

ON HIS BLINDNESS

JOHN MILTON

John Milton (1608–74) was born in London and with a few intermissions lived there for his entire life. From an early age he showed prodigious talent as a student of languages. He mastered not only Latin and Greek but also Hebrew and a number of other European languages. After taking his M.A. he retired to his father's country house at Horton and devoted himself completely to scholarly pursuits. From 1640 onwards he became increasingly active as a supporter of the Puritan cause against the Royalists. In 1642, when the Parliament dominated by the Puritans ended monarchy in England and established the Commonwealth, Milton was appointed Latin Secretary to the Committee for Foreign Affairs. In spite of failing eyesight he kept writing pamphlets to promote the Puritan cause. By the age of forty-five, Milton had become totally blind. It was at this stage that he wrote the sonnet 'On His Blindness'.

Upon the restoration of monarchy in 1660, Milton was arrested, two of his books were publicly burnt, and for a while his life was under threat. While the timely intervention of his friends saved his life, it could not secure his property or his political stature. Living in poverty and political isolation, he set about completing a poem which was to make him immortal. He published *Paradise Lost* in 1667, which was instantly recognized as an epic of the highest order. Later he wrote two other significant poetic works: *Paradise Regained* and *Samson Agonistes*.

Milton is often regarded as the most sublime of English poets and a supreme exponent of 'the grand style'. He possessed tremendous descriptive powers and handled blank verse with characteristic aplomb.

'On His Blindness' is one of the most famous of Milton's sonnets. A sonnet is a poem of fourteen lines, with varying rhyme schemes. The Italian or Petrarchan sonnet begins with an octave or eight-line section, which poses a problem, and concludes with a sestet or six-line section, in which the problem is resolved. The English sonnet or the Shakespearean sonnet falls into three quatrains, or three four-line sections, and a concluding couplet. The present sonnet follows the Petrarchan pattern. In this sonnet the turn in thought occurs in the middle of the eighth line.

Like a number of Milton's poems, which drew inspiration from *The Bible*, 'On His Blindness' also contains several biblical allusions. The sonnet is explicitly autobiographical and captures Milton's deep anguish over the loss of his sight. In fact, since his early youth he aspired to 'leave something so

written to aftertimes, as they should not willingly let it die.' The poet expresses his regret at his inability to produce a work of art commensurate with the prodigious talent he is endowed with. Like the servant in the biblical parable who was taken to task by his master for keeping unused the money given to him, the poet fears that he will be admonished by his Maker for dereliction of duty. But then an inner voice reminds him that God is not in need of man's services. Those willing servants who patiently wait on Him probably serve Him as much as those who run errands for Him. And those who submit to the will of God in all humility serve Him best. The poem, thus, ends on a note of reconciliation.

When I consider how my light is spent,
Ere half my days, in this dark world and wide,
And that one talent which is death to hide
Lodged with me useless, though my soul more bent
To serve therewith my Maker, and present
My true account, lest he returning chide;
'Doth God exact day-labour, light denied?'
I fondly ask. But Patience, to prevent
That murmur, soon replies, 'God doth not need
Either man's work or his own gifts. Who best
Bear his mild yoke, they serve him best. His state
Is kingly: thousands at his bidding speed,
And post o'er land and ocean without rest;
They also serve who only stand and wait.'

NOTES

'talent : Refers to Milton's poetic talent and also to the silver coins mentioned in the parable in St Matthew's Gospel (25: 14–30). The servant in the parable did not make use of the money given to him by his master but kept it buried, and he was, on that account, scolded by his master. Milton is afraid that he too would meet a similar fate for not putting to proper use the poetic talent given to him by God.

death to hide : Milton fears that if he does not put to proper use the God-given talent of writing poetry, he will have to die a spiritual death.

day-labour : labour which can be performed only with the light of eyesight. In Milton's case it relates to poetic creation, a task which Milton thinks he cannot perform after he has become blind.

'fondly : foolishly

pre'vent : forestall

mild yoke : Yoke is a piece of wood placed across the necks of oxen pulling a cart or a plough. In the present context it refers to God's control over man's existence. 'Mild' here is a transferred epithet. Thus to bear Almighty's yoke (= will) mildly is to be His true servant.

post : travel with speed

COMPREHENSION

1. Explain: 'how my light is spent/Ere half my days.'
2. What is 'that one talent' the poet refers to in the poem?
3. 'But Patience, to prevent/That murmur, soon replies': What is 'that murmur'?
4. Which power within the poet prevents the 'murmur'? What reply does it give?
5. Explain: 'They also serve who only stand and wait.'
6. What brings solace to the poet?
7. Those who carry out God's orders serve Him. Who else also serve God?
8. What words suggest that the poet thinks of God as a hard task-master?

COMPOSITION

1. What is the main idea of this sonnet?
2. Describe how the poem begins on a note of sadness but ends in a mood of acceptance and resignation.
3. Is God in need of man's services? Explain in the light of the above poem.
4. Why does the poet feel guilty? How does he overcome his feeling of guilt?
5. Explain: 'Who best/Bear his mild yoke, they serve him best.'

GRAMMAR: SOUNDS OF ENGLISH

To speak English well, you have to learn its correct pronunciation. Many languages are used by the people living in different parts of our country. Even people in a small state like Himachal Pradesh use many dialects which are quite different from one another. A local variety of English pronunciation is developed by using the sound patterns of the mother tongue or the first language of a learner. This may not be fully intelligible to native speakers of English or even to the educated Indians living in other parts of India. Different accents by speakers from different parts of the world increase the problem. In order to be reasonably intelligible, acquiring the correct speech sounds of English is important.

Unfortunately, there is *no perfect correspondence between letters and sounds in English* as we have in Indian languages. In words like:

read field greed key seize people	the letters	ea ie ee ey ei eo	represent the same vowel sound /i:/

or in words like:

knife	letter 'k' is not pronounced as it is silent
kite	letter 'k' is pronounced as /k/
cow	letter 'c' is pronounced as /k/

There are more sounds in the English language than there are letters in the alphabet. It is, therefore, necessary to learn about all the vowel and consonant sounds in English and we should not confuse them with the spellings of words.

Each sound in English is distinct, and the substitution of one sound for another may either bring about a change in meaning or lead to the production of a word that does not sound like an English word at all. In order to avoid this confusion one must be able to distinguish one sound from another.

For example, one should be able to distinguish between pairs of words like:

1. peak and pick
2. mate and met
3. set and sat
4. cut and cart
5. hard and heard
6. cut and cot
7. lust and lost
8. full and fool
9. here and hair
10. seat and sheet
11. pen and fen
12. bat and fat

Such pairs of words which differ only in one sound are called *minimal pairs*. The English sound system has 20 vowel sounds (12 pure vowels and 8 diphthongs) and 24 consonant sounds. In vowel sounds the breath flows out freely through the mouth without being obstructed and there is no friction. In consonant sounds the passage of air stream through the mouth is either briefly stopped and then released or the passage is so narrow that air moves through it with some measure of friction.

Thus, to speak English well and correctly one has to maintain the requisite distinctions between significant sounds in the language. One must learn to refer to a dictionary regularly for the correct pronunciation of words. In the dictionary, symbols are used to represent sounds and one symbol stands for one sound only. It is important to learn these symbols and the sound each symbol represents.

Students are advised to have a personal copy of any of the standard dictionaries prescribed for the undergraduate classes. These are:

Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary of Current English, 6th edition; or
Longman Dictionary of Contemporary English; or
Collins Cobuild Dictionary.

Daniel Jones's, *Everyman's English Pronouncing Dictionary*, 15th ed. (Cambridge University Press) is a comprehensive dictionary of pronunciation. A low price Indian reprint of this dictionary is also available.

English Vowel Sounds

In this course you will be introduced to the sounds of the English language and to the manner in which they are represented on paper. Phonemic transcription is the term used to represent the sounds of a language on paper. Phonetic symbols are written within slashes (/ /) to distinguish them from ordinary letters.

The phonemic symbols are those used in the Oxford *Advanced Learner's Dictionary of Current English*, 6th ed., and Daniel Jones's *English Pronouncing Dictionary*, 15th ed. Dictionaries provide the RP or the *Received Pronunciation* of a word. RP is also known as BBC English; this is the pronunciation of professional speakers employed by the BBC as newsreaders and announcers on the World Service of BBC radio and television. Nowadays, however, with changed notions of what is 'standard', it is not insisted upon.

There are many differences in how sounds are articulated in RP and Standard Indian English. For instance, in RP the final 'r' is not pronounced, as in words like *here*, *there*, *poor* unless followed by a vowel sound; therefore, in phonemic transcriptions it is given in brackets. Indian speakers usually pronounce it even when not followed by a vowel sound.

A diphthong (or mixed vowel) is considered a single sound. In a diphthong the quality of sound changes quickly from one vowel sound to another.

The English RP sound system has 20 vowel sounds. Of these, 12 are pure vowels and 8 are mixed vowels (also known as *diphthongs*). Given below are the phonemic symbols for the vowels and diphthongs along with the keywords in the production of which the particular vowel sounds are pronounced.

Phonemic symbols	*Keyword (the letters representing the sound in question has been underlined)*	*Phonemic transcription of the keyword*
Pure vowels		
1. / /	as in sheep	/ /
2. / /	as in sit	/ /
3. / /	as in set	/ /
4. / /	as in sat	/ /

5.	/	/	as in	calm	/	/
6.	/	/	as in	pot	/	/
7.	/	/	as in	caught	/	/
8.	/	/	as in	full	/	/
9.	/	/	as in	fool	/	/
10.	/	/	as in	cut	/	/
11.	/	/	as in	bird	/	/
12.	/	/	as in	a'bout	/	/

Diphthongs

13.	/	/	as in	day	/	/
14.	/	/	as in	no	/	/
15.	/	/	as in	five	/	/
16.	/	/	as in	now	/	/
17.	/	/	as in	boy	/	/
18.	/	/	as in	near	/	/
19.	/	/	as in	there	/	/
20.	/	/	as in	poor	/	/

12

THE ECHOING GREEN

William Blake

William Blake (1757–1827) was born in London. Taught informally at home by his own mother who took tremendous personal interest in his education, Blake was extremely well-read in literature and well-versed in several languages, including French, Italian, Latin, Greek and Hebrew. He led a fairly simple and uneventful social life, but his spiritual life was quite exceptional. Gifted with a vivid and fertile imagination, Blake peopled his world with symbolic characters. He was an engraver by profession, and except for his first collection of poems, *Poetical Sketches*, he himself etched his poems and prophetic books on copper plates, with decorative designs.

Blake published *Songs of Innocence* in 1789, which was followed by *Songs of Experience* in 1794. The two were republished later as a single volume under the title *Songs of Innocence and of Experience*. The poems contained in this volume depict the two contrary states of human soul. In *Songs of Innocence* Blake evokes the picture of a world of pastoral innocence and uncorrupted childhood where joy is the reigning principle. These poems look at the world from the viewpoint of innocent children who are as yet unaware of the existence of evil in human society. *Songs of Experience*, on the contrary, envision a world which is rife with repression, disease, poverty, and exploitation. Blake's other major works include *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell, The Book of Thel, Visions of the Daughters of Albion, Urizen, The Four Zoas, Milton,* and *Jerusalem.*

'The Echoing Green' has the lucidity and directness which characterize Blake's *Songs of Innocence*. The poem can also be read as an extended metaphor for the progress of human life through its different stages. The Green, i.e. the open green space, comes alive with the cheerful shouts of children and the joyous chirping of birds. While the children play, the old folk relax under an oak tree. These old people feel happy as they watch the children at play and are reminded of their own childhood. As old John 'Does laugh away care', he momentarily shakes off the problems of his day-to-day life and shares the carefree laughter of the children.

No negative emotion of fear, despair, pain or grief ruffles the serenity which suffuses the Green. After spending the fun-filled day on the Green, the children return home at sunset, tired but fulfilled, to the protective warmth of their mothers' laps.

The Sun does arise
And make happy the skies,
The merry bells ring
To welcome the Spring,
The skylark and thrush,
The birds of the bush,
Sing louder around
To the bells' cheerful sound,
While our sports shall be seen
On the Echoing Green.

Old John with white hair
Does laugh away care,
Sitting under the oak
Among the old folk.
They laugh at our play,
And soon they all say:
"Such, such were the joys
When we all, girls and boys,
In our youth-time were seen
On the Echoing Green."

Till the little ones, weary,
No more can be merry;
The sun does descend,
And our sports have an end.
Round the laps of their mothers
Many sisters and brothers,
Like birds in their nest,
Are ready for rest,
And sport no more seen
On the darkening Green.

NOTES

the Echoing Green : an open green space or a playground in the village, reverberating with noise made by the children and the birds
'weary : tired
de'scend : come down or go down

COMPREHENSION

1. Name the birds which sing to welcome the spring.
2. What purpose does the ringing of merry bells serve in the poem?
3. Where does old John sit?

4. Who watch the children playing on the Echoing Green?
5. What do the old folk say when they see the children playing?
6. When does the play come to an end?
7. Where do the children go when the sport on the Green ends?
8. What happens to the Echoing Green at the end of the day?

COMPOSITION

1. Describe the effect of the sun on the village Green.
2. Describe the activities that take place on the village Green during the day.
3. Give the substance of the poem.
4. Describe how the 'Echoing Green' turns into 'darkening Green' at the end of the day.

GRAMMAR: ENGLISH CONSONANT SOUNDS

The English RP Sound System has 24 consonant sounds. In English there is often no one-to-one relationship between the letters of the alphabet and the sounds they represent. For example, the sound / tʃ / is represented by two letters: 'ch'. Phonemic transcription is a device to represent on paper the way in which words are pronounced in English. Given below are the phonemic symbols for consonants along with the keywords in the production of which the particular consonant sounds are pronounced:

	Phonemic symbols	*Keyword (the letter representing the sound in question has been underlined)*	*Phonemic transcription of the keyword*
1.	/ /	as in pen	/ /
2.	/ /	as in back	/ /
3.	/ /	as in tea	/ /
4.	/ /	as in din	/ /
5.	/ /	as in kin	/ /
6.	/ /	as in gun	/ /
7.	/ /	as in chin	/ /
8.	/ /	as in jump	/ /
9.	/ /	as in fan	/ /
10.	/ /	as in van	/ /
11.	/ /	as in thing	/ /
12.	/ /	as in then	/ /
13.	/ /	as in sip	/ /
14.	/ /	as in zip	/ /
15.	/ /	as in ship	/ /
16.	/ /	as in 'pleasure	/ /

17.	/	/	as in	hat	/ /
18.	/	/	as in	led	/ /
19.	/	/	as in	red	/ /
20.	/	/	as in	man	/ /
21.	/	/	as in	no	/ /
22.	/	/	as in	king	/ /
23.	/	/	as in	yes	/ /
24.	/	/	as in	wet	/ /

Thus, the English RP sound system at the word level has 44 sounds (20 vowels + 24 consonants) and three levels of stress (main stress, secondary stress and weak stress).

The main stress mark is shown as /ˈ/ as in aˈbout / / above the line and the secondary stress mark is shown as / ˌ / below the line as in ˌacademic / /. Weak stress is not marked.

13

THE WORLD IS TOO MUCH WITH US

William Wordsworth

William Wordsworth (1770–1850) was born in Cockermouth in West Cumberland, just on the northern fringe of the Lake District of England, a region rich in natural beauty in its calmer aspects. He spent much of his boyhood 'drinking in' (Wordsworth's favourite metaphor) the scenic beauty of his native country, mixing freely with such simple characters as a shepherd or a leech-gatherer. These plain country characters and the sights and sounds of Cumberland had a profound influence on his personality and were immortalized in his poetry. He believed that someone who lived in harmony with nature could easily attain happiness and peace of mind.

Wordsworth enjoyed a long and creative relationship with Coleridge. Their friendship and mutual admiration led to the publication of an epoch-making book, *Lyrical Ballads*, in 1798, which launched a new movement in English poetry popularly known as the Romantic Movement.

The French Revolution of 1789 had a deep impact on Wordsworth. He even made several trips to France, but for some personal reasons he could not take an active part in the Revolution. Later, the reign of terror let loose in France rudely shook his faith in the abstract principles behind the Revolution, and he even recanted his progressive ideas of youth. This change in Wordsworth's attitude was lamented by Robert Browning in his poem 'The Lost Leader'. Wordsworth's major poems include *The Prelude*, 'Tintern Abbey', 'Ode on the Intimations of Immortality', *The Excursion*, 'The Recluse', and 'Resolution and Independence'.

Like Milton's 'On His Blindness', Wordsworth's sonnet 'The World Is Too Much With Us' also follows the Petrarchan pattern; here the turn in thought occurs in the middle of the ninth line. Arnold's observation that Wordsworth excels in his shorter pieces seems apt if one considers the artistic excellence of the poem. Deeply meditative in nature, the poem speaks against the soul-destroying nature of modern civilization. Modern civilization traps us in the vicious cycle of earning and spending money, which blunt our natural ability to respond to the splendid spectacles of nature with joy. Wordsworth feels that in this respect the pagans of ancient time were more fortunate because they could appreciate the beauty of changing forms of nature personified in their gods like Proteus and Triton. Through this sonnet the poet makes a strong appeal to the people of his generation to give up their blind pursuit of wealth; they should, instead, seek such pleasures of life as can be attained through a keen observation of the myriad sights and sounds of nature.

The world is too much with us; late and soon,
Getting and spending, we lay waste our powers;
Little we see in Nature that is ours;
We have given our hearts away, a sordid boon!
This Sea that bares her bosom to the moon;
The winds that will be howling at all hours,
And are up-gathered now like sleeping flowers;
For this, for everything, we are out of tune;
It moves us not.—Great God! I'd rather be
A Pagan suckled in a creed outworn;
So might I, standing on this pleasant lea,
Have glimpses that would make me less forlorn;
Have sight of Proteus rising from the sea;
Or hear old Triton blow his wreathed horn.

NOTES

lay waste our powers	:	we waste our spiritual powers by spending our time and energy in amassing and spending wealth
'sordid	:	dirty and unpleasant, displaying meanness ('sordid boon' refers to material gains)
howl	:	loud cry or a similar noise made by a strong wind
'pagan	:	a person who is not a believer in any of the world's chief religions. Christian writers often use the word 'paganism' to refer to pre-Christian religions that worshipped different forces of nature personified as gods and goddesses
'suckle	:	feed (a baby or a young animal) with milk from the breast or udder (here, nurture)
creed	:	system of belief or opinions
lea	:	meadow
for'lorn	:	lonely and unhappy
'Proteus	:	in Greek mythology Proteus was a sea god who could assume any shape
'Triton	:	a minor sea god who could soothe restless waves of the sea by blowing a conch-shell trumpet

COMPREHENSION

1. What does the title of the poem mean?
2. How do we lay waste our powers?
3. What have the winds been compared with?
4. What would the poet like to be in order to enjoy nature?
5. Why would the poet like to be a pagan?
6. What effect does an undue involvement in materialistic pursuits have on people?
7. Explain: 'We have given our hearts away, a sordid boon!'

COMPOSITION

1. How has materialism affected us?
2. Why does nature fail to move us?
3. In what ways would the poet like the people to change?
4. Give the central idea of the poem.

GRAMMAR: WORD STRESS AND SYLLABLES

Words are made up of one or more individually pronounced parts, called *syllables*.

A syllable must contain a vowel sound (known as the nucleus) and it may also contain one or more consonants.

For example, the word 'I' has only one speech sound which is a vowel (the nucleus) and is a one syllable word.

The word 'pen' has three speech sounds consisting of one vowel (the nucleus) and two consonants and is also a one syllable word.

The word 'pencil' has two syllables 'pen.cil'.

It is easier to understand a syllable in terms of air-stream mechanism. When we speak, the air from the lungs does not come out in a continuous stream. The muscles of the chest push the air out in small puffs (approximately five times in a second) and each puff of air produces a syllable.

For example, when we say the word 'up' it is spoken with one puff of air and it consists of one syllable.

But when we pronounce the word 'upper' it is spoken with two puffs of air 'up.per', therefore, it consists of two syllables.

And when we say the word 'accident' it is spoken with three puffs of air 'ac.ci.dent', so it consists of three syllables.

English is a rhythmic language. Its rhythm depends on the stressed syllables in a speech segment. It takes roughly the same amount of time to move from one stressed syllable to another stressed syllable irrespective of the number of unstressed (or weak stressed) syllables in between, whose sounds tend to be shortened.

When we speak English not all syllables in a word are equally prominent; some syllables are louder or more prominent. These are said to be stressed. In words of two or more syllables, at least one syllable stands out from the rest and we say it has greater *stress*. In terms of air-stream mechanism, when the puff of air in speaking a word is produced with greater effort, it is called a stressed syllable.

For example, in saying *upper* the stress is on the first syllable *'up.per*; it is a two syllable word.

In saying *accident* the stress is on the first syllable *'ac.ci.dent*; it is a three syllable word.

In saying *already* the stress is on the second syllable *al.'read.y*; it is a three syllable word.

The *main stress* (also known as the *primary stress*) is shown as a vertical bar (') placed above and before the syllable that carries the main stress in the word.

For example, words like *upper, unit, after, accident,* have stress on the first syllable:
'up.per 'u.nit 'af.ter 'ac.ci.dent
whereas words like *correct, recall, already*, have stress on the second syllable:
cor.'rect re.'call al.'read.y

Usually words with more than two syllables have a **secondary stress** which is shown as a vertical bar (,) placed below and before the syllable that carries the secondary stress:

understand	,un.der.'stand
education	,ed.u.'ca.tion
conversation	,con.ver.'sa.tion

Stress is a permanent property of the word. It is also obligatory. It is indicated in a standard dictionary.

It is not always possible to show syllabic division in ordinary spelling. The correct syllabic division can be shown with the phonemic transcription of a word because a transcription indicates the actual way in which the word is pronounced. However, for the convenience of students and to develop the habit of correct pronounciation, a list has been given of common words in ordinary spelling with stress and possible syllabic division marked.

An important feature of spoken English is word accent. Content words are generally accented, be they monosyllabic or polysyllabic. Content words are nouns, adjectives, main verbs, adverbs, demonstrative and interrogative pronouns. Structure words, i.e. articles, personal and relative pronouns, prepositions, conjunctions and auxiliaries are normally not stressed. In monosyllabic words, stress mark is not indicated. But if it is a content word, the entire monosyllabic word is stressed. We normally use the weak, unstressed forms of structure words in English. In words of two or more syllables it is obligatory to indicate the stress mark (') on the accented syllable.

Please note that words with one syllable may consist of one or more letters. This is because the syllable belongs to the sound system of the language and the spelling in a word belongs to the writing system of the language.

Exercise 1
Indicate syllabic divisions of each of the words given below.

For example, canteen—can.teen.
copper, biscuit, breakfast, contain, examination, irritating, collocations, rigid.

Exercise 2
Find one syllable words in English which have one to eight letters.

For example, 1 – a 3 – the
2 – an

14

A BIRD CAME DOWN THE WALK

EMILY DICKINSON

Emily Dickinson (1830–1886) occupies a position of pre-eminence in American literature. Born in Amherst, a sleepy village in the Connecticut valley of Massachusetts, Dickinson lived an outwardly quiet life, but was secretly driven by a desire to write poetry about issues that were of concern to her, including those of love, life, death, and immortality.

Dickinson was an unusually reticent person, and whatever little we know about her emotional life comes by way of inference from her poems and letters. She guarded her poems so closely that even her immediate family was astonished when after her death they chanced on a box filled with her poems.

In many of her finest poems, Dickinson explores the nature of pain, its effect upon human soul, and its relation with death. She treats the subject of death in more than five hundred of her lyrics. Dickinson's attitude to death, however, is not one of morbidity and negation: if death, for her, results in despair and terror, it also brings peace and rest and enhances one's enjoyment of life.

Emily Dickinson's poetry is notable for its stylistic peculiarities. Her poems are short, swift and breathless, stripped of all extraneous luxuriance. Individual words inspired awe in her: these organic entities had a life of their own and were charged with imperishable significance. Frugality, reticence and simplicity are the outstanding features of her poetry. Her use of unconventional metaphors, ungrammatical phrasing, frequent use of dashes have greatly influenced twentieth century poets and contributed to Dickinson's recognition as one of the most innovative American poets.

Read literally, 'A Bird Came Down the Walk' is a minutely-observed and beautifully-worded description of a bird as it comes down a walk, eats a worm, drinks a dewdrop, darts a few furtive glances in the direction of suspicious human activity and flies away upon sensing danger.

At another level, the poem offers a new perspective on the relationship between the world of human beings and the world of nature. The poet suggests that even when human beings seek to participate in the world of nature with the best of intentions, their efforts can seem intrusive. The life of the bird, which is in tune with nature, goes on uninterrupted until it is disturbed by the unwelcome spectator who steps in to participate in its life. Unable to comprehend human intentions, the bird reacts with suspicion and fear. Its fear is suggested by the rapid and

hurried movement of its eyes, which look like 'frightened beads'. The poet tries to allay the bird's fear by offering it a crumb, little realizing that her intentions would be misunderstood. Moreover, nature has already supplied sufficient food for the bird, and the bird rejects the poet's useless offer of a crumb. The poem highlights nature's superior self-sufficiency; man's longing for an active role in the non-human world is likely to be resisted. The poem reaches its aesthetic climax in the concluding stanza, which captures in superb images the silky smooth flight of the bird away from the human presence.

A bird came down the walk:
He did not know I saw;
He bit an angle-worm in halves
And ate the fellow, raw.

And then he drank a dew
From a convenient grass,
And then hopped sidewise to the wall
To let a beetle pass.

He glanced with rapid eyes
That hurried all abroad,—
They looked like frightened beads, I thought
He stirred his velvet head

Like one in danger; cautious,
I offered him a crumb,
And he unrolled his feathers
And rowed him softer home

Than oars divide the ocean,
Too silver for a seam,
Or butterflies, off banks of noon,
Leap, plashless, as they swim.

NOTES

'angle-worm	:	earthworm (used as a bait in angling, i.e. fishing)
'beetle	:	a type of insect, often large and black, with hard wing-cases
row	:	propel (a boat) by using oars
oar	:	long pole with a flat blade used for rowing a boat
seam	:	a seam is a line along which two edges, especially of cloth, are joined or sewn together
too silver for a seam	:	the ocean is shining so brightly that even as oars strike the water, no seam or line is seen

plashless	:	without splashing, so softly that no drops fly about
and rowed . . . as they swim	:	the fine and smooth movement of the bird as it flies away is compared to the seamless rowing of a boat in an ocean or the movement of the butterflies as they escape the midday heat by swimming in the liquid coolness of air

COMPREHENSION

1. What did the bird do to the angle-worm?
2. Did the bird know that it was being watched?
3. What did the bird do when it saw the beetle?
4. What did the bird's eyes look like?
5. How is the bird's head described?
6. What did the narrator offer to the bird?
7. What did the bird do when it was offered a crumb?
8. What did the bird drink from 'a convenient grass'?

COMPOSITION

1. How does the poem describe the bird's fear?
2. How is the flight of the bird described in the poem?
3. Comment on the interaction between the narrator and the bird in the poem.
4. Summarize the poem in your own words.

PRONUNCIATION: WORD STRESS – DISYLLABIC WORDS— stress on first syllable

Disyllabic words are words with two syllables. Each of the words listed below has two syllables, and the stress is on the first syllable. In this unit, all the words carry primary stress on the first syllable.

(Main stress has been shown as (ˈ) and the syllabic division has been shown as (.)) Say these words aloud. Put greater stress on the first syllable.

1. 'ac.tion
2. 'al.most
3. 'al.ways
4. 'an.swer
5. 'an.y
6. 'bat.tle
7. 'bet.ter
8. 'bod.y
9. 'broth.er
10. 'busi.ness
11. 'cap.tain
12. 'cer.tain
13. 'cit.y
14. 'col.our
15. 'com.mon
16. 'coun.try
17. 'dif.fer
18. 'doc.tor
19. 'dol.lar
20. 'doz.en
21. 'ear.ly
22. 'ei.ther
23. 'Eng.lish
24. 'e.ven

25. 'eve.ry
26. 'fig.ure
27. 'fol.low
28. 'for.eign
29. 'for.tune
30. 'fre.quent (adj.)
31. 'gar.den
32. 'glo.ry
33. 'gold.en
34. 'gov.ern
35. 'grate.ful
36. 'health.y
37. 'hol.low
38. 'hon.est
39. 'hu.man
40. 'hus.band
41. 'i.dle
42. 'in.sect
43. 'in.stant
44. 'in.terest
45. 'in.to
46. 'jeal.ous
47. 'jour.ney
48. 'judge.ment
49. 'kitch.en
50. 'knowl.edge
51. 'la.dy
52. 'let.ter
53. 'man.y
54. 'meas.ure
55. 'mo.ment
56. 'na.tion
57. 'na.ture
58. 'nev.er
59. 'noth.ing
60. 'num.ber
61. 'of.fer
62. 'o.pen
63. 'oth.er
64. 'out.put
65. 'o.ver
66. 'pa.per
67. 'peo.ple
68. 'per.son
69. 'pres.ent (n./adj.) [but pre.'sent (v.)]
70. 'pub.lic
71. 'quar.ter
72. 'ques.tion
73. 'ra.ther
74. 'rea.son
75. 'riv.er
76. 'sec.ond
77. 'some.thing
78. 'sto.ry
79. 'sub.ject (n./adj.) [but sub.'ject (v.)]
80. 'sys.tem
81. 'ta.ble
82. 'thea.tre
83. 'there.fore
84. 'tick.et
85. 'treas.ure
86. 'un.der
87. 'up.ward
88. 'use.ful
89. 'val.ue
90. 'ver.y
91. 'wat.er
92. 'wel.come
93. 'wheth.er
94. 'win.dow
95. 'wis.dom
96. 'wom.an
97. 'wood.land
98. 'work.man
99. 'wor.ship
100. 'yel.low

Exercise 1

Work with your friend saying each of the words in the above list aloud. Mark stress by beating the table with your palm as you call out each word. Repeat each word twice. Test each other.

15

STOPPING BY WOODS ON A SNOWY EVENING

ROBERT FROST

Robert Frost was born in San Francisco, California (USA) on March 26, 1874. He lost his father quite early in life and had to live in an alien environment in New Hampshire. As a boy he did not show much inclination for study. He worked in mills, took to newspaper reporting, taught in schools and occasionally wrote poetry. As a student at Harvard College, he hoped to prepare himself for college teaching, but he soon realized that academic atmosphere was not congenial to him. In 1912 he and his family moved to England where he published his first book of verse, *A Boy's Will*. The collection was well-received and was soon followed by another collection of poems, *North of Boston*. In 1915 he returned to the USA and settled on a farm in New Hampshire. In 1961 he was specially invited to recite his patriotic poem, 'The Gift Outright', when President Kennedy took office. He died in 1963.

Frost is regarded as a great nature poet, and like Wordsworth wrote about nature as he saw it in a particular district. But compared to Wordsworth, Frost's treatment of nature is more realistic. He does not indulge in idealizing or eulogizing nature. He is captivated by the beauty of a snowfall, a spring thaw or a misty morning, but he keeps a firm hold on reality and remains alert to the possible dangers that may lurk beneath the surface. In fact, the bleak and barren in nature is more characteristic of his nature-sketches. Since he was a practising farmer, rural people and their occupations like apple-picking, mowing, etc. naturally became the subject of his poems. He often employs the simple, colloquial language of the country folk, which appeals to the ordinary readers. But the apparent simplicity of his verse is deceptive. His poems are subtle, complex and have a rich texture. He developed the fine art of stating serious philosophical issues in the simplest possible language. His literary merits have earned him a place of distinction as a major American poet of the twentieth century.

'Stopping by Woods on a Snowy Evening' is one of Frost's best-known lyrics. For Greek writers a lyric was a song rendered to the accompaniment of a lyre. Now the term lyric is used for a fairly short non-narrative poem with a single speaker who expresses a state of mind or a thought process. Lyrics are usually rhymed. However, free verse and blank verse lyrics are not uncommon. The ode, elegy, and sonnet are also forms of the lyric, though they have some distinctive attributes of their own.

Indians have a great affinity for this poem because it touched the heart of Pandit Nehru. His love for the poem came to light when a piece of paper bearing the last four lines of the poem written in his own hand was discovered on his table after his death. The poem makes a deep impact on the reader not only for its thought content but also for its simplicity. The poet stops one evening along a country road to watch the snowfall in the woods. Captivated by the spectacle he slips into a trance-like state and feels tempted to prolong his stay indefinitely. But he knows that he cannot afford the luxury of losing himself completely in this dark and silent whiteness as he has to travel for many miles more before he can rest or 'sleep'. In the concluding line 'sleep' acquires a deeper meaning suggestive of the final sleep, i.e. death. Just as sleep is a deserved reward after a day's labour, death becomes meaningful only after one has undergone a wide range of human experiences and has fulfilled one's obligation to oneself and to society.

Whose woods these are I think I know.
His house is in the village though;
He will not see me stopping here
To watch his woods fill up with snow.

My little horse must think it queer
To stop without a farmhouse near
Between the woods and frozen lake
The darkest evening of the year.

He gives his harness bells a shake
To ask if there is some mistake.
The only other sound's the sweep
Of easy wind and downy flake.

The woods are lovely, dark and deep,
But I have promises to keep,
And miles to go before I sleep,
And miles to go before I sleep.

NOTES

queer	:	strange
'harness	:	equipment consisting of leather straps and metal fittings by which a horse is controlled and fastened to the cart, plough, etc.
downy flake	:	flakes of snow which are soft like feathers ('down' means very fine soft feathers)

COMPREHENSION

1. Why did the narrator stop in the woods?

2. What did the horse possibly think when the poet stopped in the woods?
3. What did the horse do to ask if the poet had stopped in the woods by mistake?
4. The horse made a sound by shaking his harness bells. What other sounds were heard in the woods?
5. Which promises does the poet allude to in the expression 'promises to keep'? What is your guess?
6. How far away was the destination of the poet?

COMPOSITION

1. Describe the central idea of the poem.
2. What made the narrator feel that he must break free of the spell of the snow-filled woods and move on?
3. What special significance does the word 'sleep' have in the poem?
4. Comment on the last two lines of the poem.

PRONUNCIATION: WORD STRESS—DISYLLABIC WORDS—stress on second syllable

In each of the disyllabic words in this unit, the main stress is on the second syllable. Say each of these words aloud. Put greater stress on the second syllable.

1. a.'bout
2. a.'bove
3. a.'broad
4. ac.'cord
5. ac.'count
6. ac.'cent (verb)
   [but 'ac.cent (noun)]
7. ad.'dress
8. ad.'mit
9. a.'dopt
10. ad.'vance
11. af.'fair
12. af.'ford
13. a.'fraid
14. a.'gain
15. a.'gainst
16. a.'go
17. a.'head
18. a.'lone
19. al.'low
20. a.'long
21. a.'mong
22. a.'mount
23. a.'muse
24. a.'part
25. ap.'pear
26. ap.'ply
27. ap.'point
28. a.'rise
29. a.'round
30. ar.'range
31. a.'shamed
32. a.'side
33. a.'sleep
34. at.'tack
35. at.'tempt
36. at.'tend
37. at.'tract
38. a.'void
39. a.'wake
40. a.'way
41. be.'cause
42. be.'come
43. be.'fore

44. be.'gin
45. be.'hind
46. be.'lieve
47. be.'low
48. be.'side
49. be.'tween
50. be.'yond
51. col.'lect
52. com.'bine
53. com.'mand
54. com.'pare
55. com.'plete
56. con.'cern
57. con.'nect
58. con.'tain
59. con.'tent (v./adj.)
    [but 'con.tent (noun)]
60. con.'trol
61. de.'cay
62. de.'ceive
63. de.'cide
64. de.'clare
65. de.'feat
66. de.'fence
67. de.'gree
68. de.'lay
69. de.'light
70. de.'mand
71. de.'pend
72. de.'scend
73. de.'scribe
74. de.'serve
75. de.'sire
76. de.'stroy
77. di.'rect
78. dis.'cuss
79. dis.'ease
80. di.'vide
81. ef.'fect
82. e.'lect
83. em.'ploy
84. en.'close
85. en.'gage
86. en.'joy
87. e.'nough
88. en.'tire
89. es.'cape
90. e.'vent
91. ex.'act
92. ex.'cept
93. ex.'change
94. ex.'ist
95. ex.'pect
96. ex.'pense
97. ex.'plain
98. ex.'press
99. ex.'tend
100. ex.'treme
101. for.'bid
102. for.'get
103. for.'give
104. ho.'tel
105. im.'prove
106. in.'clude
107. in.'crease (verb)
     [but 'in.crease (noun)]
108. in.'deed
109. in.'stead
110. in.'tend
111. ma.'chine
112. mis.'take
113. my.'self
114. ne.'glect
115. o.'bey
116. ob.'ject (verb)
     [but 'ob.ject (noun)]
117. ob.'serve
118. of.'fend
119. o.'mit
120. op.'pose
121. per.'haps
122. per.'mit (verb)
     [but 'per.mit (noun)]
123. pos.'sess
124. pre.'pare
125. pre.'serve
126. pre.'vent
127. pro.'duce (verb)
     [but 'pro.duce (noun)]
128. pro.'pose
129. pro.'tect
130. pro.'vide

131. re.'ceive
132. re.'duce
133. re.'fer
134. re.'flect
135. re.'fuse(v)/ 'ref.use(n)
136. re.'gard
137. re.'main
138. re.'gret
139. re.'mark
140. re.'mind
141. re.'peat
142. re.'ply
143. re.'port
144. re.'quest
145. re.'serve
146. re.'spect
147. re.'sult
148. re.'tire
149. re.'turn
150 re.'view
151. suc.'ceed
152. sug.'gest
153. sup.'port
154. sup.'pose
155. to.'day
156. to.'wards
157. un.'less
158. up.'on
159. with.'in
160. with.'out
161. your.'self

Exercise 1
Work with your friend saying each of the words in the above list aloud. Mark stress by beating the table with your palm as you call out each word. Repeat each word twice. Test each other.

16

PALANQUIN-BEARERS

SAROJINI NAIDU

Sarojini Naidu (1879–1949) was the eldest daughter of the poet Varada Sundari and the distinguished educator Aghorenath Chattopadhyay. She entered Madras University at the young age of twelve and went on to study at King's College, London, and Girton College, Cambridge. Her family was steeped in art and literature. Poets, intellectuals and revolutionaries were regular visitors to her home. Multiple cultural influences, including the Muslim culture of Hyderabad, the Hindu ethos of her family and her English education shaped the young Sarojini. When she was fifteen, she fell in love with Govindaraju Naidu, a widower ten years her senior, whom she married in a controversial intercaste marriage.

Her poetic career, as she herself wrote, began when she was barely eleven years old. 'I was sighing over a sum in Algebra: it wouldn't come right; but instead a whole poem came to me suddenly. From that day, my "poetic career" began.' Her early poems lack originality in terms of theme as well as style: the influence of English literature, English ethos and English setting seems all-pervasive. Edmund Gosse, to whom she showed some of her poems, found her efforts misdirected and advised her to strive for a poetic flavour more true to her immediate experience. Her first volume of poetry, *The Golden Threshold*, appeared in 1905. In 1914 she was elected a fellow of the Royal Society of Literature. Her collected poems have been published under the titles *The Sceptred Flute* and *The Feather of the Dawn.*

Besides writing poetry, Sarojini Naidu was deeply involved in nationalist politics. She came into prominence when she delivered a fiery speech at a meeting of the Indian National Congress in Calcutta in 1906. She worked closely with Mahatma Gandhi, was elected president of the INC in 1925, participated in Salt Satyagraha in 1930, and became Governor of Uttar Pradesh in 1947, a post she retained till her death in 1949.

In 'Palanquin-Bearers' Sarojini Naidu describes a young bride being carried in a palanquin to her husband's house. The poet evokes a period from Indian history when palanquins were a common sight on the streets. A mode of transportation which was used primarily by men of means or women of the upper classes, palanquins have long gone out of use in most parts of the country today. However, in some parts of Himachal Pradesh the tradition of carrying a bride and in some cases even a bridegroom in a palanquin still exists.

Written in the tradition of a folk song, the poem uses vivid imagery to capture the carrying of a bride by palanquin bearers. The bearers turn the dreary task of carrying a person in the palanquin into a rich and joyful experience as they sing songs in harmony with their movement.

Though the poem does not have a thematic core, yet its charm is only too apparent. The poem employs a number of images which follow each other in quick succession and reinforce the rhythmic motion of the palanquin bearers. It uses as many as seven similes (a figure of speech in which one object is compared to another using words such as 'like' or 'as') to describe the manner in which the young woman is being borne. These similies range from the concrete, as in 'falls like a tear from the eyes of a bride', to the abstract, as in 'floats like a laugh from the lips of a dream'. The two images together hint at the twin emotions associated with the moment of departure of a young bride from her parental house to that of her husband's. If the first image is suggestive of her sorrow at leaving her parents, the second image speaks of her joy at the prospect of a new phase of life.

Lightly, O lightly, we bear her along,
She sways like a flower in the wind of our song;
She skims like a bird on the foam of a stream,
She floats like a laugh from the lips of a dream.
Gaily, O gaily we glide and we sing,
We bear her along like a pearl on a string.

Softly, O softly we bear her along,
She hangs like a star in the dew of our song;
She springs like a beam on the brow of the tide,
She falls like a tear from the eyes of a bride.
Lightly, O lightly we glide and we sing,
We bear her along like a pearl on a string.

NOTES

ˌpalan'quin	:	*palaki*, a covered seat carried on poles held parallel to the ground on the shoulders of two or four people
sway	:	move slowly from side to side
skim	:	move or glide lightly (over a surface)
beam	:	ray
brow	:	(here) edge or the top part

COMPREHENSION

1. Who do you think is being carried in the palanquin?
2. For what purpose were palanquins used in the past?
3. What else do the bearers do while they carry the palanquin?
4. What words does the poet use to describe the manner in which the bearers carry the person in the palanquin?

5. What emotion do the bearers display in doing their work?
6. Explain: 'She sways like a flower in the wind of our song'.

COMPOSITION

1. Summarize the poem in your own words.
2. What is a simile? What purpose do similes serve in the poem 'Palanquin Bearers'?
3. Describe the various images the poet evokes in relation to the woman sitting in the palanquin.

PRONUNCIATION: WORD STRESS IN POLYSYLLABIC WORDS

A word with three syllables is called a trisyllabic word. Given below is a list of trisyllabic words with the main stress on the first syllable:

1. 'ac.ci.dent
2. 'ad.ver.tise
3. 'aer.o.plane
4. 'a.gen.cy
5. 'an.y.thing
6. 'ar.gu.ment
7. 'ar.ti.cle
8. 'av.e.nue
9. 'beau.ti.ful
10. 'bi.cy.cle
11. 'cal.cu.late
12. 'cap.i.tal
13. 'cen.tu.ry
14. 'char.ac.ter
15. 'cir.cu.lar
16. 'cit.i.zen
17. 'civ.i.lize
18. 'com.pa.ny
19. 'con.fi.dence
20. 'cul.ti.vate
21. 'dan.ger.ous
22. 'del.i.cate
23. 'dif.fi.cult
24. 'dis.ci.pline
25. 'ed.u.cate
26. 'ex.cel.lent
27. 'fam.i.ly
28. 'glo.ri.ous
29. 'hes.i.tate
30. 'hol.i.day
31. 'in.dus.try
32. 'in.stru.ment
33. 'li.brar.y
34. 'med.i.cal
35. 'mem.o.ry
36. 'min.is.ter
37. 'mod.er.ate
38. 'nu.mer.ous
39. 'op.er.ate
40. 'or.na.ment
41. 'pas.sen.ger
42. 'per.ma.nent
43. 'pho.to.graph
44. 'pop.u.lar
45. 'pos.si.ble
46. 'prac.ti.cal
47. 'prej.u.dice
48. 'prob.a.ble
49. 'prop.er.ty
50. 'pun.ish.ment
51. 'qua.li.ty
52. 'quan.ti.ty
53. 'rec.og.nize
54. 'rel.a.tive
55. 'sac.ri.fice
56. 'sat.is.fy
57. 'set.tle.ment
58. 'sym.pa.thy
59. 'ter.ri.ble
60. 'yes.ter.day

Given below is a list of trisyllabic words, with the main *stress on the second syllable*:

1. ac.'cus.tom
2. ad.'van.tage
3. ad.'ven.ture
4. al.'read.y
5. am.'bi.tion
6. an.'oth.er
7. ar.'ri.val
8. ar.'tis.tic
9. a.'ston.ish
10. at.'ten.tion
11. be.'hav.iour
12. col.'lec.tion
13. com.'mer.cial
14. com.'mit.tee
15. com.'ple.tion
16. con.'di.tion
17. con.'fu.sion
18. con.'nec.tion
19. con.'sid.er
20. con.'tin.ue
21. de.'ci.sion
22. de.'li.ver
23. de.'part.ment
24. de.'ter.mine
25. de.'vel.op
26. di.'rection
27. dis.'cov.er
28. dis.'cus.sion
29. dis.'tin.guish
30. di.'vi.sion
31. en.'cour.age
32. es.'sen.tial
33. ex.'am.ine
34. ex.'am.ple
35. ex.'cep.tion
36. ex.'ist.ence
37. ex.'pen.sive
38. ex.'plo.sion
39. ex.'pres.sion
40. ex.'ten.sion
41. im.'por.tant
42. pro.'duc.tion
43. re.'la.tion
44. re.'mem.ber
45. sus.'pi.cion
46. to.'bac.co
47. to.'geth.er
48. to.'mor.row

Given below is a list of trisyllabic words, with the *main stress on the third syllable* and *secondary stress on the first syllable*

1. ˌaf.ter.'noon
2. ˌdis.ap.'pear
3. ˌen.gi.'neer
4. ˌen.ter.'tain
5. ˌin.tro.'duce
6. ˌrec.om.'mend
7. ˌrep.re.'sent
8. ˌre.pro.'duce
9. ˌun.der.'stand
10. ˌdis.ap.'point
11. ˌcig.a.'rette

Words with more than three syllables are called polysyllabic words. The presence of syllables affects the stress pattern. Study and call out each word separately.

1. fa.'mi.li.ar
2. im.'me.di.ate
3. ˌed.u.'ca.tion
4. re.'spon.si.ble
5. ˌcon.ver.'sa.tion
6. ˌex.am.i.'na.tion
7. ˌhes.i.'ta.tion
8. ˌman.u.'fac.ture
9. ˌop.por.'tu.nity
10. ˌpen.e.'tra.tion
11. re.'spon.si.ble
12. 'pen.e.trate

1. ˌed.u.'ca.tion.al
2. ˌed.i.'to.rial
3. ˌex.com.'mun.i.cate
4. ˌin.con.'ven.ient
5. ˌprof.es.'so.rial
6. pro.ˌnun.ci.'a.tion

Exercise 1

Work with your friend saying each of the words in the above list aloud. Mark stress by beating the table with your palm as you call out each word. Repeat each word twice. Test each other.

17

NIGHT OF THE SCORPION

NISSIM EZEKIEL

Nissim Ezekiel was born in 1924 in Bombay (Mumbai) in a Jewish family. He studied English at Wilson College, Bombay, and Philosophy at Birkbek College, London. He has taught at the University of Bombay, the University of Leeds, and also in several American and Australian universities. In post-Independence Indian English literature, Ezekiel has wielded enormous influence as a leading poet, a critic of literature and art and as editor of many journals such as *Quest* (which he founded and edited from 1955 to 1957), *Poetry India*, the poetry page of *The Illustrated Weekly of India* and *The Indian PEN*.

Ezekiel is a prolific writer. His *Collected Poems: 1952–1988* with an introduction by Gieve Patel, contains seven collections of verse including *Latter Day Psalms,* for which he received the Sahitya Akademi Award in 1983. His poems have been published in such reputed journals as *Encounter, London Magazine*, and *The Spectator.* He has also written plays and translated Marathi poetry into English.

Ezekiel's poetry is characterized by an urban strain, with Bombay, the 'barbaric city sick with slums', serving as a backdrop for a lot of his writing. While he is alive to its dirt and squalor it does not seem to diminish his love for the city.

Ezekiel strives to Indianize English through his use of vernacular words and syntactical peculiarities of Indian English in poems like 'Very Indian Poem in Indian English' and 'Goodbye Party for Miss Pushpa T.S.'.

Ezekiel has shown remarkable capacity to poeticise ordinary events and mundane subjects. He believes that a poem need not essentially deal with important events or deep philosophical truths; a poem dealing with ordinary things may equally touch our heart and illumine our mind.

In 1988 Ezekiel was honoured with Padma Shri Award for his distinguished contribution to Indian literature in English.

'Night of the Scorpion' is a narrative poem that depicts a section of Indian society still guided by superstitious beliefs and practices. The poem describes the response of a whole community to the suffering of a woman stung by a scorpion. The simple well-meaning peasants who come in large numbers pray to bring her speedy relief from the effects of poison. They believe that by paralysing the scorpion, the evil incarnate, through their prayers they might arrest the flow of the poison through the blood. Out of their ignorance they interpret the pain and suffering the woman undergoes as atonement for the

sins of her previous birth or as undeserved agony which would possibly mitigate the misfortunes of her next birth. Even the narrator's father, apparently a rational being, does not quite understand how to deal with the situation. In his own scientific way he pours some paraffin on the bitten toe and puts a match to it, burning the woman's flesh in the process. The mother reels under the effect of the poison for full twenty hours, showing the inefficacy of both the superstitious and the 'scientific' ways. Nobody realizes the simple truth that the effect of the poison wears off on its own, providing the long-awaited relief from pain.

The poem also highlights the self-effacing nature of a mother who gladly bears pain and suffering to save her loved ones from any possible harm.

I remember the night my mother
was stung by a scorpion. Ten hours
of steady rain had driven him
to crawl beneath a sack of rice.
Parting with his poison—flash
of diabolic tail in the dark room—
he risked the rain again.
The peasants came like swarms of flies
and buzzed the name of God a hundred times
to paralyse the Evil One.
With candles and with lanterns
throwing giant scorpion shadows
on the sun-baked walls
they searched for him: he was not found.
They clicked their tongues.
With every movement that the scorpion made
his poison moved in mother's blood, they said.
May he sit still, they said.
May the sins of your previous birth
be burned away tonight, they said.
May your suffering decrease
the misfortunes of your next birth, they said.
May the sum of evil
balanced in this unreal world
against the sum of good
become diminished by your pain, they said.
May the poison purify your flesh
of desire, and your spirit of ambition,
they said, and they sat around
on the floor with my mother in the centre,
the peace of understanding on each face.

More candles, more lanterns, more neighbours,
more insects, and the endless rain.
My mother twisted through and through
groaning on a mat.
My father, sceptic, rationalist,
trying every curse and blessing,
powder, mixture, herb and hybrid.
He even poured a little paraffin
upon the bitten toe and put a match to it.
I watched the flame feeding on my mother.
I watched the holy man perform his rites
to tame the poison with an incantation.
After twenty hours
it lost its sting.

My mother only said
Thank God the scorpion picked on me
and spared my children.

NOTES

dia'bolic	:	devilish
swarm	:	large number of insects, birds, etc. moving around together
clicked	:	made a slight sharp sound expressing sympathy
peace of understanding	:	the calmness of mind resulting from ready acceptance of something that cannot be prevented from happening
'sceptic	:	one who doubts everything
'rationalist	:	one who is guided by reason and logic in matters of beliefs and actions
ˌincan'tation	:	series of words used as a magic spell or charm

COMPREHENSION

1. Where did the scorpion hide itself?
2. What did the scorpion do after parting with its poison?
3. What did the peasants do when they came?
4. What was the effect of the poison on the mother?
5. What did the father do to lessen the effect of the poison on the mother?
6. Do you think the poison wore off because of
   (a) the prayers; (b) the medicine; (c) by itself.
7. How do the people relate the mother's suffering to the misfortunes of her next birth?
8. How long did the effect of the poison last?

COMPOSITION

1. Comment on the reaction of the mother. How has the speaker described it?
2. Compare the attitudes of the father, the mother, the narrator, and the peasants to the incident.
3. What idea do you get of the character and role of the peasants from their actions?
4. What picture do you form of the community described in the poem?

Part IV

GRAMMAR, COMPOSITION AND TRANSLATION

18

PUNCTUATION

In written English, punctuation marks are used to make the meaning clear. At one time, a great deal of punctuation was used. Today, we use the minimal that is required to convey the meaning.

1. (.) Full stop

(i) Is used to mark the end of a sentence:

It was a costly book.
He reported the matter to the Principal.

(ii) Sometimes it is used in abbreviations:

Dec., a.m., B.Sc., misc., etc. Full stops were used in abbreviations such as Mr, Dr, dept, edn, etc. in the past. But they are no longer used these days.

2. (?) Question mark

(i) Is used at the end of a direct question:

Where is the book?
Are you leaving?
(But not in indirect questions like: He asked me if I was leaving.)

(ii) In brackets to express doubt:

Two (?) men broke into the room.

3. (!) Exclamation mark

An exclamation mark is used at the end of a sentence expressing surprise, joy, anger, shock or some other strong emotion:

Alas! Oh! Well done!
(Today, we tend to use it sparingly.)

4. (,) Comma

(i) Is used to separate items in lists though it is usually omitted before *and*:

He was honest, brave, diligent and smart.
Bread, meat, fruit and milk are all items of food.

(ii) To separate phrases and clauses:

He had to lead a life of pain and poverty, dishonour and decay.
If you work hard, take your time, ponder and think ahead, you will achieve success.

(iii) Before and after a clause or phrase that gives additional information about the noun it follows:

Vimla, the daughter of my neighbour, is my classmate.

(iv) To separate a clause that interrupts the sentence:

The boy, although he had been ill for several days, was still cheerful.

(v) To separate certain words and phrases like *therefore*, *however*, *by way of*, *by the way*, *for instance*, *on the contrary* from the rest of the sentence:

By the way, did you hear the noise?
I did not, however, accept the invitation.
This, in fact, is the truth.

(vi) To separate a question tag or similar word or phrase from the rest of a sentence:

It is quite big, isn't it?
You live in Shimla, right?

(vii) In reported speech, after the reporting verb:

He said, "Father is not at home."
A comma is not used before a reporting verb if there is a question mark or exclamation mark immediately preceding it within the inverted commas (example, "What is your name?" he said.)

5. (:) Colon

(i) Is used to introduce a list of items:

The following boys were absent from school: Mir, Ravi, Ganesh and Joseph.

(ii) To give instructions:

Proceed as follows: write down your name and code number and then solve the question.

(iii) To introduce a quotation:

As Jawaharlal Nehru writes: "India is a great country . . ."

(iv) To amplify or explain a statement:

The house had been neglected for a long time: it was old and in a dilapidated condition.

6. (;) Semicolon

(i) To separate pairs or groups of words when the words forming each pair/group are separated by a comma:

Distinguish between the following pairs of words:
seem, seam; elect, select; fare, fair; quite, quiet.

(ii) A semicolon is often used instead of a full stop when sentences are grammatically independent but their meaning is closely connected.

7. (') Apostrophe

(i) Is used with an 's' to indicate the possessive:

Bimla's book	men's jackets
girls' school	at a stone's throw

(ii) In contracted forms to indicate that letters or figures have been omitted:

I'm (= I am)	he's (= he is)
Hon'ble (= honourable)	'99 (= 1999)

8. (—) Dash

(i) Is used instead of a colon or semicolon to indicate that what follows is a summary or conclusion of what has gone before:

Men were quarrelling, women were shouting, children were crying—it was chaos.

(ii) To separate extra information, a comment or an afterthought from the rest of the sentence:

Winters in Delhi—contrary to what many people think—are very cold.

(iii) Between two numbers or dates to include everything that comes between these numbers or dates:

pages 117–22
A study of the British Economy, 1947–63

9. (-) Hyphen

(i) Shorter in length than the dash, is used in compound words:

radio-telescope	mother-in-law
thirty-two	pre-European
passer-by	Vajpayee-Musharraf summit

(ii) To separate a prefix ending in a vowel from a word beginning with the same vowel:

co-ordinate
re-elect
pre-eminent

(iii) To break up a word that is divided between one line and the next:

. . . it was a mis-
take

10. (. . .) Dots

Three dots (also called an ellipsis) are used to indicate that words have been omitted, especially from a quotation or at the end of a conversation:

Others, however, have challenged this view . . .

Note: Where the context requires a full stop, it is placed as a fourth dot in addition to the three dots.

11. (/) Slash or oblique

(i) Is used to separate alternative words or terms:
Male/female, tea/coffee, take a raincoat and/or an umbrella

(ii) To indicate the end of each line of poetry where several lines run on in a quotation:
'I wandered lonely as a cloud/That floats on high over vales and hills . . .'

12. ( ) Brackets

(i) Also called parentheses, are used to separate extra information or an afterthought or a comment which is not of primary importance from the rest of the sentence:

His father visited the Taj three years ago (I don't remember the exact date).

(ii) To enclose cross-references:

This moral tone is a main feature in Pope's poetry (see Chapter Eight).

(iii) To enclose numbers and/or letters in the text:

This information was (a) true, and (b) disturbing.
The match was (1) dull, (2) slow and (3) uninteresting.

13. (' ', " ") Quotation marks

(i) Or inverted commas are used to enclose all words and punctuation in direct speech:

The cook said, "Dinner is ready."

(ii) To draw attention to a term that is unusual in the context:

During the emergency thousands were imprisoned in the name of 'internal security'.

(iii) To enclose titles of articles, short poems, essays, stories, radio and television programmes, etc.

Premchand's "Kafan"
O. Henry's "The Gift of the Magi"

(iv) To enclose short quotations or sayings:

The saying 'Old habits die hard' is quite famous.

14. Italics

(i) Are used to indicate stress or emphasis:

I am *not* going away empty-handed.

(ii) For titles of books, magazines, newspapers, plays, operas, films, paintings:

Kamath's *The Other Face of India, The Tribune, The Times*

(iii) To indicate foreign words or phrases that have not become naturalized into English:

Tempus fugit (i.e. time flies)

While writing we use underline in place of italics.

15. Capital Letters

(i) Are used to begin the first word of every sentence.
(ii) The first word of each line of poetry.
(iii) For the pronoun 'I' and the interjection 'O'.
(iv) For proper nouns and adjectives formed from them:

Ramesh Janak India European

(v) For names of the days of the week and the months:

Monday January December

(vi) The first word of the reported speech within inverted commas:

The Count said, "He would have told me if he knew."

(vii) Personified objects, nouns and pronouns referring to God, religions, subjects and languages:

O Death! God Buddhism Physics English

(viii) Newspapers and magazines:

The Times of India *India Today*

(ix) Festivals:

Diwali Christmas

(x) Important words in the titles of persons, forms of address in letters, headings of books, stories, essays, etc.:

Lord My dear Sister Dear Sir *Stories for the Young*

(xi) Letters denoting abbreviations:

M.A. I.P.S. B.A. L.L.B.

Exercise
Punctuate the following, inserting capital letters wherever necessary:

1. lions tigers leopards and panthers are cats
2. I have no money therefore I cannot keep a carriage
3. speech is silver silence is golden
4. alas i am undone said the poor beggar
5. I said to him remember the old saying all that glitters is not gold
6. you must hurry he said or you will be late for school
7. a young man was walking alone on a dry and dusty road the sun beat fiercely on his head his mouth was so parched with heat and dust and his feet were so weary that he could not walk
8. one evening when the sun was setting a wolf watched his own shadow growing longer and longer what a great animal i am said the wolf to himself how foolish i am to be afraid of the lion whom they call the king of beasts
9. no smoking in this compartment said the ticket inspector to the traveller I am not smoking was the travellers reply but you have got your pipe in your mouth answered the inspector yes was the sharp reply i have got my feet in my boots but i am not walking
10. the postmaster was beginning to lose his temper have you no sense he cried
11. once upon a time two goats met in the middle of a narrow bridge the bridge was just wide enough to let one goat pass at a time let me pass said one goat in an angry voice let me pass said the other in angrier tone get back said one you go back said the other
12. there was once a poor man who could no longer keep his only son the son said dear father things are so bad that I feel i am a burden on you i would rather go away and seek some employment
13. great men like alexander the great guru gobind singh byron keats and shelley did not live long but they won everlasting fame through their wonderful achievements
14. robert bruce king of scotland was fighting hard to free his country from the english he was badly defeated and had to flee for his life

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SPELLING

Words Commonly Misspelt

SECTION I
Based on the Text

The Gift of the Magi
possession, generosity, coffee, immediate, worshipped

A Duel
opponent, wrestler, traveller, passenger, messenger, siege, foreigner, carriage, moustache, fierce, tobacco, seize

Nitya
manoeuvre, crucial, negotiation, assurance, luxury, route, conductor, committee, rupee, receipt, running, beginning, initial, shoulder, wrapped, catalogue, corridor, scissors, appearance, neighbour

The Fatalist
secretary, bachelor, participant, cholera, typhoid, apparently, cigarette

The Child
weather, leisure, precious, complaint, believe, marriage, resignation, definite, definition, dying (die + ing), dyeing (dye + ing), athlete, medal, interrupt, separate

Work in the Sun and in the Light
mysterious, suggestion, heroine, endeavour, oppressed

My Financial Career
accountant, relieve, cheque, echo, ceiling

Principles of Good Writing
principle, principal, interference, essential, discipline, magazine, genuinely, successful, relevance, approach, authority, argue, argument, support, consciousness, musician, mutually, inhabitant, acroplane, melancholy, yours (no apostrophe), absence

The Elixir of Life
draught, drought, liquid, vegetation, significance, quench, maintenance, characteristic, beneficial, occur, occurred, occurrence, excessively, apparent, terrace, moisture, technique, courageous, availability, unique

Streamlining
swimming, resistance, sufficient, design, vehicle

On His Blindness
patience, murmur, ocean

The Echoing Green
merry (= happy), weary, descend

The World Is Too Much With Us
bosom, creed, glimpse

A Bird Came Down the Walk
half, halves, convenient, cautious

Night of the Scorpion
scorpion, peasant, lantern, ambition, groaning, sceptic, bitten, rites

SECTION II
Some More Words Commonly Misspelt

A
abandon
abbreviation
absentee
abundance
academic
accommodation
accurate (ly)
ache
achieve (ment)
acknowledge (ment)
acquaint (ance)
adjacent
advice (n)
advise (v)
address
affectionate (ly)
agree (ment)
aggregate
aggression
alcohol (ic)
allot (ted)
allow (ance)
almighty/Almighty
almost
all right
all-round
already
altogether
always
ambitious
ambulance
analyse
analysis (singular)
analyses (plural)
anger – angry
anniversary
anxiety
anxious
apparent

appear (ance)
appetite
appropriate
aptitude
architect (ure)
artificial
ascend (v)
ascent (n)
assent (= agreement)
assignment
assist (ance)
association
asthma
astronaut
atheist
athlete
attend (ance)
attitude
auction
audible
audience
autobiography
automobile
autumn (al)
average
awe, awful
awkward
B
baggage
balloon
ballot
barometer
battalion
bayonet
bazaar
behaviour
belief
benefit
benefited/benefitted
bicycle
biography
biscuit
boundary
bouquet / bʊ'keɪ /
boycott
breath (n)
breathe (v)
brevity
buffalo
bungalow
bureaucrat
burial
business
bye-bye
C
cabinet
calendar
campaign
cancel (led)
career (profession, etc.)
carrier (carry + -er)
category
cease (=stop)
ceiling
cement
certificate
changeable
character
chauffeur / 'ʃəʊ.fə(r) /
chorus
civilization, civilisation
cleanliness
client
climax
colleague
colonel
column
commentary
committee
competition
competitor
compulsory
condemn (ation)
condolence
confidence
congratulation (s)
conscience
conscious (ness)
constituency
controversy
convey (ance)
correspond (ence)

courier
courtesy
cruel (ty)
curiosity
cylinder

D

dairy (of milk)
diary (= notebook)
deceive
declamation
deficiency
delicious
democracy
description
designation
desperate
devotee
diabetes
diagnose
diesel
disaster
disciple
disobedience
disturbance
divorce
drizzle
drunkard
dysentery

E

eclipse
economical
eczema / 'ek.sɪ.mə /
employee
enmity
entrance
envelope (n)
envelop (v)
epidemic
equator
etiquette
European
excellent
exemplary
exhibition
existence
explanation
extraordinary
extravagance
extremist

F

facility
famine
fatigue
favourite
flavour
foreign
forfeit
forty
fourth
funeral

G

gaiety
gallery
gazette
genius
goodbye
governor
grammar
grandeur
grateful
gratitude
greenery
grievance
guarantee
guidance
gymnastics

H

handicapped
handicraft
handkerchief
harmonious
hasten
height
hereditary, heredity
hindrance
hoarse
homeopathy, homoeopathy (Br E)
honorary
humorous
hygiene
hymn
hypocrisy, hypocrite

I

ideology
ignorance
illegible
illiterate
illusion
imaginary
inadequate
inaugurate
incessant
inconvenience
increment
indebted
indiscipline
infectious
inferior (ity)
inimical
insurance
intrigue
intuition
irrelevant
island

J

jealous (y)
jewellery
judg(e)ment
jubilee

K

kerosene
kidney
knife
knowledge (able)

L

laboratory
legislature
lenient
leopard
licence
lieutenant
luggage
luxurious

M

magnificent
manifesto
manual
manufacture
manuscript
matinee / 'mæt.ɪ.neɪ /
matrimonial
memorandum
message
messenger
millionaire
miscellaneous
mischief, mischievous
mockery
momentary
monetary
municipality
muscle
museum
myth (ology)

N

naughty
necessary
negligence
nephew
neutral (ity)
niece
nineteen
ninetieth
ninth
notorious
novelty
nuisance
nutritious

O

oath
obedience
obscene
obvious
olympic
omen
omission
omnipotent
omniscient
orchestra
orphan
orthodox (y)
oxygen

P

parallel

paralysis
partiality
pavilion
pedestal
pedestrian
penicillin
performance
personality
persuade
physician
pleasant
pneumonia
poisonous
postmortem
prescription
psychology, psychological
pursue, pursuit

Q

quarrel (led)
queue
quorum
quiet
quite
quote

R

realm
rebellion
recommend (ation)
recruit (ment)
recurrent
referee
refrigerator
refugee
rehearsal
reign (= to rule)
reliable
relief
religion
repetition
rescue
restaurant
rhyme
rhythm
routine

S

salient
sandwich
scenery
schedule
scheme
scientist
scripture
secretariat
sentry
servant
shriek
signature
sincerely
skeleton
skilful
spontaneous
superior (ity)
supervisor
superstitious
superintendent
supplementary
surety
surgeon
suspicion
symptom
syringe
syrup
symmetry

T

talkative
taught
temporary
tension
testimonial
theatre
thermometer
thoroughfare
tournament
tranquil (lity)
transfer (red)
transistor
trespass
triumph
trivial
truly
tuition
twelve, twelfth

tyranny, tyrant

U

ultimatum
umbrella
umpire
unanimous
unconscious

V

vaccination
vacuum
vague
variety
vegetarian
vein
ventilator
veto
villain
violence
virtuous
vocabulary
voluntary

W

wander
wonder
weather (atmospheric conditions)
whether (conjunction)
weight
whistle
woollen
wrestling

X

xerox

Y

yield
yoke
yolk

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SINGLE WORD FOR A GROUP OF WORDS

SECTION I
Based on the Text

A child who stays away from school without permission	truant
A person who loves his/her country	patriot
Line at which the earth and sky appear to meet	horizon
Treating a religious or sacred subject disrespectfully	blasphemy (n) blasphemous (adj)
A person who is addicted to alcohol	alcoholic
One who abstains from alcohol	teetotaller
Occurring yearly	annual
Yearning for a past period	nostalgia
A complete list of items (usually in book form), especially of things one can buy or look at	catalogue
Person walking in the street and not travelling in a vehicle	pedestrian
A holy book/the sacred writings of a religion	scripture
One who believes in fate	fatalist
An informal (often humorous) name given to a person	nickname
A place where government records or historical documents are stored	archives
The person one is engaged to	fiancé (masculine) fiancée (fem.)
A harmful habit from which one is unable to free oneself	addiction
A person who suffers or dies for his/her beliefs	martyr
A person who has over a million pounds, dollars, rupees, etc.	millionaire
A person aged between thirteen and nineteen	teenager
Very informal words and expressions that are more common in spoken language	slang

Impossible or very difficult to believe	incredible
Natural ability to do something well	talent

SECTION II
Some Other Words

A place or building where animals are killed for their meat and by-products	abattoir/ slaughterhouse
A list of items to be discussed at a meeting or a formal list of things to do in a particular order	agenda
One who takes part in a sport or other activity for pleasure (not as a job)	amateur
Loss of memory	amnesia
Absence of government or control in society	anarchy
The scientific study of the structure of human or animal bodies	anatomy
Objects having life	animate
A letter or a piece of writing not bearing the name of the writer	anonymous
Substance that can destroy bacteria or limit their growth	antibiotic
A word opposite in meaning to another word	antonym
A collection of poems, stories, letters, etc. written by different people and published together in a book	anthology
One who plans and designs buildings	architect
One who undertakes a scientific study of ancient cultures through a study of their material remains	archaeologist
A class of people who hold high social rank	aristocracy
One who undertakes a scientific study of celestial bodies	astronomer
One who foretells things by studying the stars	astrologer
One who does not believe in God	atheist
One who conducts a public sale (an auction)	auctioneer
What can be heard clearly	audible
An assembly of listeners and watchers	audience
The life-story of a person written by himself	autobiography
Government by a single person with absolute power	autocracy
A place where birds are kept	aviary
A place where bread, cakes and biscuits are made	bakery
A large building or groups of buildings for the lodging and accommodation of soldiers	barracks
Occurring twice a year	biannual
Happening once every two years	biennial
Account of a person's life written by someone else	biography
A bunch of flowers	bouquet
Hard but easily broken	brittle

Government run by officials	bureaucracy
A person or animal that eats its own species	cannibal
The dead body of an animal	carcass
An animal or plant feeding on flesh	carnivorous
A picture of a person or thing drawn in such an exaggerated manner as to cause laughter	caricature
A place where dead bodies are buried, especially one that is not attached to a church	cemetery
An official count of a country's population	census
Persons living at the same time	contemporaries
A residence for nuns	convent
A person who reports news from a particular country or on a particular subject for a newspaper or T.V. channel or radio station	correspondent
A place where babies and small children are looked after while their parents are at work	créche / kreʃ /
A person paid to deliver letters and parcels	courier
Ceremonial burning of a dead body	cremation
A group of people working together on a ship or an aircraft	crew
A system of government in which all adult citizens of a country can vote to elect their representatives	democracy
The management of relations between countries, especially by their ambassadors and official representatives	diplomacy
Alphabetically ordered book of names and addresses and telephone numbers	directory
A place where medicines are given, e.g. in a hospital	dispensary
A place where strong alcoholic drinks are produced	distillery
Legal termination of a marriage	divorce
A large room in which many people sleep, especially in a boarding school	dormitory
Absence of rain for a long time	drought
A person who prepares or sells medicines/drugs	druggist/ pharmacist
Fit to be eaten by human beings	edible
Death caused from electric shock	electrocution
A poem of lamentation, especially for the dead	elegy
The art of speaking clearly and effectively, especially in public	elocution
To take money secretly and dishonestly that one was entrusted with	embezzle
A book or a set of books containing information on all areas of knowledge	encyclopedia
A disease affecting a large number of people at the same time and place	epidemic

The study of the origin and history of words and their meanings	etymology
A person living in a country that is not his own	expatriate
Send goods to another country for sale	export
A speech made without previous preparation	extempore
Spending or using in a wasteful manner	extravagant
Causing or ending in death	fatal
Animal life of a period or a region considered as a whole	fauna
The flowers and vegetation of a certain region	flora
A person who owns or works in a shop/store that sells flowers and plants	florist
Easily broken or damaged	fragile
A building where a car is kept or where cars are bought, sold and repaired	garage
A place for storing grain	granary
An area of land where dead people are buried	graveyard
A place (a room or hall) with equipment for doing physical exercise	gymnasium
A post for which no salary is paid	honorary
One who is friendly and welcoming to guests and visitors	hospitable
That which is difficult or impossible to read	illegible
An activity or action forbidden by law or is against the law	illegal
Not allowed by law or strongly disapproved by people in general	illicit
Unable to read or write	illiterate
To bring from abroad or from an outside source	import
One who pretends to be what one is not	impostor
That which is not likely to happen or be true	improbable
That which cannot be approached or reached	inaccessible
Objects without life	inanimate
Sound not loud enough to be heard	inaudible
A person with bad habits or faults which cannot be changed or corrected	incorrigible
A disease which cannot be cured	incurable
That which cannot be done away with	indispensable
Not having the necessary qualifications to have or do something	ineligible
That which cannot be explained or understood	inexplicable
A person who cannot commit a mistake	infallible
That which cannot be imitated	inimitable
That can catch fire easily	inflammable
A problem too difficult to be solved A substance impossible to dissolve	insoluble

Animals without backbone	invertebrates
Too strong to be defeated or overcome	invincible
That which cannot be seen	invisible
A list of goods sold with the price (s) charged, sent as a bill to the buyer	invoice
A person who watches over students taking an examination	invigilator
A school for very young children	kindergarten
A person who compiles dictionaries	lexicographer
The original copy of a book or article before it is printed	manuscript
An instrument for making very small objects appear large	microscope
A place where coins are produced, usually under State authority	mint
A person who hates and avoids other people	misanthrope
A disorderly crowd of people, especially one that could easily turn violent	mob
A residence for monks or priests	monastery
A place where dead bodies are temporarily placed	mortuary/ morgue
A place where treasures of art, or objects of historical or scientific importance and value are kept, studied and put on display	museum
Having a bad reputation	notorious
A building that has been specially equipped for observing and studying the stars and planets	observatory
Words or things no longer in use	obsolete
A doctor who attends to the diseases of the eyes	oculist
One who is all-powerful	omnipotent
One who is present everywhere	omnipresent
One who knows everything	omniscient
One who tests eyesight, recommends and sells glasses	optician
One who looks at the bright side of things	optimist
Something that is supposed to cure all illnesses or solve all problems	panacea
An animal or a plant that feeds on another animal or plant	parasite
One who makes a display of his learning	pedant
One who looks at the dark side of things	pessimist
Happening after a person's death	posthumous
A medical examination of a dead body to find out the cause of death	postmortem/ autopsy
A person who specializes in the study of human mind and the reasons for human behaviour	psychologist

A pile of wood on which a dead body is placed and burned in a funeral ceremony	pyre
To send or bring someone back to his own country	repatriate
A natural or artificial lake where water is stored before it is supplied to houses	reservoir
One who is reserved in speech	reticent
Coming back to life again	resurrection
Art of using language impressively or persuasively	rhetoric
An act of causing damage to, or treating with disrespect something holy or important	sacrilege
A speech in which a character, who is alone on the stage, speaks his or her thoughts aloud	soliloquy
A person who looks on, especially at a show or game	spectator
A person who speaks on behalf of a group or an organization	spokesperson
Information collected and presented in numerical form	statistics
The study and knowledge of the practical uses of applied sciences	technology
An instrument for seeing distant objects	telescope
Capable of being seen through	transparent
Agreed to by everyone in a group	unanimous
That which cannot be understood	unintelligible
One who does not eat meat or fish	vegetarian
Animals with backbones	vertebrates
A person who has a lot of experience in a particular activity gained over a long period of time	veteran
One who offers his services free of charge	volunteer
Food which is good for health	wholesome
The part of the sky that is directly overhead, or the highest point	zenith

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ANTONYMS AND SYNONYMS

ANTONYMS

An *antonym* is a word that means the opposite of another word.

SECTION I
Based on the Text

The Gift of the Magi

prosperity	adversity
income	expenditure
modest	immodest
unassuming	arrogant, haughty, conceited
agile	lethargic, lazy
depreciate	appreciate
disapproval	approval
discreet	indiscreet

A Duel

occupy	vacate
inhumanity	humanity
patriot	traitor
self-preservation	self-destruction
foe	friend
futile	useful
futility	utility
detachment	attachment
comic	tragic
occasionally	frequently

Nitya

legal	illegal
predecessor	successor
survive	perish
triumph/victory	defeat
confidence	diffidence
visible	invisible

demon	god
regular	irregular
adulterated/mixed	pure

The Child

friendly	unfriendly, hostile
illiterate	literate
ignoble	noble
disclose	hide, conceal
sympathetic	hostile, unsympathetic
stupid	wise
deny	admit, confess
unperturbed	perturbed
contentment	discontent, discontentment
dissuade	persuade
bearable	unbearable
sincerity	insincerity
morality	immorality

Work in the Sun and in the Light

conceit	humility
fascinated	repelled
oppressor	(the) oppressed
freedom	bondage, slavery
doubt	certainty, faith
brave	cowardly
leader	follower

My Financial Career

irresponsible	responsible
timid	bold
reveal	conceal
deposit	withdraw
valid	invalid

Principles of Good Writing

ability	inability
frequent	infrequent, occasional
careful(ly)	careless(ly)
genuine	fake, spurious
success	failure
likely	unlikely
interested	uninterested, disinterested
relevant	irrelevant
concrete	abstract
definite	indefinite

savage	civilized
remote	near
melancholy	merry, cheerful
formal	informal

The Elixir of Life

immortal	mortal
fertile	infertile, barren
regularity	irregularity
potent	impotent
origin	end, termination
dense	sparse
credible	incredible
adequate	inadequate
rural	urban

Streamlining

modern	ancient
resist	yield
sufficient	insufficient
increase	decrease
rapid	slow
sharp	blunt
smooth	rough

SECTION II
Some Other Antonyms

NOUNS

absence	presence	beginning	end
addition	deduction, subtraction	belief	doubt, disbelief
		benevolence	malevolence
advantage	disadvantage	blessing	curse
acceptance	rejection	bottom	top
affluence	poverty	bravery	cowardice
alien	native	care	neglect
analysis	synthesis	cause	effect
angel	devil	cheerfulness	dejection
arrival	departure	civility	rudeness
attack	defence	civilization	barbarism
attraction	repulsion	coherence	incoherence
ascent	descent	comedy	tragedy
assent	dissent	compliance	non-compliance, defiance
barrenness	fertility		
beauty	ugliness	confession	denial

concord	discord	increase	decrease
creation	destruction	interest	indifference
creator	destroyer	joy	sorrow
credit	discredit, debit (cash)	justice	injustice
		likeness	difference
danger	safety	love	hate
darkness	light	major	minor
death	birth	majority	minority
deficit	surplus	master	servant
delay	hurry	merit	demerit
discount	premium	miser	spendthrift
disease	health	motion	rest
dwarf	giant	optimist	pessimist
ebb	flow	patience	impatience
economy	extravagance	peace	war
equality	inequality	plenty	scarcity
enemy/foe	friend	pride	humility
entrance	exit	profit	loss
expansion	contraction	punishment	reward
exterior	interior	rashness	caution
fact	fiction	rear	front
facility	difficulty	retreat	advance
failure	success	repute	disrepute
falsehood	truth	safety	danger
fame	infamy	sea	land
familiar	unfamiliar	security	insecurity
forgiveness	revenge	similarity	dissimilarity
gain	loss	smile	frown
glory	shame	solid	liquid
gratitude	ingratitude	summit	base
guest	host	superiority	inferiority
happiness	unhappiness, misery	synonym	antonym
		use	disuse, abuse
head	tail	vanity	humility
heaven	hell	violence	non-violence
hope	despair	virtue	vice
honour	dishonour, shame	wisdom	folly
ignorance	knowledge	zenith	nadir
inclusion	exclusion		

ADJECTIVES

absent	present	artificial	natural
active	inactive, passive	attractive	repulsive
affirmative	negative	attentive	inattentive
agreeable	disagreeable	audible	inaudible
animate	inanimate	barbarous	civilized

base	noble	false	true
beautiful	ugly	fickle	constant
beneficial	injurious, harmful	final	initial
bitter	sweet	flexible	rigid
blunt	sharp	frank	reserved
bright	dull	foreign	native
broad	narrow	fresh	stale
cautious	rash, reckless	fruitful	fruitless
certain	uncertain	foolish	wise
cheap	dear, expensive	fortunate	unfortunate
cheerful	cheerless, gloomy	general	particular
clean	dirty	glad	sad
clever	stupid	great	small
common	uncommon, rare	guilty	innocent
complex	simple	hard	soft, easy
confident	diffident	harsh	mild
convenient	inconvenient	heavy	light
convex	concave	high	low
coarse	fine	hollow	solid
correct	incorrect	honest	dishonest
cruel	kind	hopeful	hopeless
dead	alive	hospitable	inhospitable
decent	indecent	humble	proud, haughty
deep	shallow	important	unimportant,
deficient	proficient		trivial
difficult	easy, simple	inferior	superior
different	similar	intelligible	unintelligible
defensive	offensive	interesting	uninteresting
dependent	independent	junior	senior
destructive	constructive	keen	dull
diligent	idle, lazy	lawful	unlawful
domestic/tame	wild	lenient	strict
dry	wet	living	dead
doubtful	sure	logical	illogical
dynamic	static	loud	low
edible	inedible	loose	tight
eligible	ineligible	long	short
empty	full	liberal	narrow-minded
equal	unequal	male	female
evil	good	material	immaterial,
explicit	implicit		spiritual
external	internal	manly	unmanly
extraordinary	ordinary	maximum	minimum
fair	unfair, foul	mental	physical
famous	notorious	modest	immodest
faithful	faithless	moist	dry

movable	immovable	religious	irreligious
moral	immoral	romantic	prosaic
negative	positive, affirmative	ruthless	humane
		round	flat
numerous	few	sacred	profane
objective	subjective	sensitive	insensitive
odd	even	steadfast	fickle
old	young, new	stern	mild
oral	written	straight	curved
partial	impartial	strong	weak
permanent	temporary	sweet	sour
pleasant	unpleasant	thick	thin
polite	impolite, rude	timid	fearless
probable	improbable	transparent	opaque
proper	improper	uniform	varied, variable
practicable	impracticable	useful	useless
prudent	imprudent	vague	definite
pure	impure	vertical	horizontal
public	private	vigorous	feeble
quiet	noisy	virtuous	wicked, vicious
rational	irrational	violent	non-violent, gentle
raw	ripe	voluntary	involuntary
real	unreal	vulgar	refined
resolute	irresolute	well	ill
restless	calm	wide	narrow

VERBS

accept	reject, refuse	begin	end
affirm	deny	bless	curse
acquit	convict	borrow	lend
advance	retreat	buy	sell
agree	disagree, differ	choose	reject
allow	disallow, forbid	compare	contrast
appear	disappear, vanish	complicate	simplify
approach	retreat, retire	condemn	praise, approve
arm	disarm	confess	deny
arrive	depart	continue	discontinue
ascend	descend	converge	diverge
assemble	disperse	create	destroy
associate	dissociate	decrease	increase
attach	detach	encourage	discourage
attack	defend, protect	enjoy	suffer
attract	repel	enrich	impoverish
beautify	disfigure	enter	exit
believe	disbelieve	exclude	include

expedite	delay	persist	desist
gather	scatter	persuade	dissuade
grant	reject	please	displease
help	hinder	praise	blame
honour	dishonour	precede	succeed
import	export	prohibit	permit
inhale	exhale	punish	reward
interest	bore	remember	forget
illumine/ illuminate	darken	retreat	advance
		shorten	lengthen
laugh	weep, cry	sink	swim
lead	follow	sleep	wake
lock	unlock	strengthen	weaken
magnify	reduce	teach	learn
make	mar	tie	untie
obey	disobey	unite	disunite
obscure	clarify	win	lose
oppose	support		

SYNONYMS

A *synonym* is a word that has the same or similar meaning as that of another word: *cheerful*, *happy*, *merry* and *jolly* are synonyms that are quite close to each other in meaning.

SECTION I
Based on the Text

The Gift of the Magi

coax	cajole, persuade
agile	active, nimble
accurate	exact, precise
chaste	pure, virtuous
generosity	liberality, magnanimity
tremendous	huge, gigantic, enormous
discreet	prudent, tactful
crave	yearn, long (for), pine (for)
adornment	embellishment, decoration

A Duel

invasion	attack, aggression
inhumanity	brutality, barbarity, atrocity
occasionally	infrequently, seldom, rarely
curiosity	eagerness, inquisitiveness
rogue	rascal, ruffian, villain, knave
adversary	opponent, enemy

Nitya

heir	successor
admonish (v)	scold, reprove, rebuke, reprimand
obscene	indecent, vulgar, lewd, profane
reckless	rash
precarious	insecure, perilous, risky, hazardous
ancestors	forefathers
consecrated (adj)	sanctified, sacred, pious
whore	prostitute, strumpet, harlot
covetous	greedy, avaricious

The Fatalist

preordained	predestined, predetermined
inevitable	unavoidable
pretext	excuse, pretence
vow	promise, pledge
stain	slur, stigma
brag (v)	boast
gruesome	horrible, grisly

The Child

perspiration	sweat
short-tempered	irritable, peevish
flattery	sycophancy
riddle	puzzle, enigma
placid	calm, tranquil, serene
perturbed	disturbed, agitated
unperturbed	unagitated, calm, composed, serene
zeal	zest, enthusiasm, gusto
complicated	complex, intricate
envious	jealous
paradise	heaven
frailty	weakness, foible
intentional	deliberate, wilful

Work in the Sun and in the Light

obstacle	hurdle, impediment, hindrance
lofty	high, dignified
conceited	proud, haughty, arrogant
reverie	day-dream
fascinating	captivating, attractive, alluring, enchanting
heroic	brave
endeavour	(earnest) attempt, effort
freedom	liberty, independence
unruffled	calm, serene, undisturbed

My Financial Career

threshold	doorsill, entrance, beginning (point)
evident	obvious, clear
detective	spy
ghastly	horrible, frightful

Principles of Good Writing

genuine	real, authentic
crank	eccentric (person)
remote	distant, isolated
melancholy	sad, gloomy, dismal, mirthless, pensive
vague	inexact, imprecise, hazy, uncertain

The Elixir of Life

vital	important, significant
origin	genesis, source, starting-point
incredible	unbelievable
beneficial	advantageous
surplus	excessive, superfluous, extra, spare
menace (n)	threat (s), danger
immense	huge, vast, enormous, considerable
investigation	inquiry, exploration, examination

Streamlining

slim	slender, thin, lean
valuable	precious, invaluable, costly, expensive
increase	enhance, augment
(to) overcome	control, master, prevail (over)
alteration	change

SECTION II
Some Other Examples

NOUNS

adversary	antagonist, opponent
adversity	misfortune, distress, affliction
aid	assistance, help, succour
amusement	entertainment, recreation, diversion
beauty	charm, comeliness
belief	faith, credence
caprice	whim, freak
command	order
consent	assent, approval, agreement
contempt	disdain, scorn, derision, spite

courage	bravery, valour, boldness, gallantry, pluck
courtesy	politeness, civility, amiability, affability
danger	peril, risk, hazard
dejection	depression, gloom, despair, melancholy despondency
deliverance	liberation, emancipation
difference	dissimilarity, variation
disagreement	discord, dissension
discontent	dissatisfaction
disgust	repugnance, loathing, aversion, abhorrence
dogmatism	bigotry, fanaticism
duty	obligation, onus, responsibility
economy	frugality, thriftiness, thrift, parsimony
enemy	foe
enmity	hostility, antagonism, animosity
error	mistake
fragrance	scent, perfume, aroma
gratitude	gratefulness, thankfulness
humility	modesty, meekness
increase (n)	addition, augmentation, increment, growth, enlargement
ingratitude	thanklessness, ungratefulness
insanity	madness, lunacy, derangement
judgment	decision, verdict
marriage	matrimony, wedding
ostentation	display, show, pomp, splendour, glitter
pain	agony, anguish
pity	compassion, sympathy, mercy, clemency
pleasure	gladness, delight, enjoyment
prediction	forecast
pride	arrogance, vanity, haughtiness, vainglory
prisoner	captive
rejoicing	exultation, jubilation, merry-making
request	plea, entreaty
resentment	displeasure
respect	regard, reverence, veneration
restriction	restraint, constraint, limitation
retaliation	reprisal
revenge	vengeance
utility	usefulness
weakness	infirmity, frailty, failing

ADJECTIVES

amusing	entertaining, recreative, playful
attractive	charming, captivating, fascinating, appealing

beautiful	pretty, lovely, dainty, handsome
benevolent	kind, considerate, well-wishing
brittle	breakable, fragile
capricious	whimsical, eccentric, wayward
concise	brief, succinct, terse, compact, laconic
contemptuous	scornful, disdainful, derisive
courageous	brave, valiant, gallant, daring
courteous	polite, civil, polished, refined
cowardly	timid, timorous, craven, chicken-hearted
credulous	gullible, trustful, unsuspicious
cunning	crafty, artful, subtle
defiant	rebellious, insolent, disobedient
different	diverse, heterogeneous, varied, divergent
excitable	irritable, irascible, peevish
easy	simple, facile
false	untrue, deceitful, dishonest
fatigued	weary, tired, exhausted
foolish	stupid, idiotic, dull-witted, silly
friendly	amiable, cordial
frightening	fearful, terrifying, scary
grateful	thankful, obliged, beholden
great	large, considerable, big
guilty	culpable, blameworthy, reprehensible
humble	modest, meek
inattentive	unmindful, heedless, unobservant, careless
loquacious	talkative, garrulous
loving	affectionate, tender, fond
malevolent	ill-disposed, malicious, malignant, spiteful
obstinate	stubborn, obdurate, inflexible
peaceful	calm, tranquil, placid, serene
permanent	imperishable, durable, lasting, enduring
powerful	mighty, potent, energetic
remedial	corrective, curative
radiant	glorious, splendid, brilliant, bright
renowned	famous, distinguished, celebrated
resolved	determined, resolute, firm
sad	gloomy
wise	sagacious, prudent, judicious

VERBS

agree	consent, suit, match, harmonize
amuse	entertain, divert, cheer, rejoice
assault	attack, assail, invade
avoid	shun, shirk, evade, dodge
conceal	hide, veil, camouflage

decrease	diminish, lessen, dwindle, decline
discourage	dishearten
elevate	raise, heighten, lift, exalt
exaggerate	magnify, overpraise, overstate
exonerate	excuse, acquit
imitate	copy, reproduce, mimic
pursue	follow, undertake, engage in
refuse	decline, turn down
repudiate	reject, deny, disclaim
relieve	mitigate, alleviate, soothe, assuage, allay
request	solicit, entreat, implore, beseech, pray
restrain	check, hinder, constrain

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COMPREHENSION

Comprehension is an important aspect of second language learning and teaching. It forms an essential part of most competitive examinations. The word 'comprehend' means 'to understand'. The ability to understand a given text satisfies our curiosity and gives us joy. Poor comprehension feeds the mind with wrong information and often leads us to erroneous conclusions.

Comprehension is an important step in the complex process of language learning. The more difficult operations of a language such as writing and speaking cannot be handled effectively unless one attains a fair degree of competence in the comparatively simpler functions of the language like reading and listening. Comprehension involves a proper understanding of the core concept as it emerges through an interaction of various ideas contained in the passage.

A comprehension exercise is set with the following objectives in view:

(a) To test a student's ability to comprehend and interpret the given passage.
(b) To test his capability to understand the implicit and explicit ideas of the writer.
(c) To judge his capability to find out the writer's own attitude to the subject.
(d) To test the range of his vocabulary and his ability to express himself with precision and economy.

Guidelines for Effective Comprehension:

Constant practice plays an important role in answering comprehension questions. A systematic approach, however, proves helpful in attempting exercises on comprehension:

(a) Give a rapid reading to the passage. This will enable you to grasp the main idea in the passage. Write it down separately.
(b) Read the passage a second time, this time a bit slowly and steadily. Concentrate on the key words and phrases and the pattern of thought development.
(c) Read all the questions from the first to the last. Unless you understand the questions properly, you will not be able to answer them correctly.

(d) Keeping the questions in mind, read the passage once again.
(e) Answer the questions in the order they have been arranged.
(f) Revise your answers and correct all grammatical and/or spelling mistakes, if any.

Important Points to Remember:

While attempting comprehension questions the following points must be kept in mind:

(a) Your answers should be brief and to the point.
(b) They should be written in a simple language.
(c) Use your own language, as far as possible. Reproducing complete sentences from the passage should be strictly avoided.
(d) Your answers should be based on the passage itself. In no case should the student give his personal opinion or observations in answering the questions.
(e) Pronouns like 'I', 'You', and 'We' should be generally avoided.
(f) Indirect form of narration should be preferred to the direct form of narration.

Example

Our body is a wondrous mechanism and when subjected to unusual stress over a period of time it adapts itself to deal more effectively with that stress. So when you exert your muscles against resistance, they are forced to adapt and deal with this extraordinary workload. This is the principle of weight training. Strands of muscle fibre become thicker and stronger in response to the demands placed on them.

One of the great merits of weight training is the strength of your heart. During weight training, your heart is forced to beat faster and stronger in order to pump sufficient blood to the muscles being worked. In time, your heart, like your body will adapt to this extra workload by becoming stronger and more efficient. Since your body needs a given amount of blood to perform its daily tasks your heart will now need fewer beats to pump the same quantity of blood. Sounds good? There's more. Your entire circulatory system is given a thorough workout every time you exercise, which increases its overall efficiency. Even the neural paths from your brain's command centre to each individual muscle become more effective, enabling easier recruitment of muscle fibres for carrying out physical tasks. In essence, your body becomes a well-oiled and finely-tuned piece of machinery, whirring along without breakdown. In today's stress-filled world, you need all the help you can get.

Questions

1. What happens to our body when it is subjected to stress over a period of time?

2. What affects the nature of muscle fibres?
3. How does the heart become stronger owing to physical exercise?
4. What makes our body a well-oiled and finely-tuned piece of machinery?
5. What does the above passage suggest?

Answers

1. Our body learns to cope with stress when it undergoes it for an extended period of time.
2. Muscle fibres undergo a change in response to the demands placed on them. Exposed to regular stress, muscle fibres become thicker and stronger.
3. During physical exercise the heart is required to work harder. It tends to adapt itself to this extra workload and, in the process, becomes stronger.
4. Regular physical exercise improves the working of the various organs of our body. Over a period of time, it turns our body into a healthy piece of machinery.
5. The above passage emphasizes the importance of physical exercise on a regular basis for the overall improvement of the human body.

Example

My neighbour's children love playing hide-and-seek as all children do, but no one expected that a game they played last week would be reported in the local newspaper.

One afternoon, they were playing in the street just outside the post office. Young Raju, who is only five years old, found the perfect place to hide. His sister, Radha, had shut her eyes and was counting up to ten when Raju noticed that the small metal door of the letter-box had been left open. The postman had just taken all the letters out and had gone into the post office to see if there were any parcels. Raju climbed into the letter-box and pulled the door from inside so hard that it locked. Upon realizing what he had done, he became very frightened and started crying. Meanwhile, Radha was looking for him everywhere but could not find him. It was lucky she happened to stop outside the letter-box and hear her brother's cries. She immediately ran to tell the postman who hurried out to unlock the metal door. Raju was now free, but he had such a fright that he could not stop crying. The postman, however, soon found a way of making him laugh again. He told him that next time he wanted to hide in a letter-box, he should remember to stick a stamp on himself!

Questions

1. What were the children playing outside the post office?

2. How old was Raju?
3. Where did Raju hide?
4. How did Raju get inside the letter box?
5. Where was the postman?
6. What happened to Raju?
7. When did Radha realize where Raju was hiding?
8. What did Radha do?

Answers

1. The children were playing hide-and-seek outside the post office.
2. Raju was five years old.
3. Raju hid himself in the letter-box.
4. The letter-box had been left open by the postman. Raju climbed into the letter box through the open door.
5. The postman was inside the post office.
6. Raju locked himself inside the letter-box, he became frightened and started crying.
7. Radha stopped outside the letter-box and heard Raju crying.
8. She ran to tell the postman.

Exercise 1

French physicist Antoine Becquerel wondered if fluorescent substance also produced X-rays. He found by chance that uranium salts emitted radiation that consisted of a stream of electrons, quite unlike X-rays.

Marie Curie was born in a poor Polish family. She left for Paris in 1891 with a burning desire to study science. She married Pierre, a chemist. They knew of Becquerel's discovery and set to refine pitchblende, a mineral ore which emitted a high amount of radiation. In 1898, they isolated a new element, polonium. Then they spent all their savings and a gruelling four years working to extract radium. The Curies refused to patent their discovery.

Later, Marie became the first woman to teach at the Sorbonne. In 1911, she won an unprecedented second Nobel prize for Chemistry. Marie died of leukaemia because of prolonged exposure to radioactivity. Even today, her notebooks are too contaminated to handle.

Questions

1. Name Marie Curie's husband. What was his profession?
2. What did the Curies find in 1898?
3. What did the couple ultimately want to extract?
4. What was novel in Marie's teaching assignment at the Sorbonne?
5. How did she die?
6. What was unprecedented about her achievement?

Exercise 2

Winston Churchill was one of the world's greatest statesmen and historians. No one could have predicted that the boy who stuttered and was at the bottom of his class at school, would inspire a nation to rise to victory in war. Churchill joined the army and in South Africa, during the Boer War, he was captured. He made a daring escape and became a hero overnight. In 1901, he was elected to the Parliament. In 1917, Churchill was made minister of munitions and supervised the development and production of the battle tank. He lost the 1922 elections but returned to Parliament in 1924 and was appointed Chancellor of the Exchequer, an office his father had held 40 years earlier. Between the World Wars, he wrote the 4-volume *World Crisis* and the 6-volume *Marlborough, His Life and Times* and took up painting.

When World War II broke out, Chamberlaine's government fell and Churchill became Prime Minister at the age of 66. He became the familiar face of Britain with his trademark cigar and 'V' for victory sign. He proved himself to be an outstanding leader, orator and military strategist. In 1945, Churchill's government lost the election but in 1951, he was back as Prime Minister. Churchill retired in 1955. He wrote the 4-volume *History of the English Speaking Peoples* before his death in 1965 at the ripe old age of 90.

Questions

1. What did Churchill write just before his death in 1965?
2. What made Churchill a hero overnight?
3. In one or two sentences write about the various qualities of Churchill.
4. Was he a bright student at school?
5. What made him a familiar face in Britain?

Exercise 3

Nobody likes staying at home on a public holiday—especially if the weather is fine. Last August we decided to spend the day in the country. The only difficulty was that millions of other people had exactly the same idea. We moved out of the city slowly behind a long line of cars, but at last we came to a quiet country road and, after some time, stopped at a lonely farm. We had brought plenty of food with us and we got it out of the car. Now everything was ready, so we sat down near a path at the foot of a hill. It was very peaceful in the cool grass—until we heard bells ringing at the top of the hill. What we saw made us pick up our things and run back to the car as quickly as possible. There were about two hundred sheep coming towards us down the path!

Questions

1. Where did the writer and his family decide to drive to last August?

2. Were there a lot of cars on the road, or were there only a few?
3. What did they get out of the car?
4. Where did they sit?
5. What did they hear soon afterwards? Where did they have to run?
6. Why did they have to run?

Exercise 4

Now that smoking is considered to be very dangerous to health, it is especially difficult for children to buy cigarettes or tobacco. Our tobacconist, Mr James, has always been very careful about this. If his customers are very young, he always asks them for whom the cigarettes are being purchased.

One day, a little girl whom he had never seen before walked boldly into his shop and demanded twenty cigarettes. She had the exact amount of money in her hand and seemed very sure of herself. Mr James was so suprised by her confident manner that he forgot to ask his usual question. Instead, he asked her what kind of cigarettes she wanted. The girl replied promptly and handed him the money. While he was giving her the cigarettes, Mr James said laughingly that as she was so young she should hide the packet in her pocket in case a policeman saw it. However, the little girl did not seem to find this very funny. Without even smiling she took the packet and walked towards the door. Suddenly she stopped, turned round, and looked steadily at Mr James. There was a moment's deathly silence and the tobacconist wondered what she was going to say. All at once, in a clear, solemn voice, the girl declared, 'My dad is a policeman,' and with that she walked quickly out of the shop.

Questions

1. Did the tobacconist ever sell cigarettes to children? What did he first ask them?
2. What did he forget to do when the young girl demanded a packet of cigarettes?
3. Where did he advise her to hide the packet? Why?
4. What did she tell him just as she was leaving the shop?
5. What was unique about the girl?

Exercise 5

As it came near the corner, the taxi stopped suddenly. The driver got out looking very puzzled. A big lorry which had been following the taxi stopped too. The taxi driver was now standing at the corner looking up at the sky and the lorry driver went and joined him. A number of cars behind were forced to stop as well and soon a large crowd of people had gathered at the corner.

The cause of all this trouble was a very strange noise. It sounded as if

thousands and thousands of birds were singing together. The noise was quite frightening and many people looked disturbed. The most extraordinary thing was that, apart from one or two pigeons, there was not a bird in sight. No one was able to solve the mystery, until two policemen arrived. They noticed a large advertisement for a film high up on a wall nearby. As the noise seemed to be coming from this direction, they climbed up and found that a tape-recorder had been hidden behind the advertisement. The noise made by birds singing was being broadcast over powerful loudspeakers so as to attract the attention of passers-by. The police asked the advertisers to take the recorder away because the advertisement had attracted so much attention that it was impossible for a great many cars and buses to move freely in the street.

Questions

1. Where did a large crowd gather after the traffic stopped?
2. Why did everyone look puzzled?
3. What did the two policemen see high up on a wall?
4. What was the cause of the noise?
5. What did the police ask the advertisers to do?

Exercise 6

I lose so many things that I could swear they just get up and walk away. Perhaps I have never admitted it—even to myself, but I am extremely jealous of people who are so orderly that they never lose anything. Most of my friends always seem to have a place for everything and everything is in its place. I hate comparing myself with them. They have special cupboards for tools, hooks to hang things on and drawers to put things in. It is quite impossible for me to compete with them.

Some things have a terrible habit of making themselves scarce the moment I need them. Pencils and ball-point pens are never anywhere near the telephone when it rings, no matter how much care I take. Screw-drivers and tin-openers always manage to wander out into the garden and, as a result, screws remain loose and the tins remain unopened. Boxes of matches slide under the radio, and needles disappear every time I want to sew a button on a shirt.

The situation was getting so much out of control that I decided to organize myself. I had a large cupboard put into the kitchen. On the shelves I neatly arranged a number of boxes and tins, the contents of which I clearly printed in ink on the outside. I had one box for pins, another for nails, and a special place for screw-drivers. There was a new address book in one corner so that I could make a note of telephone numbers and addresses. Before this I had always written addresses on bits of paper—which I promptly lost. Soon, everything was tidily arranged in its place, from pairs of scissors to cakes of soap and spare lamps. Having made such a sincere attempt to prevent things from running away, I felt

very proud of myself. But it was not long before the matches disappeared and the hammer decided to hide itself in the waste-paper basket. I soon got my revenge, however. I had a lock fitted to the cupboard and thus made sure that nothing could escape. This was an admirable solution—until I lost the key to the cupboard!

Questions

1. Why does the writer hate comparing himself with others?
2. When does the writer need pencils and ball-point pens?
3. Why does he need needles?
4. Why do screws remain loose and tins unopened?
5. How does he try to organize himself?
6. What is the writer's main problem?
7. Is he able to manage his problem?
8. What happens in the end?

LETTER WRITING AND INVITATIONS

Recently, with the increasing use of the computer, the format of letter has changed considerably. The standard dictionaries like *Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary* (6th ed. 2000) and *Cambridge Learner's Dictionary* (2001) give examples of this changed format. In this format punctuation marks are not used in the beginning or the end of the letter and the 'inside address', 'complimentary close' and first lines of different paragraphs, all begin with the left hand margin. However, the conventional format also continues to be used widely in India, and you may use either the new format or the old format. Examples of the two formats are given on the next page.

A letter is a personalized form of composition. It is an index of one's personality. When we read a good letter, we hear the writer talking to us. Simplicity of expression, clarity of thought, brevity, relevance, politeness and, above all, adherence to the accepted norms are required in a good letter.

Broadly speaking, letters are of two types:

(i) *Formal Letters:* These include official letters, business letters, letters of request/application/complaint, letters to newspapers, etc.

(ii) *Informal Letters:* These include letters to friends, relatives and acquaintances.

Layout and Parts of a Letter

Letters may be of various types but they have a certain layout accepted by convention. A letter comprises the following six parts:

(i) The Heading (it also includes the date)
(ii) The Inside Address (it is omitted in personal letters)
(iii) The Salutation
(iv) The Body
(v) The Complimentary Close, and
(vi) The Signature

(i) THE HEADING

The writer should give his/her full address in the top right-hand corner. The number or name of the house, name of the street/colony, name of the village/town/city along with PIN code should be mentioned here.

CONVENTIONAL FORMAT

Deepak Lodge,
21, Pawan Vihar,
Shimla 171005.

February 7, 2003.

To

The Executive Officer,
Municipal Corporation,
Shimla-171001.

Subject: Insanitary conditions of Pawan Vihar area.

Sir,

I want to bring to your kind notice the insanitary conditions of Pawan Vihar where I live. For almost a month no sweeper has swept the roads and streets. The dust-bins have not been emptied since long and the garbage is lying littered here and there. There is so much stink on the main road that every passer-by has to stop his breath for a while. The drains remain choked with dirt and the overflowing water has made many pot-holes in the road. Unless some remedial measures are taken, there is every danger of the outbreak of an epidemic.

I, on behalf of the residents of the area, request you to take effective steps for the proper sanitation of Pawan Vihar immediately.

Thanks in advance for your kind help.

Yours faithfully,

Sd/
(Rajan Azad)

HEADING

INSIDE ADDRESS

SALUTATION

BODY

COMPLIMENTARY CLOSE

SIGNATURE

CONTEMPORARY BRITISH FORMAT
(as in Oxford Advanced Learner's Dictionary, 6th ed., p.B14)

26 Windmill Road
Bristol BS2 6DP

24 May 2000

Ms Emma Campbell
Personnel Manager
Multimedia Design
4 Kennington Road
London SE1 8DD

Dear Ms Campbell

I am writing to apply for the position of assistant designer advertised in the Evening Post of 23 May. Please find enclosed a copy of my CV.

I have a degree in Graphic Design from Anglia Polytechnic University. Since graduation last summer I have been working for EMS Corporate Imaging on a contract basis. I have become particularly interested in interactive and multimedia work and now wish to develop my career in that direction. I would welcome the chance to work as part of a small, dynamic team where I could make a significant contribution while developing my skills yet further. I would be happy to show you a portfolio of my work.

I look forward to hearing from you.

Yours sincerely

Sd/
Peter Green

Note: (a) The writer may or may not write his/her name above his/her address.
(b) The writer may or may not use punctuation marks at the end of each line.

The Date should be written right under the address. It can be written in any one of the following accepted ways:

(a) January 10, 2003 (comma has to be used to separate the date from the year)
(b) 10th January 2003 (comma optional after the name of the month)
(c) 10 January 2003 (No comma after the name of the month)

The name of the month should be written in full.

(ii) THE INSIDE ADDRESS

Here, in a formal letter, you should write the name and/or the designation of the person you are writing to. If you write both, you need to remove 'The' written with the designation. Write the name of the office or institution you are writing to and its complete address, e.g.

Mr Dinesh Goswami
Managing Director
H.P. Tourism Department
The Mall
Shimla 171 001

(or)

The Managing Director
H.P. Tourism Department
The Mall
Shimla 171 001

'To' may or may not be written before the Inside Address of the addressee. If 'To' is used, the Inside Address would be slightly away from the left margin; otherwise it would be placed with the left margin (If 'To' is used, punctuation marks are also often used with the Inside Address).

(iii) THE SALUTATION (or GREETING)

The Salutation (or Greeting) has to be placed two spaces below the recipient's address, that is, after leaving one line blank. It is to be written with the left margin. In most official or commercial correspondence, the normal ways of addressing a person are:

(a) to address the head of some department, office, firm, etc. in connection with some request, complaint, etc. you may write:

Dear Sir
Dear Madam
Dear Sirs
Dear Sir/Madam
Dear Sirs/Mesdames
Dear Ms

However, in very formal requests, e.g. to the Principal of your college, omit 'Dear' and write only 'Sir' or 'Madam'.

(b) in a formal letter to an acquaintance, a neighbour or a colleague, or to address someone not personally known to you, use their title and *surname*

Dear Dr Sharma
Dear Mr Verma
Dear Mr Bharti

Titles other than Mr, Mrs, Miss, Dr are spelt in full:

Dear Professor Sharma
Dear Captain Raj

You can use 'Ms' for both married and unmarried women.

In the salutation, the full name is not written; only the surname or the last name is written with the title, e.g.

Dear Dr Smith

The salutation or greeting in an informal letter depends upon one's intimacy or relationship with the addressee. The most commonly used forms are:

Dear Dinesh
My dear Samuel
Dear Ms Singh
Dear Sister

While addressing older relatives, mention relation after 'Dear' or 'My dear', e.g. 'My dear Father', 'Dear Uncle'; in case of younger relatives or friends, 'Dear' or 'My dear' should be followed by the first name of that person.

(iv) THE BODY OF THE LETTER

The body of the letter may be written in paragraphs and the first line of each paragraph may start either with the left hand margin or after leaving some space.

Some ways of starting a formal letter are:

I am writing to inform you of/that . . . .
I am writing to complain about/enquire about . . . .
I am writing regarding your advertisement . . . .
Please send me . . . .
Further to my letter of June 1, ...

Some ways of starting an informal letter are:

Thanks for your letter.
How are you?
I hope you're well.
Sorry, it's been long since I last wrote.
It was a pleasure to hear from you.

Some ways of ending a formal letter are:

I look forward to hearing from you soon.

Thank you in advance for your help.
Wishing you all the best for the future.

Some ways of ending an informal letter are:

We're looking forward to seeing you.
Drop me a line soon.
Write soon.
Take care.
Keep in touch.
Give my love to Rouhi.
I hope to hear from you soon.

In a personal letter, it is customary to send good wishes to the family of the recipient of the letter. It may be written before the complimentary close like this:

All good wishes to you and your family.
Pay my regards to your parents.
My greetings and good wishes to all of you.
Please convey my regards to your family.

Note: According to the latest trend, one should avoid ending a letter with a present-participle construction like:
"Hoping to receive an early reply."
Instead, one should write:
I hope to receive an early reply.

(v) THE COMPLIMENTARY CLOSE

It is written two spaces below the main body of the letter either on the right or, as per the latest trend, on the left. It has to be in accordance with the salutation.

(a) if you have addressed the person as 'Dear Sir' or 'Dear Madam' (or as 'Sir' or 'Madam'), write: Yours faithfully,
(b) if you have addressed the recipient by name, write: Yours sincerely,
(c) if you know the name of the person you are writing to, but the letter is formal, even then write: Yours sincerely,
(d) British style in letters where there is no personal relationship between the writer and the addressee: Yours truly

The complimentary close in the case of informal letters is as under:

Family members and close friends:
Love,
Love from,
All my love,
Lots of love,

Less close friends/acquaintances:
Best wishes,
All the best,
Take care,
Yours,
Kind regards,

(vi) THE SIGNATURE

The name should be clearly written below the complimentary close after leaving sufficient gap for signature. In the examination, the students can write 'X' or the fictitious name they have been asked to use in the question.

Don't write 'Mr' or any other title like 'Professor' with your name below the signature. However, in case the name does not indicate whether the writer is man or woman (married or unmarried), the title 'Ms', 'Miss' or 'Mrs' is put within brackets:

(Miss) Rita Bhardwaj

The degrees to a person's credit may be written after the name below the signature:

Surinder Kumar, Ph.D.

Reference No.: In all official correspondence, a reference number is usually given so that one may refer back to this particular letter as and when the need arises. The reference number is written on the left in the line next to the 'Heading'.

Subject: In a formal letter, the subject of the letter is written below the 'Inside Address'.

Enclosures: In a formal letter, the papers/documents attached with the letter are mentioned at the end of the letter on the left, e.g. Enclosed: CV and Experience Certificate.

The Postscript: Sometimes, despite every care, some important point is left out in the body of the letter. Such a point can be written at the end of the letter after writing 'P.S.' at the beginning of the line.

Informal Letters

Informal letters are in the form of extended long distance private conversation. For instance, in a letter to a friend or relative, one may like to describe a place, a person, an incident or may wish to converse on a matter of mutual interest as if one is actually talking to the person addressed. In these private letters one may use an informal and conversational style.

In real life, one may use even slang or non-standard expressions in informal letters. But a letter written for examination purpose should not contain ungrammatical expressions current in casual speech, because here the purpose is to test the candidate's ability to write correctly.

Although informal letters should be written without formality, they should not be formless. The format of an informal letter is much less rigid than that of the formal letter which is based on certain conventions and customs. However, it would be useful to adhere to the following format:

27, Ram Gali
Upper Gaura
Hamirpur 177 005
10th March 2002

My dear Puran

I have just learnt from your brother that you have been ill and in the hospital for the last ten days. I feel very sorry. But I am glad to know from your brother that now you are recovering fast and would be discharged from the hospital in a day or two.

You must have had a difficult time in hospital. But now the bad time is over. Try to feel cheerful and happy. Take care of yourself when you go home. Take the medicines regularly as advised by the doctors and take proper rest.

I shall come to see you next week. You can let me know if I can bring anything from here for you.

I pray to God for your fast recovery and good health.

Sincerely

Jai Dayal

Exercises

1. Write a letter to your friend congratulating her on her admission to a medical college.
2. Write a letter to your friend expressing your condolences on his father's death.
3. Write a letter to your younger sister sympathizing with her on her failure in the Matriculation examination.
4. Write a letter to your father who is away from home, telling him about the family affairs.
5. Write a letter to your teacher seeking his advice in some personal matter.
6. Write a letter to your father requesting him to increase your monthly allowance.

Formal Letters

A formal letter has to conform to the format adopted for such communication. It must be precise, unambiguous and as brief as possible. The tone of the letter should always be courteous and considerate. It should also clearly state why you are writing, highlight the main points and explain what exactly you want the addressee to do for you. Hence words and phrases should be selected very carefully.

Remember that only in letters to friends and acquaintances can you use short forms like *I'll*, *We'd*, etc. One should write plain English instead of hackneyed jargon.

Instead of	*Write*
Received yours of 12th instant	Received your letter of 12th May
Re your favour of 15th ultimo	Please refer to your letter of 15th April
24th proximo	24th of next month

As already stated, formal letters include official letters, business letters, letters of request/application/complaint, letters to the Editor of a newspaper, etc. Some specimens are given below along with hints and exercises for practice:

Letters of Request

Letters of request ask for some favour, facility or service. Specimen:

12, Taravati Building,
Upper Kaithu,
Shimla 171 003.
26th January, 2003.

To
The Principal,
Government Degree College,
Shimla 171 004.

Sub.: Request for testimonial.

Sir,

I am an old student of your college. As I am applying for a position in the Postal Department, I urgently need a testimonial from you.

I remained on the college rolls from July 1996 to April 1999 and passed B.A. under Roll No. 37655 (college Roll No. 1377) in the first division, obtaining 63% marks. I was a member of the College Dramatic Club and took an active part in inter-college Debates and also won many prizes. My lecturers had a high opinion of my work and behaviour.

I request you to send me a testimonial at the earliest. I shall feel grateful to you for this.

Yours faithfully,

Sd/-
Onkar Chand

Exercises

1. Write a letter to the Principal of your college requesting him to remit your fine.
2. Write a letter to the Principal of your college requesting him to exempt you from the payment of college fees as your father cannot afford it.
3. Write a letter to the Principal informing her of your misbehaviour and offering a satisfactory apology.
4. Write a letter to the Principal of your college requesting him to improve the condition of the college toilets.
5. Write a letter to the Transport Authority of your town requesting that a bus stop be approved for your locality as a large number of residents would find it useful.
6. Write a letter to the Registrar of the university for change of dates of the annual examination as some of the dates clash with those of the competitive examination to be held by some other examining body.
7. Write a letter to the Gram Panchayat Pradhan of your village to make arrangements for cleaning the village well and repairing its compound.
8. Write a letter to the Manager of a paper factory asking for permission for your friends to visit the factory.

Letters of complaint

There are things or situations in our daily life which cause us some inconvenience and need to be changed. It becomes necessary to write to the appropriate person, organization or department, pointing out the cause of complaint and suggesting measures for redress. If the complaint is of a general nature and one wants many people to read it, it can be sent to a newspaper for publication as an open letter. Here are a few suggestions that can be useful in composing a letter of complaint.

1. Take care that the facts of the complaint are accurate. A complaint without reason will annoy the addressee.
2. Avoid sounding rude or nasty in the letter. Be polite but firm.
3. If you have a complaint to make, do not delay. Delay weakens one's case.
4. There is no need to apologize for complaining.
5. Be direct and come straight to the point.

Here is a specimen of a letter of complaint:

A-35, First Floor
Police Lines
Chamba
15th December 2002

Bakshish & Company
Quality Garment Store
New Market
Chamba

Dear Sirs

I bought a T-shirt from your shop last week. The cash memo number is 2348 of 8th December 2002. I find that after the very first wash, the colour has faded and it is not in shape.

I am sure this particular T-shirt is not a representative of your products, and that you will immediately replace it.

Yours sincerely

L.R. Sharma

Exercises

1. Write a letter of complaint to a shopkeeper that a Philips two-in-one purchased by you last week is giving frequent trouble. You want to get it replaced.
2. Write a letter to the Health Officer of your town complaining about the insanitary condition of the street in which you live.
3. Write a letter to the Bank Manager pointing out that the latest entries in your savings account passbook show that a certain amount has been shown as withdrawn without your knowledge and consent. Write to the Manager for rectification of the mistake.
4. Write a letter to the Postmaster of your locality complaining about the irregular delivery of letters.
5. Write a letter to the Superintendent of Police complaining about the rude behaviour of a constable.
6. Write a letter to the Head of the Water Supply Department of your place complaining about the irregular water supply to your locality and asking him to regularize the supply and increase the hours of water supply.

Letters for jobs

These days most letters of application for jobs are required to be submitted in specific forms prescribed for the purpose. However, sometimes one may be asked to apply for a job on plain paper. A letter of application for a job is almost of the same nature as a business letter.

Here is a specimen of a letter of application for a job:

4, Krishna Nagar
Circular Road
Shimla 171 001
25th June 2002

The Principal
DAV Senior Secondary School
New Shimla 171 009

Dear Madam

I am hereby applying for the post of Librarian advertised in *The Tribune* of 20th June 2002. I am enclosing a copy of my CV.

I have a first class degree in Science from Himachal Pradesh University and have been pursuing the three year course in Library Science at Indira Gandhi National Open University which I hope to complete by July 2002. I would welcome the chance to work in your school where I could make a significant contribution in helping young students.

Though I have no work experience, yet given a chance I shall try my best to come up to your expectations.

I look forward to hearing from you.

Yours faithfully

Baljit Kaur

Note: You may furnish the details in your CV (*Curriculum Vitae* or *Bio-data* or *Resumé*) in the following manner:

Curriculum Vitae

Name
Address
(Telephone no., if any)
Nationality
Marital status
Date of birth
Educational Qualifications

2001	B.Sc. from H.P. University in the first division with 68% marks
1998	10+2 from H.P. Board of School Education in the first division with 76% marks
1996	Matriculation . . .
	. . .

(You can also furnish this information in tabular form):

Name of the Examination	University/ Board	Year of passing the examination	Subjects studied	Marks obtained/ %age of marks	Division

Experience (if any)

Skills Diploma in Computer Science

Interests Reading, painting and playing cricket

Exercises

1. Write an application for the post of a teacher in a school.
2. Write an application to the Managing Director of the State Tourism Department for the post of a Guide in his office.
3. Write a letter to the Registrar of the University applying for the post of a clerk in the Examination Branch of the University.
4. Write to the Editor of the *Times of India*, Chandigarh, offering your services as a correspondent.
5. Write to a business firm applying for a post advertised in a newspaper.
6. Write to a shopkeeper applying for the post of a salesman advertised in a local newspaper.

Letters to the Editor

Letters intended for publication in a newspaper are always addressed to the Editor of the newspaper. These may deal with some matter of general interest, social issues or one's reaction to a news item or a view expressed in the newspaper.

Here is a specimen letter to the Editor of a newspaper:

12, Kuldip Bhawan
Dharamsala Road
Kangra
March 25, 2002

The Editor
The Times of India
Chandigarh

Sir

Through the columns of your esteemed newspaper I want to draw the attention of the authorities concerned to the problem of people smoking in educational institutions.

Although the Supreme Court of India has banned smoking in public places and educational institutions, one can still find employees smoking in offices. I myself saw this when I visited a government office yesterday. This is also true of schools and colleges where even students can be seen smoking in canteens. Smoking is not only injurious to the health of those who smoke but also causes harm to those who are not smokers themselves but are made to inhale air which has been polluted by smokers. Passive smoking, as this phenomenon is called, is a major health hazard. The authorities should take strict action to root out this problem, otherwise the orders of the highest Court of the country shall be reduced to a farce.

Yours truly

Raj Kumar
A Student

Exercises

1. Write a letter to the Editor of a newspaper complaining about a school in your village whose building needs immediate repairs.
2. Write a letter to the Editor of a newspaper complaining about the delay in the declaration of results by the University, particularly in cases of applications for re-evaluation of answer books.
3. Write a letter to the Editor of *The Tribune* making an appeal for funds for the construction of your college auditorium.
4. Write a letter to the Editor expressing your views on the evil of noise pollution, particularly from the loudspeakers used by religious organisations.

Notes of Invitation or Letters Inviting People

We often invite our friends, relatives, neighbours, colleagues or others on a number of occasions such as parties, ceremonies, functions, etc. Letters of invitation are either formal or informal. Informal notes of invitation are like ordinary friendly letters, though very very brief. Here are specimens of informal letters extending invitation:

(i) to a friend living at a far-off place

Amar Palace
Lower Jakhu Road
Shimla 171 001
21.6.2003

Dear Raj

It shall be a great pleasure if you visit us for a week during your college vacation. We can plan to go for sightseeing and can visit the Indian Institute of Advanced Study, Wild Flower Hall and Chail Palace. My parents and younger brother look forward to your visit and I am sure it will be as enjoyable for you as it will be for us.

With love

Jatinder

(ii) to a neighbour inviting him to a tea party

57, Rose Cottage
Mandi
2nd February 2003

Dear Mr Puri

Could you please give me the pleasure of your company at a tea party at my residence at 5 p.m. on 13th February, 2003? I shall look forward to your joining us.

Yours sincerely

R S Narula

In case of a *formal invitation* to a large number of people in the event of ceremonies, functions or parties, generally invitations are extended in the form of invitation cards. While writing such invitations, the following points may by kept in mind:

(a) they are written in the third person.
(b) they do not contain any heading, salutation or complimentary close.
(c) the writer's name appears in the body of the invitation.
(d) the address of the writer and the date of writing are written to the left or right below the body of the letter.

Here is a specimen of *formal invitation*:

Mrs and Mr Dina Nath request the pleasure of your company at the marriage reception of their daughter at Hotel Krishna on Monday, 11th February 2003 at 8 p.m.

15 Model Town
Bilaspur
9 February 2003

The reply to such an invitation is also written in the third person and repeats the date and time mentioned in the invitation. Here is a *formal Note of Acceptance*:

Mr Amar Chand accepts with pleasure the kind invitation of Mrs and Mr Dina Nath to the marriage reception of their daughter at Hotel Krishna on Monday, 11th February 2003 at 8 p.m.

21 Kewal Building, Bilaspur
10 February 2003

Here is a *formal Note of Refusal*:

Mrs and Mr Chand thank Mrs and Mr Dina Nath for their kind invitation to the marriage reception of their daughter on Monday, 11th February 2003 at 8 p.m., but regret that owing to a previous engagement they will not be able to come.

21 Kewal Building, Bilaspur
10 February 2003

Exercises

1. Write a formal invitation to a friend asking him to join you at a dinner.
2. Draft a formal reply accepting the above invitation.
3. Draft a formal reply declining the above invitation.

4. Write an informal invitation to your friend requesting him to attend the marriage ceremony of your sister.
5. Write a letter to your friend inviting him to a picnic arranged by you.
6. Write an invitation to the Students' Central Association of another college requesting participation by the students of that college in a dance contest.
7. Send an invitation to the Principal of your college to be the chief guest at the Students' Association Function of your college. Use your imagination for other details.
8. Write an invitation to a village Pradhan requesting him to preside over the special ten-day-camp function of your NSS unit.

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REPORT WRITING

A. What is a Report?

A report is an objective statement of an event (e.g. an accident, a function, a match, or any other happening or condition) that has taken place or exists. It contains accurate information. Depending on its purpose, relevant facts and figures are to be concisely and clearly conveyed. Every report aims at helping people to form opinions, draw conclusions and take decisions. Obviously, authenticity of facts becomes an obligation on the reporter. Conjectures and subjective observations are completely avoided in it. Facts, figures and ideas are presented logically in precise, standard and least involved language. The reporter is only a narrator of facts and therefore is not supposed to express his emotions or make value judgements of the facts.

We propose to discuss in the following pages formal reports and newspaper reports only because these reports are of immediate relevance to our readers.

B. Formal Report

These reports are called formal reports because the information is provided according to a formalized structure. It is prepared under the following headings: (i) Title (ii) Introduction (iii) Procedure (iv) Findings and (v) Conclusions.

The following points must be carefully noted while writing a formal report:

1. Write only on two sides of your answer sheet or as directed.
2. Use an 'attention line' to show how you address the report.
3. Give a full and explanatory title to the report on the centre of the page.
4. Give a very brief introduction. State why the report is being submitted, what it is about, and what its scope is to be.
5. State very briefly the manner in which the information has been collected.
6. present your findings in a logical manner. If need, group them under sub-headings.

7. Based on your investigation, observations and findings, make general comments which are relevant to the aim of the report.
8. Use only the impersonal style of writing, using, as far as possible, passive structures.
9. Do not offer your own suggestions or comments except when extremely necessary.
10. Sign the report, give your designation and put the date.

Two specimen reports are given below to demonstrate how a formal report is to be written.

Demonstration Exercise 1

You are the secretary of the college debating society. The Rotary Club has organized an open debate on the government's reservation policy. Your principal has asked you to attend the debate and submit a report to him on the participants, audience, arguments offered by the debaters, and the prizes. You can include any other aspect you think is important.

For the attention of Mr Bhardwaj, Principal

A REPORT ON THE OPEN DEBATE ORGANIZED BY THE ROTARY CLUB OF LUCKNOW

1. **Introduction**
   The report is designed to give an overall picture of an open debate on the government's reservation policy which was organized by the Rotary Club of Lucknow on 1 June 2001 at the Institution of Engineers.
2. **Procedure**
   The debate at the Institution of Engineers held on 1 June 2001 was audited and detailed notes made of the speakers' ideas and arguments. The information in this report is based on these notes and the observations of the jury.
3. **Findings**
   (a) Debate
      i. All the speakers for the motion based their arguments on the plea of social justice and equality. No fresh argument was given.
      ii. The speakers against the motion criticized the reservation policy on the grounds of discrimination and efficiency. Some of them also pointed out that the policy was politically motivated and was against national interest.
   (b) Audience and speakers
   More than 200 Rotarians were present in the hall. Some special invitees, mainly educationists, and press correspondents were also present. In all twenty students from local English medium colleges

participated in the debate. City Montessory College and Spring Dale College sent eight students each to represent them. Two girls came from Christ Church College and one each from Model School and Seventh Day College.

(c) Results
The shield went to Spring Dale College. Nikita of Class VII and Vartika of class XI were adjudged the best and the third best debaters. Alok of CMS won the second prize. There was some disagreement between the jury and the speakers of Christ Church College. But the judgement of the jury was upheld by a special jury.

(d) Other observations
Most of the speakers offered their arguments with great conviction and presented them very effectively. Their language was clear and accent very good. Some boys read out their speeches.

4. **Conclusions**
The overall performance of the speakers was satisfactory. The debate generated a lot of enthusiasm both among the speakers and the audience and the discussion continued long after it was declared closed.

Chikki Dwivedi
BA I
Navyug Degree College,
6 June 2001

Demonstration Exercise 2

As a committee member of the State Tourist Bureau you have been a guest, for two weeks, at a newly inaugurated luxury hotel. You are required by your department to put in a report on the hotel and the facilities it offers. Given below are some important points you are to bear in mind while writing your report.

Location of the hotel, surroundings, rate, number of staff, number of rooms/suits, how the rooms/suites are equipped and furnished, comment on room service, courtesy of staff/kitchen, cleanliness, variety of meals, quality, facilities, swimming pool, billiards room, lawn or garden, how they are maintained—other features worth mentioning.

Write a report of about 450 words in the form of a short formal report.

For the attention of the Director, Tourist Bureau, UP

A REPORT ON THE GENERAL FUNCTIONING AND FACILITIES OF HOTEL NATRAJ

1. **Introduction**
   This report is designed to give an overall picture of the building, facilities and service of Hotel Natraj, a five star hotel which was inaugurated on the 15th of December, last year.

2. **Procedure**
The three member Tourist Bureau Inspection Committee stayed in the hotel from 2nd March to 17th March. During this time a detailed study of the facilities offered and the services provided to guests and visitors and also of its surroundings was made. The information which is submitted in this report is based on the observation of the members together with knowledge drawn from other guests.
3. **Findings**
   i. Building
   The hotel is situated on an area of about 40,000 square feet on the eastern bank of the river Gomati. In front of the hotel is a huge park, well maintained by the corporation. It is centrally located.
   Hotel Natraj is a 15-storey building with 150 single bedrooms, 75 double bedrooms and 15 VIP suites. The entire complex is fully air-conditioned. The rooms are spacious and gorgeously furnished with the most modern luxury gadgets. There are five lifts running day and night. Every floor has an elegantly furnished lounge and a recreation room with facility for indoor games and a snack-bar.
   ii. Range of services
   Besides board and lodging facilities, the hotel also has arrangements for exchanging money through a nationalized bank on the second floor of the building. In its basement, it has a very modern and fashionable shopping complex. The Air India Office looks after the air-travel needs of the visitors. It is open from 8 a.m. to 8 p.m. The swimming pool and the billiards room are open to non-visitors as well. A five line telephone exchange works round the clock. The bar too is open throughout. Annexed to the hotel is a cafeteria for guests and local visitors. It provides meals and snacks from morning till late in the night. It also has a snackbar serving tea, coffee, cold drinks, ice-creams, sandwiches, biscuits and sweets and is open 24 hours a day.
   iii. Staff
   On the whole, the staff are cooperative, friendly and helpful, particularly in the reception and the service sections
   iv. Cleanliness
   Every part of the building is well kept and maintained; not a fly or dust particle is noticed. Vases with real roses decorate every corner and staircase of the building.
   v. Cost
   Considering the luxury facilities and services offered by the hotel, the rates both for lodgers and causal visitors are moderate.
4. **Conclusion**
The overall picture is one of a majestic hotel in a cosmopolitan city. It provides a range of services for the benefit of its patrons. The general appearance is that of a modern, very clean and well maintained luxury hotel and the facilities are adequate to cope with the needs of the visitors at all hours.

19 March 2001
R.K. Kaushik
Member Secretary
State Tourist Bureau Committee

C. Newspaper Reprot

Newspaper reports do not have a formalized structure. The facts of the event are stated in paragraphs. The events selected for newspaper reports are of general interest. Some of these can, however, be for a particular class, for examples, sports events, music, literary functions, etc.

While writing a newspaper report one should follow the guidelines given below:

1. Give a sensational and catchy heading. It should highlight the most significant event.
2. Begin the introductory paragraph with the place and the date of the occurrence. Explain the sensational news of the heading in grammatical sentences.
3. Sate the whole event in a logical sequence in the subsequent paragraph. Describe details in independent paragraphs.
4. Conclude the report describing the situation as it exists or existed at the time of the report.

Based on the guidelines given above, we present five model reports for greater clarity and emphasis.

I. Report on an accident

ONE KILLED, TWO HURT

LUCKNOW, March 31– One person was killed and two others hurt when a Rajdoot motorcycle, DHQ 7207, bumped against a three-wheeler in front of the Economic Store on Latouche Road yesterday.

An eye-witness said that around 3 o'clock in the afternoon a motorcyclist from Hewett Road drove fast across to the left side of Latouche Road with the intention of getting ahead of a three-wheeler coming from Charbagh. The three-wheeler struck the motorbike so violently that the rider hit his head against an electric pole a few yards away. The three-wheeler turned turtle; its windscreen was broken to pieces. The steering-wheel jolted the driver's chest.

Dr Chakravarty of the Economic Stores examined the motorcyclist. He was bleeding from his ears and nose and was immediately rushed to hospital where he was declared dead. His body has been sent for post-mortem.

The driver of the three-wheeler was also attended to by Dr Chakravarty. He had received a severe shock on the ribs and was referred to an orthopaedic surgeon.

Another man sitting beside the driver was pushed out before the vehicle turned turtle. He received minor bruises, and disappeared in the crowd. The other five passengers crying underneath the three-wheeler were taken out. None of them had received any noticeable injury.

The police has taken the motorcycle in its custody and is trying to find out the identity of the deceased.

II. A report on a tennis match

SPORTS COLLEGE ESTABLISHES SUPREMACY

LUCKNOW, March 28, 2001 – Jaipal of Sports College, Lucknow, outplayed Lucknow Christian College champion Mahmood in a well contested lawn tennis match at the K.D. Singh Babu Stadium here last evening.

Jaipal's 6-4, 6-3, 6-2 triumph over Mahmood was glorious. He remained aggressive throughout. During the two hour and thirty minute game he showed remarkable deftness and confidence.

Mahmood was no less marvellous and played some very powerful shots and serves but Jaipal's confidence grew with each shot he was getting in. Mahmood began the match serving very well and began troubling the Sports College competitor on his serve in the second game. He took him to deuce but Jaipal with an ace took the advantage and with a serve and volley broke Mahmood's serve to win the set.

Jaipal was becoming more and more confident. He won the next set with his deadly serves. But the last set was keenly contested and lasted for seventy minutes. The break came in the fourth game as Jaipal gave away several negative points and double faults to surrender his serve. However, young Jaipal regained his concentration and confidence in the fifth game. He jumped to 30-40 after Mahmood's lob went wide and then his calculated serve made it a deuce. With a powerful volley Mahmood got the advantage but Jaipal spoilt it with the shot of the day, a cross court shot that went like a bullet. With two consecutive wins he won the fifth game too. The last game was a cake walk. He got it with straight serves.

The hundred and fifty minute match ended with a trophy to the Sports College.

III. A Report on the Annual Function of a College

SPRING DALE CELEBRATES ANNUAL FUNCTION WITH GAIETY

LUCKNOW, June 7, 2001 – Spring Dale College, Indira Nagar, yesterday

celebrated its Annual Function in the College Auditorium with enthusiasm and gaiety.

The whole college wore a festive look with colourful buntings and balloons.

The noise suddenly subsides. The glittering procession lead by the Director, Mrs Sood, and followed by the chief guest, the college principal and senior lecturers moved on to the carpeted dais sharp at 2 o'clock. The function began with the national anthem.

In her two-minute address, Mrs Sood welcomed the chief guest and the audience, and thanked the parents for their cooperation and urged them to continue their support in the future.

Mr A.K. Misra read out a report on the academic and extra-curricular achievements of the college. He particularly mentioned the name of Ashish Goel who scored 93 per cent marks in the ISC examination. There was a loud applause when he announced that the Spring Dale College had granted him a special scholarship for pursuing his studies in any university in the country.

Mr Misra also read out the names of other students who received the first three ranks in their respective classes. They were given medals and merit certificates by the chief guest. Many other students, on this occasion, received ovations for their excellent performance in games, art and debates.

Mr H.K. Awasthy, the Vice-Chancellor of the Lucknow University and the chief guest, in his address praised the academic excellence of the boys and girls and exhorted them to cultivate such habits as would always help them improve their own academic and moral standards and also help them build a healthy and strong nation.

The chief guest's speech was followed by a cultural programme presented by the college students and teachers. The most fascinating part of the event was the fancy show. The boys and girls paraded in the masks of animals, giants and gods. The performance given by Gaurav of class three who played the role of Shakuni in the Mahabharat was highly appreciated.

The recital of a folk-song by the class XI girls, *qawaali* by the class of XI and XII science students, a *bhajan* by a six year old girl were some of the fascinating events of the function.

Significantly, the whole function went on gracefully except for a few minutes when some old boys tried to force their entry. But Mr Misra soon brought the situation under control.

The function was attended by a large gathering of distinguished men and women from the town.

The Head Mistress, Mrs Khanna, proposed a vote of thanks and the function ended with the national anthem.

IV. Report on the break-out of a fire

SLUM-DWELLERS RENDERED HOMELESS

LUCKNOW, March 30 – A huge fire broke out near Mahanagar Police Station last evening and rendered about 75 men, women and children living in the 25 hutments near Kukrail bridge on the Faizabad road homeless.

Around 7 in the evening, a thick cloud of smoke was noticed rising form a scrap-dealer's godown on the Faizabad road near Kukrail bridge. Soon some residents rushed with their buckets to extinguish the fire. But the very first bucket of water sent the blue flames high into the sky. The fire became furious and in no time the nearby hutments caught fire. Cracker-like bursts were heard for over 30 minutes. When the fire tenders reached the spot there was nothing left to do.

No human life was reported to be lost. Some women and children sustained minor burn injuries. They were taken to Balrampur hospital where they were given first aid and released. However, nearly a dozen caged birds in different hutments were reduced to ash-balls. Belongings worth over one lakh rupees have been destroyed.

The social welfare minister visited the scene of fire late last night and announced a rehabilitation grant of Rs 5,000 to each hutment owner.

The scrap dealer has been arrested and a police enquiry ordered to look into the causes of this fire.

V. Report on a Street Fight

THREE INJURED IN A STREET FIGHT

LUCKNOW, March 31, 2001 – Two rival gangs clashed near Arya Kanya Pathshala in New Hyderabad at about 1.30 p.m. yesterday. Three persons sustained injuries. The condition of one of them is reported to be critical.

Suresh Yadava of Paper Mill Colony was escorting a college girl when some boys standing near a pan-shop passed some rude remarks. Yadava whisked his knife and attacked Ragghu. His followers too jumped into the fray. Soon soda bottles, hockey sticks and iron rods were exchanged. Three boys fell down bleeding, one of them profusely. A crowd of girls ran helter-skelter. Shutters were immediately downed, panic gripped the locality. The police on duty at Arya Kanya Pathshala, however, rushed immediately to the spot but not before some blood had been spilt.

The injured were taken to Balrampur hospital where two were released after first aid but the condition of Bhondu is stated to be critical.

Suresh Yadav and Munna, the leaders of the two rival groups managed to escape and are absconding. The police has registered a case against them and is frantically searching for them.

D. Practice Exercises

1. You were appointed observer for the elections of a local college students' union. The elections had to be cancelled in the middle of voting. Write a brief report for your organization. You can use some of the following points:
   Violence and group clashes led to cancellation; Police arrangement inadequate; Returning Officer and Proctorial Board negligent; entry not well regulated; no arrangement for proper exit; crowding in the booths; voting trend; group clashes, police silent observer; Returning Officer manhandled; elections cancelled; mild *lathi* charge, campus vacated, enquiry set up.
2. A senior bureaucrat's wife gold chain and purse have been stolen. Prepare a report for the press. You can use some of the following points. Bureaucrat's wife gold chain and purse stolen; resistance offered; circumstances that forced her to surrender her belongings; contents in the purse; action taken by police; clues provided by the victim and eye-witnesses.
3. While putting out a fire at your college you have been involved in an accident in which three students (including yourself) fell down the stairs while carrying buckets of sand from the courtyard. You were taken to hospital but discharged after first aid for a fractured thumb. Invent any other necessary details, including how the building caught fire and how the three of you fell down. Write a report for the college principal.
4. You have been asked to submit your report on the malfunctioning of the college library. Report on the staff, maintenance and upkeep, cleanliness, issue and return of books, quality of books, reading room facility, newspapers, magazines, journals, etc.
5. You have spent the whole day observing the atmosphere in the university. Write a report for your magazine pointing out the involvement of students in academic activities, attendance in class rooms, attendance in library reading room, scenes at the offices of the Vice-Chancellor, Registrar, Deans, Proctor, Cashier, Canteen, etc.

25

COMMON ERRORS

The aim of this chapter is to concentrate on and correct the most frequent grammatical mistakes made by students of English. It further attempts to introduce students to knowledge of grammar that would enable them to face competitive examinations or other English language tests like GRE, TOEFL, etc. A common grammatical error is one that is made frequently by learners. We have concentrated only on some areas of English grammar because these areas in spite of being taught and learnt pose difficulty for the average student. The problems in these areas can be diluted by systematic and simple presentation.

Common Errors in the Use of Nouns

Incorrect	Correct
He gave me a ten-rupees note.	He gave me a Ten-rupee note.
He gave me some advices.	He gave me some advice.
Where have you left your luggages?	Where have you left your luggage?

(Words like luggage, advice, etc., though they look singular are always used as plural)

Yesterday they gave us fishes for dinner.	Yesterday they gave us fish for dinner.
I lost my spectacle.	I lost my spectacles.
Please lend me your scissor.	Please lend me your scissors.

(Nouns like spectacles, scissors, etc., are usually not used in the singular)

I like tight-fitting cloth.	I like tight-fitting clothes.
There was much hot last summer.	There was much heat last summer.
When will you go to your house?	When will you go home?
Politics are very popular those days.	Politics is very popular these days.

Common Errors in the Use of Pronouns

Incorrect	Correct
This is the only that I like.	This is the only one that I like.

I insisted on him coming to my place.	I insisted on his coming to my place.
I received your's letter yesterday.	I received your letter yesterday.
They enjoyed here.	They enjoyed themselves here.
I remember all what he said.	I remember all that he said.
May I know who is he.	May I know who he is.
This is torn, please give me.	This is torn, please give me
one other notebook.	another notebook.
One should work hard, if he wants to pass the examination.	One should work, hard, if one wants to pass the examination.

Common Errors in the Use of Verbs

Incorrect	Correct
Shall I come in?	May I come in?
The ship was drowned.	The ship was sunk.
Do not see outside the window.	Do not look outside the window.
Would you want to go on a picnic?	Would you like to go on a picnic?
Can you make this problem?	Can you do this problem?
What is the promise he has done?	What is the promise he has made?
Will you say me a story?	Will you tell me a story?
My teacher always puts on dark glasses.	My teacher always wears dark glasses.
Furniture is nowadays made from steel.	Furniture is nowadays made of steel.
Did you went to the cinema last night?	Did you go to the cinema last night?
Women are generally fond to talk.	Women are generally fond of talking.
He has now left smoking.	He has now given up smoking.
He went to the doctor so that he may recover soon.	He went to the doctor so that he might recover soon.
My father rose at four in the morning.	My father used to rise at four in the morning.
He was bathing every day.	He bathed everyday.
Make haste lest you might miss the train.	Make haste lest you should miss the train.
I asked him what is the matter.	I asked him what the matter was.
See this word in the Dictionary.	Look up this word in the dictionary.
The teacher took the test of the boys.	The teacher gave the boys a test.

Common Errors in the Use of Preposition

Incorrect	Correct
Boys come at school every morning.	Boys come to school every morning.
The dog rushed in the room.	The dog rushed into the room.
I bought this book at three rupees.	I bought this book for three rupees.
Every boy should learn English beside the mother tongue.	Every boy should learn English besides the mother tongue.
They have been playing cricket since 10 this morning till now.	They have been playing cricket from 10 this morning till now.
I will leave from Calcutta tomorrow.	I will leave Calcutta tomorrow.
He resembles to his mother.	He resembles his mother.
The police accused Mohan Singh for stealing.	The police accused Mohan Singh of stealing.
He was charged of murder in the court.	He was charged with murder in the court.
Do not shout against me.	Do not shout at me.
My sister was married with a captain in the army.	My sister was married to a captain in the army.
The teacher is sitting on a chair.	The teacher is sitting in a chair.
Let us sit down under the shade of that tree.	Let us sit down in the shade of that tree.
Sign on this paper.	Sign this paper.
You should agree to me with my proposal.	You should agree with me to my proposal.

Common Errors in the Use of Articles

Articles behave like adjectives. They tell us something about the noun that follows them.

There are two articles in English.

1. The indefinite article: **a/an**
2. The definite article: **the**

The indefinite article occurs before those nouns that are:

- Countable, i.e. they can be counted
- Singular in number, i.e. they refer to a single object

The definite article **the** makes the noun before which it is used particular. It can be used with countable, as well as non-countable nouns (singular as well as plural).

Incorrect	Correct
I am not student.	I am not a student.
I told the boys not to make noise.	I told the boys not to make a noise.
On Saturday he goes to cinema.	On Saturday he goes to the cinema.
The air is essential for life.	Air is essential for life.
He died of the plague.	He died of plague.
An European likes to travel much.	A European likes to travel much.
It is quarter to five by the school clock.	It is a quarter to five by the school clock.
Himalayas stand to the north of India.	The Himalayas stand to the north of India.

Common Errors in the Use of Conjunctions

Incorrect	Correct
Although the train was late but he could not catch it.	Although the train was late, he could not catch it.
Unless you do not work hard you will not pass.	Unless you work hard, you will not pass.
The poor man did nothing else than weep.	The poor man did nothing else but weep.
I require one thousand thirty-two rupees.	I require one thousand and thirty-two rupees.
Though it is very cold outside, still I will go.	Though it is very cold outside, I will go.
I had hardly reached the school then it began to rain.	I had hardly reached the school when it began to rain.
I will not go until you do not come back.	I will not go until you come back.

Common Errors in the Use of Adverbs

Incorrect	Correct
He works hardly but without success.	He works hard but without success.
Last night I went to bed lately.	Last night I went to bed late.
It is very cold to come out.	It is too cold to come out.
He is very weaker than my brother.	He is much weaker than my brother.
I met him before two days.	I met him two days ago.

The child is learning to talk by and by.	The child is learning to talk gradually.
He is enough wise to face the situation.	He is wise enough to face the situation.
He writes carefully his notes.	He writes his notes carefully.

Common Errors in the Use of Adjectives

Incorrect	Correct
He is stronger than anybody.	He is stronger than anybody else.
He is not interesting in his work.	He is not interested in his work.
I reached the station latter than he.	I reached the station later than he.
Chandigarh is further than Shimla from here.	Chandigarh is farther than Shimla from here.
I have many advice for you.	I have some advice for you.
Nepoleon was a big man.	Nepoleon was a great man.
Tulsidas was greater than all the Indian poets.	Tulsidas was greater than any other Indian poet.
This boy is more good than that.	This boy is better than that.

Exercises

I. Correct the errors in the following sentences.

1. I who is your friend will do my best to help you.
2. Do it carefully lest you may not make a mistake.
3. I live in Delhi since January 1975.
4. I ordered for a cup of tea.
5. He sat under the shade of a Tree.
6. In the case if it rains, please stay indoor.
7. He asked me which books did I like most.
8. He is used to tell lies.
9. I gave him a few books I had.
10. Please tell me what do you want.
11. All this discussion is beside the point.
12. Have you to go home now?
13. The last bus is gone we'll have to go by foot.
14. It has been raining since four hours.
15. The population of China is greater than India.
16. He sold all the furniture's before leaving.
17. We are looking forward to hear from you.
18. My income now is much higher than last year.
19. Being a very hot day, She stayed indoors.
20. One should help poors.
21. In my opinion I think it is right.
22. I have received your letter yesterday.

23. If I will met him today. I shall give him the letter.
24. We must go and congratulate him for his brilliant success.
25. This question has given me lot of trouble.
26. I am in great hurry.
27. The manager has sent this a month ago.
28. He discussed about politics with me.
29. I cannot be able to come.
30. Neither the destruction nor the creation of matter are possible.
31. The observation of this custom is characteristic of that tribe.
32. The president gave his ascent to the bill.
33. The team of players were then not in the town.
34. She is far superior than her husband.
35. It is raining for a week.
36. Where you bought your new shirt?
37. Neither he nor his sister were there.
38. I sat under the feet of many teachers.
39. The doctor saw my pulse.
40. I always have and shall be your friend.
41. She told to me the whole truth.
42. I have sent him a telegram only a week ago.
43. The teacher asked us to please attend to him.
44. Ravi and Vinod both play well, but Ravi is the best.
45. He asked me what do I like?
46. Each of them brought their own food to the picnic.
47. You are not understanding my difficulties.
48. He is taller than me.
49. This book is too interesting.
50. The boy who stands first he will get a prize.

26

RIGHT TO INFORMATION ACT

Pre-reading exercises

1. It is believed that India is a very corrupt country. Have you had any personal experience when you have been asked for a bribe? Tell the class about it.
2. Do you think that government officials are more corrupt or do you think that politicians, lawyers, teachers, etc., are more corrupt?
3. Do you think that people who agree to give bribes are as much to blame as people who accept bribes?
4. What, according to you, is the best way to deal with corruption?

The Right to Information Act

We all pay taxes, for every single facility that we use – water, electricity, roads, etc. So, have you ever wondered what you can do to improve the condition of roads around your locality or to ensure that the taps are not always dry, or to find out where the money you pay as taxes to the government actually goes, or whether the government meant to serve your interests is actually functioning. You can begin by asking questions about the potholed road in your colony or the overflowing garbage dump or the foul-smelling water in your tap. The Right to Information Act empowers you to do so. It is the citizens' weapon, which enables them to fight corruption, bureaucratic delays and take the authorities concerned to task.

The Right to Information Act 2005 makes it necessary that government officials respond within a fixed time to citizens' requests for government information. As part of the fundamental rights of the people under Article 19(1) of the Constitution, the Central Right to Information Act came into force on 12 October 2005. The Act lays down the process on how to apply for information, where to apply, thus empowering every citizen to –

- Ask any question from the government or seek any information
- Inspect government works, documents, and records
- Take notes, extracts or certified copies of government documents or records
- Take certified samples of material of any government work

Excluding the State of Jammu and Kashmir, the Central RTI Act extends to the whole of India. All government bodies (including non-governmental organisations or NGOs), constituted under the Constitution of India or under any law, and owned, controlled or substantially financed by the Government, are covered under this Act. India is a democracy and therefore every citizen has the right to know how the governments meant to serve him or her are functioning. The RTI is an effective shield against corruption and inefficiency and is, eventually, in the greater national interest. The RTI gives you the power to initiate necessary action. If you think that an important matter is being neglected, then you can very well incite the authorities concerned into action by asking for a report on the status of the matter.

To give you a clear idea on how to go about applying for information we are reproducing below a part of the Maharashtra Right to Information Ordinance, 2002. This will help you understand the rules and regulations involved while seeking information regarding government records and documents.

Maharashtra Right to Information Ordinance, 2002

EXTRACT

6. *Procedure for seeking information* – (1) Any person desirous of obtaining information as provided under the provisions of the ordinance shall, apply to the concerned Public Information Officer on plain paper in the format given in Annexure 'A' by affixing a court fee stamp of rupees ten.

(2) The Public Information Officer on receiving the application under sub-rule (1) shall, subject to the provisions of sections 7 and 8, call and compile the requisite information and shall also assess the amount of fees which will be required to be paid by the applicant as per sub-rule (3).

(3) After the Public Information Officer has compiled the requisite information, he shall send an intimation to the applicant in the format given in Annexure 'B' within a period of fifteen days from the date of receipt of the application informing him the amount of fees payable by him as per the Schedule appended to these rules, for the supply of such information to him by the Public Information officer and the date by which he should make the payment and collect the information. If the information sought for by the applicant cannot be supplied without the assistance of an employee or officer, and such employee or officer fails to supply the required information or to render the assistance within the period specified in sub-section (2) of section 6, then such an employee, or as the case may be, the officer [being the person covered under (7) of section 2 of the Ordinance], shall be liable for penalty under the Ordinance.

The applicant shall pay the requisite fees as informed by the Public Information Officer either by way of money order or by making cash payment in the office of the Public Information Officer concerned or make payment in the Treasury.

The amount of fees received from the applicants by the Public Information Officers shall be deposited in the budget head No. '0070-Administrative Services, 60-Other Services, 800-Other receipts, Right to information ordinance, 2002 (0070-016-1)'.

On receiving of the payment or on receiving the copy of chalan showing payment of fee in treasury, the Public Information Officer shall forthwith supply the information to the applicant either in person or by post.

ANNEXURE-A

[See rule 6(1)]

Affix here Court Fee Stamp of Rs. 10

Format of Application form under the Maharashtra Right of Information Rules, 2002

To

The Public Information Officer,
(Name of the office with address)

(1) Full name of the applicant :

(2) Address :

(3) Particulars of information required :

(i) Subject matter of information* :

(ii) The period to which the information relates.# :

(iii) Description of the information required$:

(iv) Whether information is required by post or in person :

(The actual postal charges shall be included in additional fees).

(v) In case by post (Ordinary, Registered or Speed).

(vi) Purpose for which the information is required.

Place
Date

Signature of the applicant.

* Broad category of the subject to be indicated (such as grant of Government land/ Service matters/Licensee, etc.)

Relevant period for which information is required to be indicated.

$ Specific details of the information is required to be indicated.

ANNEXURE-B

[See rule 6(3)]

From . . .,
Designation of the
Public Information Officer.

To

(Name of the applicant)
Address of the applicant.

Sir,

Please refer to your application dated . . . addressed to the undersigned requesting information on . . . . The above information is ready to be supplied to you. The additional fee for supplying this information to you is Rs. . . . .

You are requested to pay the fee at this Office or send a money order or make paymet in a Government Treasury and send a copy of the *challan* to this office and collect the information.

The amount of fees shall be deposited in the budget head No. '0070-Other Administrative Services, 60-Other Services, 800-Other receipts, (18)–Right to Information Ordinance, 2002 (0070—016—1)'.

Please make the payment on or before . . . .

Public Information Officer.

Questions:

1. Do you remember the scene from the movie *Lage Raho Munna Bhai*, where an aged man starts taking off his clothes when the officer in-charge denies him his pension rights? You may have heard of other such cases as well. Perhaps a grandfather or an old uncle has been denied his pension. In such a situation what would you do as a concerned citizen to help these people?
2. Every morning you see your mother getting up early to fill up the buckets for the day. In spite of repeated complaints there has been no improvement in the water supply. If you wanted to help your

mother how will you fill an RTI? Who are the concerned authorities whom you will approach?

3. The RTI is a victory for Indian democracy and a transparent medium to take appropriate and corrective action. If the government tries to bring about amendments to make this Act ineffective would you join hands with other RTI volunteers to protect this act? Explain how you will gather public support to keep this act effective and powerful.

Now read through the following news report published in the 23 February 2007 issue of the *Hindustan Times:*

Top score but IMM will not take her in

B R Srikanth
Banglore, 23 February

The wait is certainly agonizing for Vaishnavi Kasturi, a visually impaired student, as she knocks on the doors of the Indian Institute of Management, Bangalore to know why she was not admitted in the IIM despite her excellent performance in CAT 2006.

On Friday, Vaishnavi's father R K Kasturi spent several hours closeted with a team of officials from IIM-B, asking them why his daughter was not called for a group discussion and personal interview. Vaishnavi cleared the CAT with a percentile of 89.29, outdoing thousands of other candidates. She was certainly eligible to sit for the next round of tests – the group discussion and interview – what with the IIM-B setting a cut-off of 86.42 percentile for the disabled. But the call never came.

Disappointed, Vaishnavi's family filed a notice under the Right to Information Act, which got Kasturi the meeting with the school authorities.

At the end of the discussion, Kasturi still did not have an answer of his daughter. He told the *Hindustan Times:* 'They told us that she did not make it because others in the category of applicants with physical disabilities) were graduates or had work experience, etc. We had a long meeting and discussed many things because we want to understand where we stand. Let us wait till Monday (26 February). We have to attend a hearing at the RTI Commissioner's office that day. The group discussions and interviews are scheduled for April. Let us see what happens on Monday.'

For Vaishnavi – a sixth semester B.Com student of local college – the doors to IIM-B may not have opened but the prestigious M.S. Ramaiah Institute of Management, has offered her a free seat for a postgraduate diploma in management.

Vaishnavi, however, still hopes she will qualify for the Indian Institute of Management-Bangalore at the end of the hearing at the RTI Commissioner's office in the state capital on Monday.

(a) Indian Institutes of Management have all along maintained that merit alone should be the criteria for gaining admission. Do you think students who have done well in the entrance examinations be denied admission just because they have physical disabilities? Do you think that Vaishnavi will get justice from the RTI Commissioner?

(b) Imagine a situation wherein the municipal corporation, for several months has taken no steps to replace missing manhole covers in your neighbourhood. Last week your friend fell into an open manhole and hurt herself grievously. Study carefully the extract from the Maharashtra Right to Information Ordinance 2002 and help the parents of you friend to write out an application to the Public Information Officer seeking information about what action the local municipal corporation has taken to replace the manhole covers which have been missing for so many months.